Double Trouble and the Orb of Entropy

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31396829.

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Mature

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F, F/M, M/M, Multi

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Character:
Double Trouble (She-Ra)

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Double Trouble and the Orb of Entropy

by Largemovingtorb

Summary

This takes place not long AFTER the events of my other fanfic, She-Ra: Masters of the Universe, and DURING the first part of She-Ra: The Lost, Book1.

Feeling themselves growing too "soft" and having too many "attachments," Double Trouble flees Etheria to make a new life for themselves. Their journey takes them to the city-wide planet of Thenlor— recently freed from the clutches of the Shen'Aan-war. There, they attempt to fall back into their old villainous ways— but the past still haunts them…

Much like my fanfic, She-Ra: Masters of the Universe, I have embedded music into this fanfic, the idea being that it is like a movie soundtrack. Embedded music links will have a title in BOLD with * to either side. Click them, and you will be transported to Soundcloud or YouTube. It is not required you listen to them, but I feel they add a certain mood you can hang on to while reading the prose.

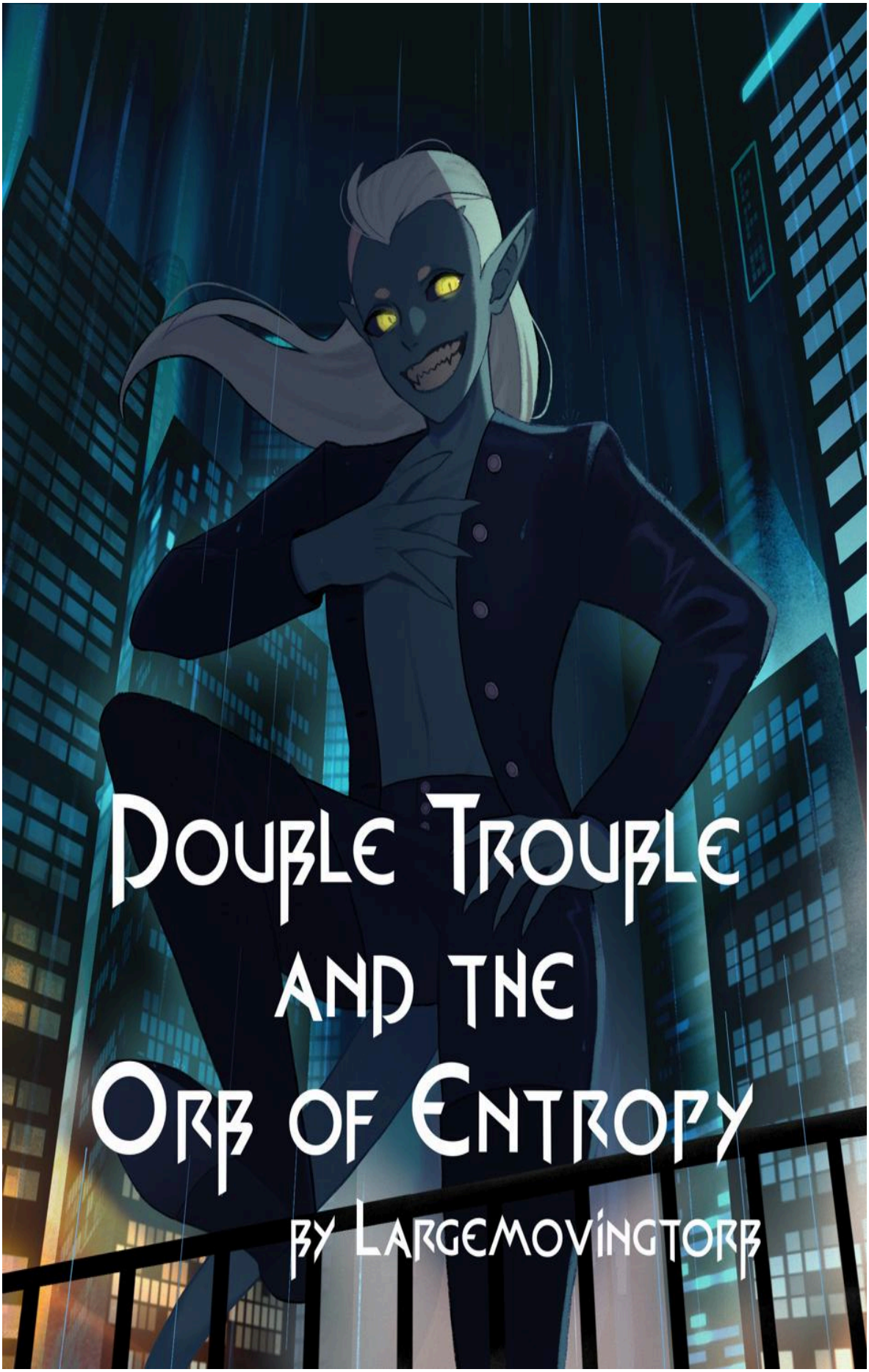
This fic will be updated every MONDAY.

Their New Them

Chapter Summary

Having fled Etheria and looking to re-invent themselves, Double Trouble arrives on the planet of Thenlor, a world whose surface is covered by endless buildings.

Flit, a homeless girl, finds hope in the form of a kind stranger.


Double Trouble
and the
Orb of Entropy
by Largemovingtorb

* **OPENING CREDITS** *

From space, the planet Thenlor was very unappealing to look upon; permanent rainstorms covered the entire surface, giving it the appearance of a sickly gray-green orb. Dim lights of the planet-wide city were barely discernable through the dense clouds, the hazy orange or yellow glow adding to the planet's sinister aspect.

For many newcomers, it seemed grungy and dirty, not a place that elicited any hope or happiness—but not everyone found it so.

Thenlor's latest visitor gazed upon the planet from their space transport's viewport with gleaming yellow and green-slitted eyes, regarding their final destination hungrily. They had come a long way to get here, lured by the promise of new opportunities and riches. Besides the materialistic aspect of visiting Thenlor, there was also the wealth of culture and art that such a large population of mixed-species could offer, something they treasured greatly.

Lastly, there was the chance to spread chaos and mischief—activities that were intrinsic to their Impish nature. They had been this way for so long now that they could not remember being any different—*well*—long ago they had not been so *Impish*, they had been…

Yes, Thenlor had much to offer them, that was evident. They were adept at looking past the outer shell to the true nature of something or someone—abilities that came with being an acolyte of chaos.

* **THE IMP'S ARRIVAL** *

The view from space was suddenly obscured by clouds as the space transport entered the atmosphere, the viewports becoming streaked with raindrops as the ship bobbed up and down through

a bout of turbulence—passing through the dense cloud layer to the underside—the cityscape below was soon revealed.

Tall rectangular buildings as far as the eye could see—packed together in a crowded conurbation of concrete and steel. Nestled amongst these smaller buildings were larger ones—much larger—scattered like dark, grim titans amongst ants. A deep canyon of an avenue ran laterally into the horizon—there—huge industrial stacks could be spotted, mighty gouts of flames and smoke spewing forth from the tops.

As the ship drew closer, the newcomer could discern other vessels and speeders zipping in multiple directions over and amongst the buildings. In the midst of these agile speeders floated vast blimps, giant viewscreens hanging from their bulbous sides displaying various images and advertisements in bright strobing lights.

The whole scene was overwhelming, oppressive, and hard; the visitor momentarily felt a longing for their origin point, wrapping their long green tail around themselves.

"Well, my dear, looks like you're definitely not on Etheria anymore," the Imp whispered to themselves.

They suppressed the pang of homesickness; that was the whole reason for this journey, right? They were getting too soft back on Etheria, too attached, too vulnerable. But that was the way of Etheria, wasn't it? It nurtured attachments and softness. Considering the planet below, they saw a place that did not nurture vulnerability or weakness. It was perfect for the *new* them.

"First time on Thenlor?" a male voice asked behind them.

The Imp turned to notice a short, squat being with pink skin—a male of his species. His face was pock-marked and jowly with a pug nose and small, almost indiscernible ears. Dressed in business attire complete with top hat, he gazed at them curiously with beady little black eyes.

Ugh, someone wants to chit-chat, they thought in annoyance as they put on their 'mask'—a winning smile and bright attitude.

"Oh no, my dear, I have businesses on multiple planets. I swing by Thenlor once in a while for an unannounced visit. I like to keep my employees on their toes," the Imp said offhandedly. This was, of course, a lie. They had sold the only business they owned to acquire universal currency—gems and precious metals—which they carried in their satchel, amongst other possessions.

"I'm a businessperson myself! More of a consultant, actually. I specialize in helping businesses deep dive into their most important KPIs to achieve the best synergy!" he exclaimed.

Eww, they thought—then to him, "Oh, *marvelous, darling*, good for you!" The Imp said, patting him on the shoulder and turning back around to the viewport. He puffed up and beamed back at them with self-importance.

By then, the transport had arrived at the star port—a large platform sitting over what appeared to be a hundred city blocks. The spacecraft landed amongst a crowd of other arriving transports, immediately beginning the disembarkation process—the transport attendants scurried amongst the passengers, helping them leave as quickly as possible. After all, time was money on Thenlor, and so was landing space. The transport needed to depart as soon as possible to make room for others.

The new arrival walked off the transport and gazed around, taking in the views. Rain was coming down lightly, wetting their blond hair, but they were unconcerned by it. Being wet never bothered them for they did not need to worry about damp garments. When you didn't actually wear clothes, there was nothing to get wet.

Feeling a presence approaching from behind, the Imp inwardly groaned. Turning, they saw the short man from earlier walking towards them, intent on some more pointless conversation. He now had some form of portable cloth canopy on a pole over himself, which he attempted to share by stretching his arm up

higher. It was pointless, for they were much taller than his stubby legs and short arms could manage, and the canopy only reached their nose. They could not help being touched by the sentiment, though.

“You’d think a return visitor to Thenlor would bring an umbrella! All it does is rain here—you’re going to catch your death out in this!” he said cheerfully.

The Imp smiled falsely. “My people come from a cold, wet planet like this. It’s just like being home, honey. Don’t you fret about me!” They lied. They had no people.

The short being removed his top hat to reveal a head topped with short yellow fuzz and bowed. He stood back up, holding out a hand in greeting.

“The name is Borpt. How might I address you?” he asked, hopefully.

The Imp grinned, now without any falsehood. “The name is Double Trouble.” They said, shaking his hand limply. “Charmed, I’m sure.”

* * *

Flit ran down the rainy alleyway, desperate to escape the pursuers stomping and cursing in her wake. Looking furtively behind her, she counted five of them—all sporting the distinctive crimson markings of the Carmine Skinners. Flit silently cursed herself for scavenging outside her normal territory—the Carmine Skinners were known as vicious reavers, constantly living up to an extremely bloodthirsty reputation.

“Why do you run, sweetheart?” one of them called sweetly. “We just want to get to know you better,”

“Yeah, we always like to meet new people—then eat them!” said another.

Yeah, I think I'll pass, Flit thought as she leaped over a wall and into a pile of stinky trash.

"Awww… I just managed to get these rags clean!" She moaned, pulling a gooey wrapper from her thick, fuzzy tail. "Gross!"

One of the pursuers had made it to the top of the wall and spotted her, grinning hungrily.

"Ah, you managed to find some nice seasoning! Yum!" she said viciously.

"Here's your seasoning!" Flit responded, flinging a half-full can of food at the grimy woman. It hit her squarely in her nose, eliciting a yelp as she fell back onto her companions.

"You'll pay for that, you little RAT!" The stricken woman screamed back over the wall.

"Add it to my tab, *you scum*!" Flit screamed back as she turned to run.

Before she continued her escape down the alley, Flit hesitated; the pursuit was taking its toll on her. She was so young, so small, not yet have the grit and stamina her pursuers had. Flit was tired and could barely catch her breath—they were eventually going to catch her—and she was becoming desperate.

The little girl saw it then—a fixed ladder leading up a nearby building to a ledge. Hopefully, it led to a better means of escape… or it could lead nowhere, and she would be dead.

Hearing a thump from behind, Flit turned; two of the Carmine Skinners had made it over the wall and were heading her way, ravenous hunger on both their faces. With a squeak of fear, Flit scrambled up the ladder, her clawed hands and feet tapping on the metal rungs as she struggled up. They were spaced so far apart for her petite body—climbing them taxed her already diminished supplies of energy.

Reaching the top, Flit moaned, discovering that the ledge only led to another wall and ladder. This ladder was rusty, rattling noisily as she scrambled up it. Flit didn't get far before the rung disintegrated in her hands—falling back with a scream—she hit the ledge below. Hard.

Laying there, dazed and panting, Flit knew she had to move—or they would get her. But the little girl just could not find the energy needed—she was so tired of running, so tired of being hungry and alone, surrounded by an uncaring world. It would just be best if they caught her and ended it all, best for Flit, and seemingly best for them.

At least they'll get a small dinner out of me, she thought miserably, beginning to cry as she curled up into a tight ball, closing her eyes.

It was then the little girl heard it, cries of alarm and the scuffling of fighting. It sounded like her pursuers were engaged in a battle; the pursuit of her was forgotten in their struggle—at least for now. As the exchange continued, less and less noise could be discerned, until only the scampering of feet could be heard—fading away. Then, there was silence.

Picking up a quiet noise on the ledge nearby, Flit tensed, the sound followed by the soft padding of feet approaching. The little girl squeezed her eyes tight, waiting for the end.

"Don't give up so soon, little one," a lyrical female voice said.

Flit felt gentle hands as she was lifted—opening her eyes—found herself staring up at her rescuer who cradled her in the crook of one arm. Two large, yellow-slitted eyes gazed down at her from a beautiful, smiling, orange-furred face. Flit's heart pounded a little harder as she spotted two fangs poking down from the other's upper lips.

"Are you going to eat me?" Flit asked in a small voice.

Her rescuer laughed brightly. “No, little one, I don’t think you would make much of a meal for a hunter like me.” She said, not unkindly.

Inspecting the woman, Flit saw a white oval around the left eye—like a patch. Long cream-colored ears sat on either side of her head—the woman’s brown hair gathered behind her head in a ponytail.

“What is your name, little one?” the woman asked.

“Flit, people just call me Flit,” Flit answered shyly.

“I am Panga.” Her rescuer replied. “Flit, I’m going to need both of my arms to climb. Can you wrap your arms around me and hold on?”

“Um... okay. Where are you taking me, Panga?” Flit said, wrapping her short arms around Panga’s neck. She laid her head against the woman’s shoulder; she smelled nice, a scent Flit couldn’t place. There were no pleasant smells on Thenlor to compare them to.

“I’m taking you somewhere safe, Flit. Everything is going to be okay now.” Panga said before leaping into the air.

* * *

Double Trouble regarded the space with complete incredulity. It was a complete dump—never in all their life had they beheld such a dreary, dreadful environment. The main workroom they currently occupied was dark and cavernous; the walls, ceiling, and floor comprised of poured concrete, complete with cracks and moisture spots from seepage—from what—heavens knew.

They even spotted mold.

Eww! Eww! Ewwww! The Imp thought, cringing inwardly. Outwardly, they lifted their tail high up and close to their body—away from any of the filthy surfaces.

The area was dimly lit, wretched phosphorescent lighting recessed in the ceiling providing the only illumination. An old rusty metal desk and chair sat in the middle of the workroom—as if to accentuate the misery of the place.

Double Trouble felt a longing just like before. *Was this really the place for them? What were they doing?*

"So… how much are you asking for this… *abode*?" They asked, trying to mask their disgust.

"It can be yours for three of those yellow gems, two of the blue, and five ingots of that purple metal you have," Borpt responded happily.

Since their arrival, the Imp could not escape the man—dogging their steps with constant incipient chatter. They were about to change form and run when he mentioned a property he wanted to offload—something they would need if they were going to do business on Thenlor. Double Trouble expressed interest in his offer, telling the diminutive man that they wanted to expand their business operations and were interested in purchasing real estate.

"*Seriously?* For *this* place?" Double Trouble stated, incensed. That was over half their savings, and they would need that for overhead and other expenses.

Borpt acted offended. "Come now. This is a fine space in a place where space is the rarest of commodities. I thought you were experienced in business here on Thenlor?" he asked suspiciously.

Double Trouble took another appraisal of what was being offered. *Well, this place does have a front for 'legal' business and a back for the 'real' business, plus a living space to boot. Ugh, it's so dirty and horrible, though…* They sighed.

"Look, I can see you're a tough businessperson, and I'll make a deal with you. I will cut the buying price in half *if*…" Borpt said, trailing off meaningfully.

"Yes…?" The Imp raised one blond eyebrow.

"…You allow me to take you out to dinner…tonight!" he declared.

Double Trouble's eyes went wide as they tried to maintain their smile—which ended up as a toothy grimace.

Oh… why me? What have I done to deserve this? I'll save so much, but… ugh! they thought miserably.

"I suppose that wouldn't hurt," Double Trouble started slowly as Borpt brightened, "A dinner between *business associates* sounds… pleasant," they finished, Borpt appearing to wilt a little.

"Excellent! I will pick you up tonight. Where is your residence?" he asked as he brightened back up.

"Oh… I have some cleaning to take care of, so you can just swing by here, darling," the Imp said, trying to put some of their old charm back into their voice.

"Excellent! It's a date!" Borpt responded, turning on his heel and exiting quickly before Double Trouble could answer.

They watched the little man leave with hooded eyes and a curl in their lips. *As if!* they thought, sulkily, tail twitching in irritation.

Double Trouble sighed and picked up their satchel, making their way into the back of the main space and up the stairs to the living quarters. It was not an inviting situation; there was a cot, bathroom, and kitchen all in one area lit by more awful yellow phosphorescent lighting that flickered on and off. Plopping down on the cot, Double Trouble placed the satchel next to them. Opening it, they pulled out the only possession they had brought that wasn't some form of currency.

A black, collarless jacket with five silver buttons—it glistened in the yellow light, like bird's feathers.

It used to be Shen's jacket, but now it was theirs. The Imp had taken it from his room during the aftermath of the Shen'Aan-war's attack—when they had decided it was time to leave Etheria. They departed before Shen could find them and give them what they knew would be an apology—they would not give him a chance. Double Trouble was still so angry after he had locked them in that dry storage locker—but more than the anger—there was hurt; he had told them so casually that he was going end his own life as if they didn't… wouldn't… what?

Double Trouble felt a mix of emotions during that time, unpleasant feelings they had not felt in a very, very long time. *Were they in love with Shen?* No… maybe… it had been so long since they had known that particular emotion. They certainly had to admit that they had grown to care for him, much like they had started to care for Catra.

The Imp chuckled to themselves, thinking of Shen and Catra—especially—Shen falling in love with Catra.

Ah… you silly boy… always getting yourself into trouble, they thought mirthfully, wondering what happened with that particular pickle of a situation.

All they knew was that Shen and Catra entered the Whispering Woods separately; Catra came back out on the back of that blue and purple creature carrying an unconscious Shen, then locked him up in Bright Moon.

Obviously, there was some delicious drama behind it all, but at the time Double Trouble wasn't excited about learning of it; they just felt sadness. It was then they decided they had grown too soft, too attached, and it was time to leave.

Thinking about all this made them suddenly go to deeper, older memories—memories of another time when they had decided it was time to leave.

"Atreya! Atreya! Where are you?"

They groan to themselves. "I told you, I don't respond to Atreya, mother! Call me by my proper name!" they shout back.

Their mother opens their bedroom door, exasperation on her green face.

"I refuse to indulge in your ridiculous nonsense, Atreya! Why can't you just be a normal girl who has a proper girl name?"

They meet their mother's vexation with some of their own.

*"I **am** normal mother. I'm just not **your** kind of normal. Please don't bother me unless you are ready to use my name with the proper noun."*

Their mother puts her hand to the bridge of her nose and sighs. "Okay… Atrey… en. What is this I hear from your school? Fighting with the other children? I won't have it!"

Atreyen places their book down and gazes at their mother. "Oh, that? Those idiots just have a hard time understanding my normal, just as you seem to do. It's not my fault they feel the need to fight me over it."

Their mother walks over to their bed where they are currently lying and sits at the edge, placing a tentative hand on their foot.

"Atrey… en, we have talked about this before. You have to get over this 'phase,' or we are going to have to…" she says, dying off at the end.

Atreyen suddenly leaps up, angry now. "What? What are you going to do? That's right. You want to send me away, to get 'fixed.' OVER MY DEAD BODY!" they shriek.

Their mother looks at them imploringly. "This isn't normal—to think of yourself as neither a little girl nor even as a little boy. To not use 'a' or 'u' at the end of your name but 'en,' the neutral noun. How did you end up this way? What did we do wrong?" their mother cries, tears in her eyes.

"I was born this way, mother. I guess the only thing you did wrong was giving birth to me." they reply scornfully as they shove past their mother and out the door.

"Atreya! Get back here! We are not finished!" their mother screams as they run away, tears in their eyes now.

The Imp snapped out of the memory, realizing they were gripping the jacket tightly—twisting it hard. Letting it fall to their lap, they ran their hands over it, trying to discern if they had caused any damage; the amount of strength they were using could break bones. But there was nothing—no marks or tears. It was completely undamaged.

Holding up one clawed finger, Double Trouble extended and sharpened the claw at the end, pressing it against the material.

It held.

They pushed harder until all their considerable strength was behind stabbing through the jacket—but they couldn't even penetrate through the top layer.

"Marvelous*…*" they whispered.

Suddenly confused, Double Trouble wondered why they had been interested in this jacket. They had taken it as a form of spite towards Shen, but their interest in it began before that. When they were together for that short week, they would tease Shen by telling him they would steal it away from him.

But they had not had a need for clothing for many, many years now, and if they wanted to, they could just create an imitation of it on their body. However, there was just something about the jacket that they couldn't quite place their finger on.

Like there was… magic in it?

Yes, that was it. The Imp could sense it now, buried deep in the shimmering black fabric—old magic. They could feel it, for there

was magic in them. It was part of their nature now, since…

But what kind of magic was it? How could they unlock it and make it work for them? The only way to find out was to keep it close. They had an idea.

Double Trouble stood and held the jacket up, inspecting the size. It was a little too small for them for it was Shen's size—but then it wasn't originally Shen's jacket, was it? He got it from that tacky old woman in the forest. She was smaller than Shen; how did it end up fitting him so perfectly?

They put a long, lithe green arm into the sleeve—it suddenly widened and lengthened to accommodate it perfectly. The Imp grinned and put their other arm in, and the jacket increased in size and length to fit their frame.

How Splendid!

Double Trouble proceeded over to their bathroom, inspecting themselves in the dirty old mirror. They had their usual black and green sleeveless bodysuit on.

The jacket is good, but not with this outfit. They thought, placing a finger against their lips. *I've been wanting to make a change anyway.*

They started by removing the bodysuit; they had to start from scratch.

Oh, darling, that looks good, but it just might be too scandalous, even for the big city. The Imp thought, grinning to themselves, wearing just the black jacket.

Gazing at the lustrous black material of the jacket, Double Trouble found themselves liking the way it glinted in the half-light of the room.

The only thing that will match such glamour is equal glamour. They thought, causing the same material to materialize on their

legs as tight-fitting pants.

And the final touch.

In a vertical line, five small, silver buttons took shape where the fly would be if these were actual pants, matching the bigger versions on the jacket. On their feet appeared tight-fitting, knee-high glossy black boots with high heels. The Imp turned, lifting one foot backward in a luxurious pose.

"Oh, honeyyy…*!*" they exclaimed, bending slightly and running their hands over their backside, admiring how the material accentuated their appealing look.

Turning back around, Double Trouble now had to decide on what to wear under the jacket. They tried a buttoned-up dress shirt complete with a high collar, switching between various colors.

Nope.

They changed to just a collarless shirt, switching between styles—adding various glitter and shiny gems.

Ugh, not working.

Then they tried just a shirt similar to the black glossy material of the jacket and pants.

Sometimes there really is too much of a good thing. The Imp thought to themselves, taking off the shirt and revealing bare green skin.

Double Trouble examined their exposed midriff and revealed section of upper chest, grinning in delight. There was something very alluring about the presentation of bare skin amongst all that black, shiny material.

No shirt needed, they decided.

With one decision made, they began to inspect their hair, turning their head this way and that.

"Hmmm…" The Imp stated thoughtfully. *The style doesn't have to go, perhaps the color?* They thought. Their eyes scanned their current outfit, searching for inspiration—then stopped to fixate on a single aspect of it.

The buttons.

Double Trouble changed their hair from blond to pure silver—the metallic sheen gleaming in the weak light of the room. They took themselves in fully—as opposed to the blond, the silver was cold—which satisfied them greatly. They now had the countenance of someone who had no attachments—a person who did not care about anyone or anything. Someone who belonged on this cold, city-wide planet of Thenlor. This would be their new appearance.

Their new *them*.

A Sketchy Business Proposition

Chapter Summary

> Not long after arriving on Thenlor, Double Trouble finds themself in over their head.
>
> Meanwhile, little Flit finds that her situation has changed dramatically. But is it good or bad?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Borpt picked up Double Trouble just as planned, and after gawking at their new appearance, whisked them away in his sleek and elegant speeder—dart-shaped and aerodynamic, not a right angle to be seen anywhere on its bright red hull. Situated in the luxurious and spacious rear passenger compartment, Borpt and Double Trouble sat comfortably in soft leather seats as a chauffeur drove them to their intended destination. The Imp was amazed that such an unappealing specimen of man had the taste needed to select such a mode of transportation—their earlier assertions of him were beginning to shift. This was a rare occasion, for once Double Trouble made a decision on one's character, it was usually solid as concrete.

Hmmm… the consultant biz must be lucrative, the Imp mused as Borpt chatted away amicably to them. It was boring blather about the type of speeder, its model, its specifications, and some such. Double Trouble had no interest in such things but did their best to act interested—after all—they were an excellent actor.

Thankfully for them the ride was short, Double Trouble and Borpt arrived at the restaurant in an expedient fashion. As it came into view through sheets of rain, Double Trouble could discern that the entire establishment was situated in the midsection of one of the enormous monolithic buildings they had spotted upon their arrival.

“The restaurant I am taking you to is a most refined establishment,” Borpt said, self-satisfied. “The only way to reach it is by personal speeder—there is no ‘back door’ for the riff-raff to enter.”

Double Trouble smiled outwardly at this, masking their true feelings on Borpt’s ostentatious boasting.

Such a braggy little toad, the Imp thought secretly.

A landing platform jutted out from the side for arrivals—from there, valets took the speeders off to a parking facility as the guests disembarked. As soon the chauffeur landed, Borpt hopped out to scurry to the other side, opening Double Trouble’s door while offering a helping hand to guide them out.

This silly little man, they thought as they graciously accepted the offer, allowing themselves to be guided out.

“Such a fine gentleman!” Double Trouble smiled.

Feeling emboldened by their apparent favor, Borpt attempted to wrap his short arm in theirs—not having the long legs to manage the maneuver—he awkwardly withdrew the attempt. Double Trouble patted him on the head; *There, there, it’s okay*—the gesture seemed to say.

Borpt then pulled up his umbrella—Double Trouble was becoming very familiar with this item—and offered it to them, not even bothering to try and hold it over the two of them again. Graciously taking the portable canopy to hold it over them both, Double Trouble led the two of them toward the entrance where a long line had formed.

But before the Imp could take a position at the back of the line, Borpt clasped their wrist—looking down—Double Trouble saw him shake his head.

“This way, my dear,” Borpt said, his tone sly as he indicated an alcove off to the side.

Once he had guided them there, Borpt presented his hand held up in a fist; on his index finger was a large signet ring—a black stone in the shape of an eye was embedded in the gold band. Placing it in a small slot on the wall, a sharp click sounded before a secret door opened, revealing a small corridor. Borpt held his hand out to Double Trouble, indicating they go first.

"*After you*," he said, grinning knowingly.

Double Trouble was wrong-footed. *This little character is more than he seems,* they thought suspiciously.

Not wanting to appear uncomfortable, Double Trouble entered the hallway leading directly into a dining hall—there—they discovered an affrontery to their refined tastes: walls lavishly decorated in a black and white art deco of overlapping fans—a horror never before seen on Etheria.

How tacky! They thought, curling their lips.

Large pillars were interspersed throughout the space—running up and down their lengths—Double Trouble could discern black and gold geometric lines, painted in intricate patterns. Sizable gold chandeliers provide the illumination for the room—beneath which—patrons sat at elegant tables set far apart from each other. At the back of the dining hall was a stage, designed as if it was being held aloft by a huge wave, complete with seashells and various creatures the Imp had never seen before.

THAT is a place for performance, for art? You wouldn't catch me dead up there! It's hideous!

A band performing on various horn instruments and drums was currently on the stage, playing a soulful melody. Double Trouble was surprised to find something they finally enjoyed in this place—its sound was simultaneously raspy and smooth, pretty and hard—dualities that spoke to something deep within them, their foot beginning to tap to the rhythm.

*** THE IMP VIBE'N ***

A server approached them. “Your usual table, Mr. Borpt?” They queried.

“Why, of course, garçon!” Borpt replied, winking at Double Trouble.

*Take it easy, hot stuff. It will take a lot more than **that** to impress me,* the Imp thought, responding with a watery smile.

The waiter directed Borpt and Double Trouble to their table, situated right in front of the stage. Before Borpt could do anything, the Imp pulled a chair out for him, indicating he sit with a broad, toothy smile. Now Borpt was the one wrong-footed; he sat with a nervous chuckle as Double Trouble pushed the chair in for him. They sat opposite them, raising their tail and running their hands through their hair, tossing it back with a flourish. Borpt gazed at them, enraptured.

It looks like I caught this little fool in my web. Perhaps I can work that to my advantage. But what would that be? He seems too straight-edged to be involved in anything I would be interested in, they thought, gazing back with their most winning smile.

They concentrated on him, using their abilities to read his facial expressions, mannerisms, and voice timbre like an open book. Many people tried to mask their inner nature with a practiced façade, but this did not work with Double Trouble. They had abilities that went beyond the norm—magical abilities. They saw Borpt now, his true self. It did not take long.

I can’t say I’m surprised, they thought to themselves, *he is just a boring little man interested in boring little things. But I’m sure there is something I can work with. He seems to be well connected, and there must be some form of opportunity I can seize upon. I just have to sit through a bunch of inane conversation.*

They were correct; after ordering food, Borpt went into a lengthy description on the selection of KPIs—Key Performance Indicators

—to correctly match the appropriate business model.

"The trouble is, Double Trouble, there are thousands of KPIs to choose from. If you choose the wrong one, then you are measuring something that does not align with your goals. Right? How, then, should you go about selecting the right KPIs for your organization?" Borpt asked animatedly.

Double Trouble listened with one elbow on the table—chin in hand—and eyes hooded.

"I don't know, darling, how about you tell me?" they replied in monotone.

"Well, I'm glad you asked! KPIs are broken down into four categories…" he began, utterly oblivious to Double Trouble's boredom.

The Imp sighed heavily, gazing over at the stage. The band had been cleared out, and there was a small performance taking place, Dinner Theater style. It was a simple show, nothing too complex, for many of the patrons were only half paying attention. It was a performance that relied heavily on body language, light, and smoke instead of speech. It was very stylish and abstract, and *very* out of place in the gaudy setting. Double Trouble found themselves drawn to the performance.

One of the performers was dressed flamboyantly and gesticulating wildly—a sense of déjà vu struck Double Trouble as they found themselves sinking into an old memory.

They lay on their bed, watching their favorite program on the image projector. ***He*** *is on—their favorite, doing his usual act.*

"Oh, marvelous, honey! You do know how to treat a boy right!" He coos to staged background laughter.

Atreyen giggles at this, laying on their stomach with their chin in their hands, feet kicking up, and tail twitching in enjoyment. They love it when he talks that way; it is so noticeable, stylish, and fun!

It makes it seem like he is so happy and full of life, unconcerned with the trivialities of society and what is considered to be normal. He seems above it all.

It is a new program, one that is considered very groundbreaking and risqué. It is definitely not a show they are supposed to be watching. If their mother finds out, they will have to endure more lectures—which they had enough of for one lifetime.

The program ends, and they hop off the bed and over to the vanity. Standing in front of it they imagine themselves a famous actor.

"Oh darling, you shouldn't have!" They say, copying the mannerisms and poses they had just seen.

They are enjoying themselves immensely—that is—until their mother calls through the door.

"Atreya, did you call for me? What are you doing in there?" She asks in concern.

"Oh, nothing, mother—it's nothing. I was just reciting something for school!" They yell back, trying to mask their annoyance at their mother not using their correct name. They just want her to go away and leave them alone.

"Okay, Atreya. Don't forget we are going shopping later. We need to pick out something nice for your ceremony! It will be a nice mother/daughter shopping trip!" Their mother says happily.

They grit their sharp teeth and do not answer, angry at being reminded.

Their ceremony: where a girl becomes a woman. It is such a stark and unforgiving reminder of the realities of their existence that it brings them crashing down from their previous fantasy.

They gaze at themselves in the mirror, looking at their green face, slitted yellow and green eyes, long pointed ears, and bright red

hair. They are noticing… changes… in themselves over the past year. They are becoming much more feminine, and they do not like what is happening to them.

It is bad enough that everyone around them refuses to recognize who they are, but to have your own body refuse is worst of all. It is also the most inescapable—for how can you explain to your body that you don't identify as either male or female? At least their mother can be made to call them Atreyen occasionally, instead of Atreya.

Soon they will blossom into a young woman, no matter what they want—and judging by their appearance in the mirror, they will be a very lovely one. The expectation to adhere to a gender role will be stronger—it will be like a landslide—the farther along ***she*** *develops, the faster* ***she*** *will be swept down and buried under the weight of society.*

Wait, *they think to themselves,* ***did I just refer to myself as 'she' inside my own head? Even my own MIND is against me!***

Atreyen closes their hands into fists, slamming them into their forehead as tears brim in their eyes.

"NO! NO! NO! NO…"

Double Trouble was suddenly snapped out of their memory by something Borpt had just asked them.

"Uh, excuse me?" They asked, confused.

Borpt gazed at them with a mischievous smile. There was something different about him now, almost like he was someone else.

"*I said*… how long have you been involved in crime?" He asked evenly.

It was the second time this evening Borpt had wrong-footed them. The Imp's eyes widened and their long green ears drooped slightly—but they quickly regained control and laughed.

"Oh, darling, you are mistaken! I'm only involved in legal business. I don't get involved in any illegal shenanigans!" They giggled.

Borpt looked at them incredulously. "*Please…* come now, my dear. The way you move, the way you gauge a room, the way you dress... Everything about you screams illicit behavior. I can't imagine you being involved in anything remotely close to legal business."

How did this little twerp read ME so well when I completely misread him? I do not like this one bit, they thought, trying to maintain their façade.

"Oh, how unfair! You've made an assumption based on only my appearance? And to accuse me in public? *How dare you!*" Double Trouble said, trying to sound incensed.

Borpt only nodded, seeming convinced. "That was the other thing that gave you away. You seemed so comfortable in this setting, Double Trouble. These people don't care about what we say."

Using their abilities, the Imp suddenly looked closer at the people around them, finding that they agreed with Borpt's assessment; these people don't care about people talking about crime.

They all were of different shapes, sizes, sex, and species, but they all shared the same appearance: sleek, confident, and dangerous. The tacky room suddenly became much more menacing, and their situation suddenly seemed precarious.

Atreyen, you silly fool! You were so absorbed with the interior decorating that you missed the obvious! These people are all criminals! They thought angrily to themselves.

Borpt chuckled, seeing the look on Double Trouble's face. "Can we drop the act now and get down to business?"

Double Trouble was furious. *They* were the ones who played people; being on the other side—getting played—made them uncomfortable. Placing both arms down on the table, the Imp leaned towards Borpt, spreading their lips to show off all their sharp teeth.

"You seem to think you have me at a disadvantage, *honey*, but I can assure you, *don't play with me*. It won't end well for you." They hissed through teeth like razor blades.

Borpt waved this off. "You have me all wrong. I don't want to play you, I only want to do business with you. Isn't that why you came to Thenlor? To do business? I know you have no established business here, or I would know—so you can drop that nonsense, too. I want to offer you an opportunity, Double Trouble—one that will help you gain a foothold here and make some real money."

Double Trouble sat back and crossed their arms, gazing at Borpt intently. They saw it now; the smooth, calculating nature under the silly, boring consultant.

How did they not see it before? How did they see it now? Were they too distracted?

"I might be interested," they said, almost sulkily. "So, what, are you some kind of crime boss then?

Borpt laughed. "No… no, I'm no boss. Merely a small piece of a larger organization. I have multiple bosses over me. I'm kind of like a talent scout, looking for individuals with potential—individuals like you."

This did not make Double Trouble feel any better. They had only been around Borpt for perhaps half a day and he had them figured out—well—their business aspirations figured out. And on top of that, they had purchased real estate from him, real estate they intended to do business out of. He had them cornered.

Ugh, you just got here, and already you're in over your head. You thought you were such a big shot player on Etheria, but here on Thenlor, you're the one getting played! So weak, Atreyen! Weak!

"Okay, let's hear it then." Double Trouble said, putting some of their old confidence back in their voice.

Borpt smiled like a predator. "Not so fast! Before we can involve you in our organization, you need to do something for us. Think of it as kind of an audition."

Double Trouble gave Borpt a broad smile. "Oh honey, there hasn't been an audition that I *haven't* nailed."

* * *

Panga awoke to a strange sensation. There was a little ball of fur snuggled against her chest, her arms wrapped around it.

Oh, that's right. The feline warrior thought, remembering the night before. It was the small child—Flit—whom Panga had rescued from the Carmine Skinners.

After the surprise rescue, Panga climbed up to her secret hideout with the child clutching her neck. The little one whimpered the whole way, pressing her face against Panga's neck every time she looked to see how high they were. After a while, Filt had fallen asleep, and Panga could feel Flit's arms beginning to loosen as the little girl drifted into unconsciousness, forcing the feline warrior to climb with only her legs and one arm as she held onto the child.

Once they were safe inside the sanctuary, Panga collapsed on the bed with the child still against her—so utterly exhausted she was from the ordeal, not even bothering to try to dry them both off as they fell fast asleep.

The girl had been a restless sleeper during the night, waking up Panga periodically as she kicked or whimpered. She would settle back into more restful sleep once Panga started purring, the white

noise soothing whatever terrible nightmares the girl might be having.

Panga lay there, listening to Flit's breathing, not wanting to move and wake the girl… at least, not yet anyway.

The little one must be so exhausted; she needs as much rest as possible. She thought to herself.

But that was not the real reason Panga did not want to wake Flit—it was because it was nice having the girl snuggled against her, a feeling that the feline woman had missed deeply. Then it started—a deep, horrible ache in her soul—overwhelming as it came in sudden waves, forcing her mind towards a name.

Chhaya.

Panga closed her eyes tightly against the tears that threatened to spill out—Flit gave a little whimper as she was hugged tighter. Panga immediately loosened her grip and started purring, settling Flit back into sleep.

No... Panga, please don't think about it, please.

When the Shen'Aan-war had invaded the galaxy and the mission to Thenlor had come up, Panga had seized upon it. It was a planet-wide city filled with people who needed her help from invaders; it seemed like the perfect escape from her pain. But when She-Ra and her friends defeated the invaders, Panga remained, telling herself that there were people who still needed her help here. That much was true, people did need her help, and there were many of them—it was a planet full of pain.

But was it that she needed them more?

Panga's attention was suddenly drawn by the fact that Flit suddenly tensed in her arms—the little girl was awake.

She is probably scared and wondering who this strange lady is holding her, Panga thought as she disentangled herself from Flit to

sat up.

“Good morning, little one,” Panga said brightly, looking down at the small child who was currently trying to squeeze herself into a tight fuzzy ball.

“Now, now, you’re okay. Don’t be scared.” Panga said, stroking her hair. Flit uncurled and turned to her, eyes wide and unsure.

“How about we try cleaning you up and getting you something to eat? Would you like that little—Flit?” She said, holding her hands out.

Flit looked at the white claws on the tips of Panga’s finger uncertainly, but after a moment, she nodded her head in assent. Panga picked her up, placing the little girl on the edge of a nearby sink, wanting to get a better look at her.

She was dressed in an array of horrible-smelling dirty rags, and covered in grime. The top of Flit’s head would perhaps come to the bottom of Panga’s thigh—only if the little girl stood on her tippy toes. Like Panga, Flit was covered in short, fine fur—but where Panga’s fur was light orange—Flit’s was a russet brown, the exception being a cream-colored section running from just above her black button nose down her neck. With small round ears poking out of a tangle of long brown hair, Flit gazed back at Panga with large dark eyes.


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The little girl was barefoot and had small black claws at the ends of her fingers and toes—although they did not look suitable for climbing. Extending from her behind was a long, fur-covered tail—it was much thicker than Panga's cream-colored, brown-striped tail and appeared very strong.

The little girl was quiet as Panga wet a rag, starting to clean some of the grime from her face.

"It's hard to believe there is a little girl under all this—and a pretty one too!" Panga smiled kindly.

Flit just stared back at her quietly, not making a move.

"You don't talk much, do you?" Panga asked with a smile.

* * *

Flit stared up into her benefactor's beautiful orange face; Panga was her name. She peered questioningly at Flit with those large yellow-slitted eyes, so much like a feline predator's. However, there was no hunger or malice in those eyes—just curiosity and a hint of something else. A look that Flit had not seen in a long time, a look that only her mother would give her before those horrible men in black robes took her and her father.

The invaders.

Flit's family had come to Thenlor from their planet of Equinos—her parents were merchants looking to offload the beautiful gem-shells only found on their world. They planned to only stay on Thenlor for a short while, renting a small booth in one of the numerous Ultra-Markets. It had been one week into their visit that the invaders came to the planet.

They swarmed down from the sky in their black ships, easily overcoming the space and air defenses with strange and dark magic. Once they were on the ground, they unleashed legions of hideous soldiers who looked more dead than alive. These hordes were augmented by soldiers in black uniforms led by mysterious

figures in black robes—the source of the black magic. These dark wizards could shield their underlings from projectiles or energy-based weapons with their arcane abilities.

The invaders focused on the few places of government on Thenlor, assuming power when the weak and cowardly leaders acceded control of the planet in return for their lives. Within a day, black-uniformed troops and their hideous counterparts began patrolling the streets. What they wanted from the planet was unclear, only announcing to the populace that they would not be harmed if they did not resist and continued to go about their daily lives.

This was shown for the lie it was on a particularly dark night, when Thenlor's constant rain was more intense than usual, masking the sounds of rushing feet with its white noise.

With their keen hearing, Flit's parents had heard the soldiers coming before they burst into the stall that served as both a place of business and living quarters. Her mother and father hid her in one of their baskets of gem-shells, begging her to be silent.

As Flit hid, shivering with fear in the basket, the soldiers dragged her parents away—despite their pleas and questions. The little girl had remained there all night not making a sound, staying as still as possible, waiting for her parents to return. They never did.

Left on her own, Flit tried to survive as best she could. Having no idea how to return to her home planet, she tried to make ends meet by selling a few gem-shells a few at a time. This came to an end when opportunistic thugs robbed Flit of her entire stock, threatening her with violence if she tried to report them to the authorities. Not that the little girl would have; the 'authorities' were the ones who took her parents.

Left with nothing but the clothes on her back, Flit did the best she could to live off the wet, dark streets of Thenlor. When she wasn't scrounging for discarded scraps of food, Flit was running from the other unfortunate denizens of the streets—many of whom saw her

as dinner. When the invaders were overthrown, nothing changed; her parents were still gone and she was still alone, trying to survive in a planet-wide city with no sympathy.

That was until Flit was saved by this strange feline woman who was now cleaning her off.

"You don't talk much, do you?" Panga had just finished asking her as she cleaned grime out of Flit's fur. The question suddenly made Flit feel self-conscious; she did not know what to say in the face of all this unwarranted kindness. It also made her suspicious.

"Sorry," Flit answered in a small voice, "It's been a while since anyone has wanted to hear me talk, and I don't know what to say. Thank you, I guess?"

A startled look on Panga's face as both of her ears lowered, but the warrior woman quickly regained her composure.

"Of course!" Panga began, a slight strain in her voice, "I couldn't imagine *not* helping you, little one—I mean, Flit."

Panga turned quickly to retrieve another clean rag—but not before Flit noticed her wiping at her face. When Panga came back with a pile of clean rags, Flit saw that the fur around her eyes was wet—she had been crying. Flit saw it now; Panga was a good person, and her intent in rescuing Flit was out of kindness. Cruel and evil people didn't cry—at least, not about cleaning off a little girl. Immediately, Flit felt more comfortable and open with this stranger; it showed in her posture, and Panga could sense it.

"Do you have a home, a family, Flit?" Panga asked as she continued to wipe her gently down. Flit only shook her head sadly, looking down.

"I have no one. I am alone." She said miserably.

Flit felt Panga's hand on her chin, lifting her gaze into the other's bright yellow eyes. Panga was smiling down at Flit with a look she had only seen from one other person—her mother.

“You’re wrong on both counts,” the warrior woman said with a gentle laugh.

For the first time in a long time, Flit felt a warmness suffusing her core, where her heart was.



IRIA ABELLA

Chapter End Notes

Illustrations done by Iria, a.k.a ilikeyoucatradora on Instagram and Tumblr.

The Audition

Chapter Summary

> Double Trouble is given the chance to join the ranks of one of Thenlor's premier crime organizations. Do they have what it takes? Or will this be the first (and last) audition they fail?

Night had fallen as Double Trouble gazed up at the monolithic building from below, its immense proportions seeming to give an exclamation point to the difficulty of the task ahead. It was at the top of the building where the Imp's goal lay—the penthouse—where they could make out the dazzling multi-colored lights of a party currently transpiring. The constant rain added a glow to the rainbow colors, making it appear quite beautiful—much like another place Double Trouble once knew.

The Imp quashed that train of thought—now was not the time for soft desires. Borpt had given them a task to prove their worth and take their position within the premier crime organization of Thenlor; *The Vibrissa*. Double Trouble did not know much about this organization, but according to Borpt, The Vibrissa was everywhere and involved in everything and anything illegal. Even better, it was involved in making loads of money. The Imp knew even less about the mysterious leader of the group—only referred to once as Janus.

Double Trouble had felt a surge of anxiety when they had heard that particular name; they had heard of Janus before—long ago. They very much doubted it was the same person, for the Janus they once knew was far, far away in another life.

As part of their 'audition,' Borpt assigned them the task of stealing something vital to Janus and The Vibrissa. Double Trouble did not know much about it, other than its description: a cylindrical metallic object as long as their forearm, referred to as 'the codex'—kept in a secured trophy room. The owner of this trophy room was Xayide—a crime boss of a rival organization to the

Vibrissa. It was essential she did not find out who had taken her prize; a war between crime organizations was terrible for business.

Xayide was currently hosting a large party with numerous open invitations to many different gangs and crime families. No one would be checking for identification, nor had there been official invitations issued. Who would dare show up to a party organized by one of the most vicious crime bosses on Thenlor if they were not 'connected' in some fashion? It was the perfect opportunity for Double Trouble to slip in and out amongst the crowd.

This was a job the Imp was good at, for Double Trouble had once stolen one of the crown jewels of Bright Moon right from under Queen Angella's nose. This was done without anyone even realizing it was missing—only when the jewel turned up at an auction in Selineas did the Bright Moon royals know it was gone. Queen Angella had been furious, accusing King Mercia of thievery—Bright Moon almost went to war with Selineas. But that was another story.

Double Trouble had to admit to themselves that they were not relishing this upcoming job—but it wasn't the burglary aspect that bothered them. No, it was what they were expected to *endure* in order to accomplish it.

The Imp was currently waiting for their 'crew'—others who were tasked to help them achieve their goal. Double Trouble was not sure whether it was the stealing or the team participation that was the test. Perhaps it was both.

With arms crossed, foot tapping, and tail twitching, the Imp watched five figures approach from the opposite end of the avenue. It was a motley group; a person of unknown gender was leading two women and two men, all attired in their own individual styles. As the group neared, the leader addressed Double Trouble.

"You must be Double Trouble, right?" They queried.

Double Trouble gave a luxurious bow at the waist, "At your service," the Imp said in their most friendly and inviting manner.

"This is our burglar?" one of the women asked, incredulous. She was a large person, garbed in an old worn black uniform with the sleeves torn off, exposing huge tattooed biceps—obviously, she was the muscle. Her face was pretty in a masculine way, and her black hair was cut short and spiked up. What really stood out was her accent—it was strange, almost sibilant—reminding them of the way Shen spoke.

Double Trouble grinned, showing all their teeth. "Oh, don't worry, *honey*, I don't often disappoint. I'm sure you won't be complaining at the end of our experience together," they said lasciviously.

The woman growled and started to approach—fists clenched. The leader put their hand on her chest and shook their head. She relented.

"Don't mind Canens. She can be a little hot-headed." The leader said. "I am Aithex, and I will be leading this operation. Borpt said you wouldn't have any problem with this."

Double Trouble answered with a dismissive shrug, taking in the leader.

Aithex was plain to look upon—a bald-headed humanoid with light blue skin, dressed in a formfitting black body glove. Their only striking feature was their eyes—like two white gems, glittering in the darkness.

"You have already met Canens here," Aithex began and then turned to the rest, "Why don't you all introduce yourselves?"

One of the men beamed. Of slight build and attired in flamboyant, tight-fitting clothing, he had long blond hair and a matching well-trimmed beard.

“I am Fontus, and I am *very* pleased to meet you! I will be tonight’s *distraction!*” he said, excitedly clapping his hands and bouncing on the balls of his feet.

Double Trouble raised an eyebrow. “I bet you will be,” they said, knowingly with a grin.

The man next to Fontus was next. He wore more utilitarian clothing than his counterpart—a dark blue long-sleeved shirt and matching pants with numerous pockets. On his head was a skull cap with a metallic device wrapped around it—its function unknown. Held snugly to his back by two straps crisscrossing over his chest was a large backpack, completing his attire.

“The name’s Tibernus—my role is technical wizard and expert. You’re not getting anywhere without me.” He said with self-importance.

Double Trouble blew a raspberry through their lips at this proclamation, acting bored.

The last person in the group was the other woman. Wearing a formal, light gray business suit, her brown hair was in a tight bun—she glanced down at the ground when it was her turn, pushing her glasses back up on her nose.

“And you are, honey?” Double Trouble prompted. Aithex interjected.

“This is Olistene. She is what I would call an expert on tonight’s acquisition. She is here to verify that it is the true codex and not a decoy.” They stated.

Double Trouble put their hands on their hips. “And if it does turn out to be a decoy? What then?” They asked, a bit of annoyance in their voice.

“Then we stay until we find it,” Aithex responded smoothly. “It is of the utmost importance that we return to Janus with his prize.”

The unspoken warning was clear to all of them—they didn't want to fail in this mission.

"So, what about you, Fancy Pants Lizard? What makes you so appealing that Borpt selected you for this mission as our burglar?" Canens asked abruptly.

Double Trouble ignored the insult and smiled. They had been called worse than a Fancy Pants Lizard.

"What makes me so appealing, you ask? Why don't I show you, *honey*," the Imp replied.

Suddenly, Double Trouble was uncertain as they held out their arms, gazing at the jacket material. It seemed to glimmer in the dark light.

Hmm… I forgot about the jacket, why did I bring it? It is going to be hard to transform with it on, they thought to themselves.

"Okay… are you going to do a magic trick?" Canens said with a laugh.

At the word *magic*, Double Trouble grinned—it all made sense to them now. Suddenly their entire body, including the physical jacket, became a black void—green motes, like fireflies, dancing within. Their outline morphed and shimmered, changing into a slighter form with more accentuated curves before the black void with the green motes disappeared, revealing Double Trouble's new appearance.

They were a dark-skinned human female, onyx hair forming ringlets around a beautiful, round face. Their shapely body was clad in a black, gem-studded evening gown—the neckline plunging past their belly button. The back of the dress mirrored the front.

"How do you like me now?" They asked in a much more feminine voice.

Canens gaped at them, completely enraptured.

"I like," she choked out.

Double Trouble laughed in wicked merriment as they changed back to their original form, leaving Canens to whine in disappointment.

Fontus piped up. "Color me impressed. One thing, though—can we just call you D.T.? Saying Double Trouble all the time will get tiring. It's such a *mouthful*!"

Double Trouble laughed at this. "Sure, my little lamb, you can call me by whatever little pet name you can come up with."

Fontus beamed at their words as Canens and Tibernus rolled their eyes.

"Okay, fearless leader, how does this go down? What is our *plan?"* Double Trouble asked, a challenge in their voice.

Aithex nodded. "Yes, well, the first step is getting to the party, Tibernus? If you please?"

Tibernus stepped up, taking off his backpack and placing it down. He opened it, right away digging through the contents and muttering under his breath.

"Hmmm… I thought I packed them… mmmm… ah here it is!" He exclaimed, seizing the items he was searching for. Fontus laughed and placed a hand on Tibernus' shoulder.

"Oh honey, I don't think you are putting much confidence into our friends here," he chuckled, smiling apologetically to the group.

"Nonsense," Tibernus said dismissively as he handed out what appeared to be wristbands, belts, and small white beads to everyone in the group.

“Now, the bracelets are basically anti-gravity units with their limiters removed. As soon as they are activated, you will start rising into the air. Once we are at the correct height, we turn them off.” He said confidently, indicating the button that acted as the on/off switch.

“And then what? We fall to the ground and die? Wow, great plan, dummy.” Canens said sardonically.

“Will you let me finish?” he said, annoyed. “Once we turn them off, that is where the belts come in. Once activated,” he said, indicating the button at the belt buckle, “They deploy parachutes which will allow us to glide into our destination. The parachutes can be retracted back into the belt so they can be used again. It’s perfect, completely silent, and undetectable. It is also a great means of escape if that is required. We don’t have to wait for a speeder or other modes of transportation.”

“Neat,” Double Trouble stated sarcastically, “But I won’t be needing the belt thingy. I assume these little things are a form of communication?” They said, holding up one of the white beads.

Tibernus was wrong-footed as Double Trouble handed back the belt. He turned to Aithex, who shrugged in response.

“Uh… yeah, that’s right. Just put it in your ear. We can talk to each other through it.” He responded. They all put their own individual devices on in their proper places, with Double Trouble the only one not putting on a belt.

Aithex removed something from a hidden fold in their body glove, holding it up in the palm of his hand. It beeped, and a three-dimensional holographic image of the penthouse materialized above it, represented in glowing blue lines.

“The party is being held in a penthouse which encompasses the entirety of the top of the mega-structure. We will enter through *here*,” Aithex said, indicating a large balcony in the back, “And enter the party. Olistene and I will stay near our entry point to

coordinate the operation while maintaining our avenue of escape. The rest of you will enter the main ballroom where Fontus will create the distraction. Canens will assist him if necessary."

Fontus squealed with delight while Canens rolled her eyes.

Aithex continued. "While everyone is distracted, D.T. will make their way to the Vitrine Salon—"

"Excuse me, a *what*?" Interjected Canens.

"It's a fancy way of saying *trophy room*, dear," Double Trouble said helpfully, "I assume that it will be locked? The owner will not want guests wandering in there without escort—*I'm sure.*"

"Yes, I'm getting to that," Aithex glared at Double Trouble, annoyed. "Tibernus will access the security network via a data port located in the utility closet here," they said, indicating its location in a hallway adjoining the ballroom, "And disable any security measures."

Double Trouble put their hand to their chin in thought. "That's a nice, simple plan, dear. What about security measures of the non-gadgetry kind—the *fleshier* kind?"

Aithex cocked their head. "Yes, there will be security and they are formidable—but that is where your *special talents* come in. I trust you can handle it."

Double Trouble only crossed their arms and grinned smugly in reply, their tail curling up into itself like a spiral.

Aithex put their holographic display away. "We ready? The time is now. Most of the guests should have arrived. Let's ascend."

All six members of the heist activated their anti-gravity units and started to rise into the gloom of Thenlor's drizzly night. Double Trouble went limp and allowed themselves to be drawn up by the wrist. Looking over, they noticed Canens holding her arm with the

bracelet on out in from of her—as if she was resisting the pull of the anti-gravity device.

They shook their head in mirth. *Silly lunk,* they thought, *you shouldn't fight it when you don't have to.*

As the group rose higher, the dark city spread out before them, transports and other aerial vehicles zipping about—thankfully, they seemed to be out of any traffic areas. It would be a shame if the Imp's night was cut short by a speeding Thenlorian on their way to a hot date.

As everyone reached a height from which they could gaze down upon the mega-structure, Aithex gave the signal. All six deactivated their anti-gravity units—but only five activated their parachutes.

Double Trouble had a different plan; spreading their arms, they morphed them into two large black wings, their glistening feathers matching the black material of their coat and pants. The Imp soared amongst the group, using their long tail as a rudder to deftly move around Fontus and Tibernus. The two men gaped at Double Trouble, visibly impressed.

"You're *amazing,* darling!" Fontus cried.

Double Trouble tipped their wings in a salute, suddenly amazed by themselves.

You never were able to perfect a bird form, let alone flight, Atreyen. How did you know this would work? They thought to themselves, but they already knew the answer*.*

It was the jacket. It was augmenting their abilities.

Ahhh… Shen… we are totally even now, the Imp thought with a smile.

It was exhilarating to feel the wind on their body, to know that the form they created was manifesting flight. There were so many air

currents and thermals in this planet-wide city—they could ride the air for a great distance. Double Trouble laughed out loud in joy; it was the first genuine emotion they had shown in a long time. They imagined that they must appear so magnificent gliding through the air, like a great majestic bird, or… a kite.

A kite? They thought, confused by comparison. *Where did that come from?*

Then they remembered.

JUST LIKE HEAVEN

It is a beautiful day, a day to be at the local park and enjoy the weather. Atreyen grasps the long pink string tethering the rainbow kite to themselves as it bobs and weaves in the sky.

"Give it more slack, Atreyen!" a female voice says next to them. "Let it fly higher!"

Atreyen did as they were told, unwinding more of the string from the spool. It is now flying so very high now, and Atreyen can almost feel the string weakening.

"Oh… I don't know, Yikka. I think the string is going to break." Atreyen said, gazing in worry at the kite.

Yikka laughs. "So what if you lose it? What's wrong with reaching higher? Take a chance, Atreyen!"

They gaze over at their friend—Yikka is one of the only few people in their life who calls them by their preferred name. Atreyen has known Yikka since they were both very small—the moment they had met her in nursery-creche, both children had a special affinity for the other. Yikka has been a constant companion in their existence, and Atreyen can not imagine life without her. She is such a dear friend—a very dear friend—and Atreyen had to admit to themselves that lately, they had been wanting something more… but that was forbidden…

Atreyen feels one final tug as the string goes limp—peering up—they see the kite flying free in the sky. There is something so simultaneously sad and wonderful about the sight; the kite is no longer bound to the earth, free from all concerns. Feeling someone grasp their hand, they turn to find themselves staring into a pair of lovely green and yellow-slitted eyes.

"Oh, don't worry, I will get you another one. I'm sorry, I shouldn't have pushed you." Yikka says sorrowfully.

"No, it's okay, Yikka. I feel like I need someone to give me a push every once in a while," they said, placing their other hand over hers. Yikka's eyes widen, and she blushes, extracting her hand from between theirs, quickly laughing it off.

"Oh, don't worry, Atreyen, I will always be there to give you a nudge when you need it." She says meaningfully, staring back into their eyes.

*Atreyen feels a warm feeling deep in their core at this sentiment, lingering on the word—**always.** It gives them a reassurance that they deeply need, that there will always be someone who accepts them in a world where nonconformance is unheard of.*

Suddenly their attention drifts over Yikka's shoulder, off to a figure standing at the edge of the park, under the shade of a tree. This person watching the interplay between themselves and Yikka—Atreyen cannot recognize their face. They are strange in appearance, covered in a dark hooded robe—its color unclear. There is a large staff in their hand, held upwards, with an orb at the top. The sphere is like a black hole—the dancing of green lights perceived within.

But that is not the strangest part; it is the face beneath the hood. The face is green, like all of Atreyen's people, but it is truly genderless. It is a face Atreyen yearns to have.

Then there are the eyes. They are just like the orb at the top of the staff, all black with sparkling green motes.

The figure smiles at them.

"D.T.! Wake up!" Fontus screamed.

Double Trouble snapped out of their reveries just as the penthouse balcony slammed into their face—right away—they curled into a ball and rolled, absorbing most of the impact. After sufficiently dissipating their momentum, Double Trouble came to a stop in the most undignified manner—a pile of black wings with their rump in the air, tail limp as a noodle.

"Ohhhh…" the Imp moaned as their wings transformed back into their normal form.

"You better work on that landing there, Fancy Pants Lizard," Canens said mockingly, reaching down to help them to their feet.

Aithex walked up to Double Trouble, concern written plainly on their face.

"This isn't the kind of performance we can expect for the rest of their heist, is it, D.T.?" They asked angrily.

Double Trouble stood with Canens's help, still rubbing their head. "No… just a little hiccup, darling." They said, trying to sound reassuring.

"Besides the landing, that was an awe-inspiring performance, D.T.!" Fontus said brightly.

Double Trouble only nodded and smiled in thanks as the group moved from the balcony into one of the penthouse's guest bedrooms. No one said anything as Aithex and Olistene stayed in the bedroom while Double Trouble, Canens, Fontus, and Tibernus exited into the hallway, closing the door behind them. Wandering guests gave them grins and knowing looks, but otherwise, their sudden arrival was not seen as suspicious.

Continuing down a series of hallways and past other guests questing for more private locations, the group followed the sound

of the electronic music, the rhythmic beats getting louder as they neared the party. Finally, they made it to the ballroom.

UNDERWORLD ABOVE IT ALL

It was a large, gloomy, circular area with bronze-colored walls, floor, and ceiling. Four large downward pointing nozzles jutted from the ceiling, equally spaced from each other, weak light emanating down from the tips to form hazy beams. Between the lights was a large, red leafy plant—like a vine—covering the ceiling. In the direct center of the room, a short, raised circular platform was erected—there—a diva provided a sultry song to accompany the sludgy beats.

Party members of different sexes, species, shapes, and sizes were dispersed throughout the room, imbibing intoxicants of their choice. The ones who smoked created a haze in the air, adding to the dark and dank environment. Around the chamber were various circular, plush couches—where revelers lounged.

The host of the party could be spotted towards the back of the room; Xayide—a slender, severe-looking woman arrayed all in black. Xayide watched all her guests intently, not appearing to be joining in on anything that would muddle her mind. Surrounding her were four members of her security team outfitted in red leather uniforms—they diligently scanned the room through a single dark horizontal slit in their red helmets. Worn openly at their waists were pronged metal batons—most likely some kind of stun weapon.

The four heist members took it all in.

"Fontus, honey, I hope you have a perfect distraction in mind. It is going to take something big to get this lot's attention." Double Trouble said dubiously.

Fontus grinned back at them before sauntering toward the center of the space, Canens trailing behind.

Feeling a tug at their jacket, Double Trouble turned to find Tibernus gazing up at them expectantly.

“Let’s go, D.T., we need to get into position.” He implored.

Double Trouble was unwilling—the Imp was curious to discover what distraction Tibernus would provide.

“Come on!” Tibernus insisted, pulling on their tail. “I’ve seen it tons of times. It's not a big deal. I’m sure Fontus will put on a private performance for you later!”

Annoyed at being handled, Double Trouble hissed as they yanked their tail out of Tibernus’ grip—whirling to follow him in a huff. Striding down the halls, the Imp could make out a loud commotion behind them—the tumult of a great mass of cats fighting combined with the blaring of trumpets. Stray guests wandering the halls began moving towards the noise, eager to partake in the distraction. Even better, the security teams patrolling the passageways began heading in that direction as well, unsure if this was a form of attack.

It must have been an incredible distraction, and Double Trouble was visibly agitated and angry—a rarity for them—as they did not like missing out on a good performance.

Coming to the utility closet, Double Trouble stood guard as Tibernus worked the bolt mechanism. As he unlocked it, the door opened, revealing a room full of glowing blue cables and blinking lights; a data screen with a keyboard nestled within. Before entering, Tibernus turned to Double Trouble.

“Hey buddy, I don’t know what’s wrong with you, but you need to focus! You seem easily distracted! My friend Fontus is back there, and I don’t want anything to happen to him because of you. Understand?” He asked.

Double Trouble favored Tibernus with a frosty expression—just before pushing him into the utility closet and closing the door.

He is right, darling. We do need to get a grip, they thought, making their way to the Vitrine Salon. *You've been completely unhinged ever since…*

The Imp shook their head, freeing themselves of that particular train of thought. Turning a corner, they spotted the entryway to their destination—a pair of gold double doors, decorated with two halves of an orb formed where they met in the middle. Bizarre symbols were carved on the outside of the orb in a ring, their meaning unknown.

"*Okay, Tibernus, I'm here at the door. Let me in*." They whispered, hoping the earbud could pick up their voice.

Hearing crackle, a tinny voice spoke in their ear. "Yes, I hear you—one moment. I'm having a heck of a time with the security mainframe. They use a code I've never seen before based on these weird symbols. Hang on,"

Double Trouble rolled their eyes and crossed their arms, their tail flicking in annoyance.

"*Well*?" They whispered.

"Agghhh… I can't open it!" Tibernus exclaimed in their ear. "Wait, hang on… there is a small vent nearby. I can deactivate the ion field long enough for you to get in and out. Any chance you could use your Fancy Pants Lizard abilities to squeeze through?"

Double Trouble peered up to discover the vent Tibernus spoke of, noticing the blue glow and a hum emanating from within, indicating that the ion field was active. It would be child's play for them to squeeze past the grill and into the shaft—they were looking forward to this—when they could *perform,* it always put them in a better mood.

"*Yes, the Fancy Pants Lizard can do that*." The Imp responded. "*Turn off the field and let me do my thang, honey."*

With a final *bzzzt*, the field was deactivated. Double Trouble extended their arms up toward the vent, their form becoming the dark night of green fireflies. The Imp's body stretched and lengthened, starting at their fingertips, becoming thinner and thinner. They flowed past the grille and into the vent, maintaining their form as they slithered through the vent like a magic snake made of green stars. Eventually, Double Trouble made it to the other side, oozing past the grill and landing on the floor in a solid blob. Their transitional form morphed back into their true aspect as they stood fluidly, sweeping their long silver hair back with both hands in a luxurious manner. Double Trouble cast about, a little annoyed no one was there to witness their performance.

"I'm in," they said, not bothering to whisper anymore. They took in the room.

Lining the walls of the Vitrine Salon were brightly lit display cases of all shapes and sizes—larger stand-alones spaced about the middle. All manner of items were encased within these cabinets, but they shared the same theme; a dark aura surrounded each and every one of them.

There were vicious whips, projectile weapons, blasters, swords, knives, and other weapons. There were skulls and ugly boxes for holding terrible things. There were glass jars containing specimens of creatures floating in preservation fluid—wicked beings whose shape Double Trouble would loathe to take. There were other more esoteric items; a painting of a horrible moon in a sky of red stars, a black hooded robe, and a palm-sized smooth white stone sitting on a small silk bag.

It was amongst these items that Double Trouble spied their prize —a silver metal cylindrical tube about as long as their forearm. It was the codex, in its very own cabinet near the middle of the space.

Approaching the case, the Imp held out a hand, their index finger forming a layer of cinnamon-colored fur as a black retractable claw appeared at the end. Using the newly formed talon, they

sliced a neat circle in the glass as their middle finger became a purple tentacle, suckers on one side to carefully extract the glass without breaking it. With their other arm, they reached inside and withdrew the codex.

"I have the item. Heading back to the exit." The Imp told their team via the communicator.

Suddenly, the alarms went off.

"Tibernus! I thought you disabled the security in this room?" Double Trouble screeched.

"Uhhh… the alarms aren't for you D.T.—it's Fontus. I think he's outdone himself and started a riot." Tibernus said, a hint of a smile in his voice. "Sometimes that boy is just too good."

"Everybody, get back to the rendezvous point!" Aithex said, suddenly coming onto the communication line. They were utterly enraged. "Fontus! You idiot! Stop what you're doing and get back here!"

"*Coming…*" Fontus replied, his voice like a whisper and sounding utterly drained.

The alarm continued as Double Trouble scrutinized the vent, feeling immediately dismayed. They could get through it, but the codex was solid and wouldn't pass through the grill—nor bend through the twists and turns of the vent.

Oh well, I just have to go through the door. The alarms are already going off. The Imp thought as they scrambled over to the door to activate the controls. As the twin doors slid smoothly to the sides, Double Trouble almost screamed as they recognized the person on the other side.

It was Xayide with two of her security detail flanking her, amusement written on her hard face.

“Oh, hello. I seem to have gotten lost. Can you show me to the nearest powder room?” Double Trouble said lamely, knowing they were caught.

Xayide shook her head. “I knew you would show up. Just couldn’t take no for an answer, could you?” She said, eyes locked on the cylinder in the Imp’s hand.

Now Double Trouble was confused. “Yeah, hon, you totally have me mixed up with someone else.”

Xayide’s face became stern. “No, I’m not, and I’m not playing any games with you this time. TAKE THEM!” she screamed.

Pulling out their batons, the two thugs thumbed the activation switches, a hard-buzzing sound indicating their energy fields were live. In unison, the bodyguards immediately lunged at the Imp, batons raised over their heads—but Double Trouble was ready for their assault. Pivoting on one foot, they spun, flinging their tail outward like an enormous lash. It was their favorite move.

The tail struck both attackers in the chest, and with Double Trouble’s considerable strength behind it, sent the thugs soaring past Xayide and into the wall. The security guards struck hard and slid down on their backs—heads lolled forward and out cold.

“Ugghhh… I will have to take care of you myself,” Xayide huffed, removing a cylindrical weapon from her waistband. She held it before her with both hands and flicked an activation stud—instantly, a long black beam slid out; the edges outlined in an electric white haze. It extended a meter from what was now obviously the hilt and ended in a point—a laser sword.

Ohhhhh, Atreyen, that looks like it could hurt, they thought to themselves, and then out loud, “Any chance we could talk about this like civilized beings?”

Xayide screamed before lunging at Double Trouble, blade singing in a downward trajectory. Instinctually, the Imp held out a forearm

to ward off the blow, wincing as they expected agony—but besides the pain of being struck—the blade did not cut through.

Double Trouble discovered the laser sword was held in place, sizzling at their forearm where it met the material of their magical, black jacket.

Shen, I could kiss you, darling, they thought, lashing out with a punch to Xayide's chest with their other arm, knocking her back into the wall. The crime boss rebounded off the wall and dropped her weapon—it deactivated with a *pop* and slid across the floor, coming to a rest at Double Trouble's feet. Picking it up, the Imp peered at Xayide's slumped form resting over one of her minions, as unconscious as they were.

"I'll be keeping this, honey. Don't need you coming after me with it again. Something like this could leave a nasty mark on my sweet precious hide." They smirked, tucking the hilt into an inner pocket of their jacket.

Suddenly the communicator in their ear buzzed. "D.T.! Where are you? We have to go!"

It was Tibernus—shouting and screaming could be heard through his end of the line.

"Coming, darling. Just ran into a little snag," they replied, starting to run in the direction of the ballroom. "Where are you?"

"We just left the ballroom. I'm helping Canens carry out Fontus. Hurry!" Was his reply.

Double Trouble ran down the hallway past disorientated party-goers running amok.

What did Fontus do to these people, and how can I learn it? They thought, reaching the ballroom.

It was chaos.

Parts of it were aflame, and the guests who were still there were fighting each other. All four of the ceiling lights were damaged and flickering, adding to the feeling of complete madness. The center performance stage was empty and covered with a sparkly slime—it glistened strangely in the strobing lights.

"What in the—" Double Trouble started to say but was interrupted by a man running at them, fist raised to strike.

The Imp slapped him, open-handed, into the ground. The assailant rolled over—dazed—gazing up at them with his mouth wide open.

"Don't *even*," they said, waving a finger down at him, "I'm not in the mood to play—*honey*."

Double Trouble left the stunned man and ran out of the ballroom, through the halls, past more lunatic guests, and finally to the bedroom, meeting up with the rest of their group.

Tibernus and Canens were holding up a wholly exhausted Fontus—all three covered in the sparkly slime Double Trouble had seen on the ballroom stage. The Imp ignored them and approached Aithex, holding out the codex.

"Here you go, hon—" They started to say before Olistene snatched it out of their hands.

Double Trouble was incensed. "My word, you're a *grabby* little thing!"

Olistene ignored them as she unscrewed one end of the cylinder to remove a rolled piece of paper from within. Unrolling it, she examined it thoroughly, Double Trouble noticing the same strange symbols they had observed scrawled on the Vitrine Salon's double doors—except these were written in a kind of scarlet ink.

"Is it authentic? Was it written by Zzar?" Aithex asked.

Olistene gaped up at him, her eyes wide and glistening with tears as she nodded.

“Who’s Zzar?” Double Trouble asked.

“Never mind,” Aithex snapped, “We have what we came for. Time to go. Janus must get his prize.”

“What about Fontus? He is barely conscious. I don’t think he can operate the chute and escape.” Tibernus said mournfully.

Aithex inspected Fontus as if he were bug on their sleeve. “Leave him.” They said, unconcerned.

“No!” Tibernus cried. Canens was also visibly upset by this proclamation, appearing unwilling to leave her comrade behind.

“Don’t worry, my precious lambs, I will carry him.” The Imp said calmly.

Holding their upper limbs outward, Double Trouble transformed their arms back into the vast, black wings. They strode over to Canens and Tibernus, indicating that they should place him on the ground, which they did without protest. Double Trouble’s lower legs and feet then morphed into large, curved claws—like a bird of prey. They gently wrapped their new feet around Fontus’ shoulders, and with a downward thrust of their wings, lifted into the air and off the balcony.

Wiping away tears, Tibernus watched Double Trouble soar away, carrying his precious Fontus to safety.

“Whatever, let’s go!” Aithex said, jumping off the balcony and activating their parachute. Tibernus, Canens and Olistene followed suit, jumping off the balcony and into the night.

By all appearances, the heist had been a complete success.

Sable

Chapter Summary

After their successful heist, Double Trouble has a new problem.

Trying to make ends meet, Flit turns to desperate tactics, bringing her to the attention of someone who can be very dangerous.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It had finally come; the off-work cycle day. It is a day for relaxation and contemplation—a day for Thenlorians to enjoy their lives instead of the drudgery of employment. Many citizens of the planet spent their lives locked away in tall buildings, sitting in small cubicles and completing menial, dreary tasks for low pay. Each second of their precious lives had a certain fiscal amount they were compensated for—and the exchange rate was poor. Every one of them looked forward to their day away from work, and the majority all shared the same way to spend it—by blowing all their hard-earned currency at one of the many indoor mega markets.

There was one such mega-market in particular that Thenlorians flocked to, located deep in the tiered sub-structure of the planet-wide city. There, eager patrons busily spent their hard-earned earnings on clothes, jewelry, data cubes containing various multimedia, and other items. They thronged the gigantic enveloping walls of the space, either on the ground floor or the multiple tiers on either side of the long processional—the various levels connected by glass lifts and automatic staircases.

One shopper stood out amongst thousands of beings—dressed outlandishly in a green and brown plaid jacket, they sauntered amongst the patrons, their long green tail swaying back and forth.

Reptilian eyes sparkled under a green, wide-brimmed sunhat—worn at a jaunty angle as they took in the merchandise.

Mmmm… shopping always makes me feel good. I have been so very taxed recently. Double Trouble thought as they inspected a revealing evening gown made of semitransparent material. They gazed at it, memorizing its form for later use.

PLEASENT DISTRACTIONS

It had been two weeks since their participation in the heist at Xayide's penthouse—two weeks since their induction into the ranks of the Vibrissa, earning the obscure title of 'Lideri' and given their own responsibilities. These *responsibilities* were on their mind at the moment, causing them a great deal of anxiety. The Imp reached down to scratch a red patch on their tail, which, try as they might, they could not conceal with their abilities.

Ohhhh… honey… stress always makes you break out. Our precious skin! I hate it! They thought miserably.

After the successful heist, Borpt visited them at their establishment, informing Double Trouble that Janus approved of their appointment as Lideri. With this new rank, they would be given their own sector, encompassing a huge territory—bigger than Bright Moon and the Frightzone combined. In this sector, they were responsible for distributing and selling Vibrissa's main product—Sable.

Borpt had brought a sample of the product to them, and Double Trouble found themselves inwardly cringing at the memory.

He had held it out to them, cupped in the palm of his hand. It appeared as a piece of chipped obsidian—pure black and shiny. The Imp had taken it from him, holding it in their hand and tipping it back and forth in the dim light of their establishment. It felt so very cold, like ice—or a heartbreak.

"Hold it up to the light, and try very hard to look through it," Borpt had prompted, a smile on his face and a laugh in his eyes.

Double Trouble did as bidden, grasping the Sable between index and thumb as they directed it towards one of the ceiling lights. The Imp closed one green and yellow eye as they squinted at it with the other, trying hard to peer through the inky substance of Sable.

They gasped.

A rare moment of love from a domineering mother, a stolen kiss from one's true forbidden love, transition and then freedom, a new world, a new them, heterochromatic blue and yellow eyes beaming at them with pure happiness for rescuing them, waking up with someone in their arms…

'Unnnnhh…" Double Trouble moaned low. It was a sound of longing, one of pure desiderium.

Experiencing all of those memories at once was simultaneously pleasurable and painful—leaving Double Trouble with the desire of wanting more. But something was wrong—it was not a fair exchange. Double Trouble—who was in touch with their body and mind like no other—could sense that something was being taken from them. It was not a physical extraction; it was deeper, down to their very essence.

Their soul?

With the Sable gripped tightly in one fist, they bent over and closed their eyes, holding their head with the other as the intense emotions left their body. They felt a warm hand prying their fist open, extracting the Sable they were clutching.

"Feels good, doesn't it?" Borpt whispered to them like a lover. "Can you see the marketability of something like this?"

Double Trouble suddenly looked at him, finally seeing him for the horrible person he was. On the inside, they were screaming, but on the outside, they said—

“Yes, my dear. I can see very promising things for it. Truly wondrous indeed.”

Borpt was pleased by this and immediately launched into an explanation. Double Trouble was to create a distribution network in their sector and was responsible for offloading a certain quantity of Sable. But more importantly, they were expected to generate a certain profit—a very high profit—and have the first earnings by the end of this month.

It was two weeks into the first month and Double Trouble had only sold a very small portion of the Sable they were expected to offload. This the Imp had done personally and at great expense to themselves, taking the form of a street thug they had once seen and going person to person trying to make a sale. It was only three days into this tedious undertaking, and they were utterly spent; there just wasn’t enough Double Trouble to go around for this method to work. The Imp had wracked their brain; *how could they build an infrastructure or network to reach more customers?*

But those kinds of plans required stability and a mind for logistics—two abilities that Double Trouble was not particularly known for. The Imp could barely maintain The Enchanted Grotto when it was under their management, and that was because the place seemed to run best when it was in chaos.

All their thinking and worrying had caused Double Trouble so much grief—it was then they decided it was best to forget everything and go shopping. Who knew? Maybe inspiration would strike when gazing upon a fabulous pair of shoes.

The Imp was strolling through the marketplace, feeling much better about themselves already when they saw it.

Located on a table and mixed with other wares—an eclectic assortment of junk—was a cheap pink plastic chain connected in a small loop. Little gems—fake, of course—were studded throughout the links; they were multicolored and gleamed dully in the weak light.

A toy bracelet.

It was so much like another Double Trouble had known from before—far away. The Imp found themselves drawn to the bracelet and picked it up, holding it in their hand like it was the most precious thing they had ever found.

“You like?” The merchant asked eagerly.

Double Trouble nodded meekly. “Yes, how much?” They asked in a whisper.

The merchant gave them a sum; it was high, meant to be haggled down, but Double Trouble handed it over, eager to be off with their prize. The merchant was pleased and started cackling to themselves, but the Imp ignored them as they walked away, placing the bracelet on their wrist as if in a trance.

They began to remember.

The hour is late, and Atreyen is on stage with Yikka. The two of them are the only souls present in the spacious hall of the school’s auditorium.

“I shall not walk with you… on this night… you are but a droll man,” Yikka states as dryly as possible. She is such a terrible actor, and Atreyen could not help but giggle to themselves.

“Atreyen! Stop laughing; it's not funny! I need to get this down before the upcoming play or I’m going to get booed off the stage!” Yikka cries.

“Easy, easy… my dear, let me show you,” they say, clearing their throat. “I shall not walk with you; on this night, you are but a droll man,” Atreyen says with much more emphasis and feeling. They absolutely LOVE acting and adore being a part of their school’s drama club. Of course, they love being in the drama club even more since Yikka is a part of it.

“Oh, Atreyen, you’re such a wonderful actor!” Yikka beams. “I wish I had a fraction of your talent!”

They grin and blush at Yikka’s compliment; it is like the sunrise to receive her praise.

“Oh, don’t be so hard on yourself. I’ve been practicing at this since I was just a hatchling. You’ll get it.” They say.

Yikka grins. “You’re so sweet to me,” she starts, then stops as if recalling something and reaches into her pocket.

“I just remembered... I have something for you,” she says as she pulls out a short loop of pink plastic chain studded with faux rainbow gems. Yikka hands it to them.

YOU SWORE

Atreyen takes it, tentatively clasping it around their slender green wrist. It fits just right, and the glass gems sparkle under the bright stage lights. They look up into Yikka’s eyes, and she smiles shyly.

“I know it’s not much, but it’s all I could afford with my allowance. It felt right to give you something special, to show how much you… mean to me.” She says, almost afraid to say the last part.

Their heart is hammering in their chest as they take Yikka’s hand in one of theirs, their other hand brushing her cheek. Her eyes widen in shock—but she does not move as they rub their thumb across her wrist, feeling her pulse quicken. Atreyen leans in—Yikka’s eyelids close as her lips quiver—both bodies entwine as the two kiss.

Atreyen does not need to feel her wrist anymore—they can feel her heart beating directly in her chest as they press into her. It is beating in concert with theirs, entirely in tune. It feels so good, so right, and they know Yikka must feel the same, for it is as if the two of them are one.

The two young lovers part and Atreyen sees that Yikka's eyes are hooded, lips still parted in memory of the kiss. She is still holding them—clutching them—at the cusp of drawing them in once again.

"I had been dreaming of this, Atreyen," Yikka breathes. "Dreaming and hoping, I thought—"

"—that such a thing wasn't possible?" Atreyen finishes.

Yikka suddenly grins and nods.

"Remember what you said to me? That day in the park—when we lost the kite." Atreyen asks. Yikka answers instantly.

"I will always be there to give you a nudge when you need it,"

"Yes!" Atreyen says. "I will always be there too, Yikka. Do you know why? It's because I lov—"

Suddenly there is the sound of a door closing, and Yikka jolts, pushing them away, gasping.

"What's wrong?" They ask, reaching for her, but she pushes them away.

"Atreyen, somebody saw us!" Yikka gasps, looking back towards the door.

"So what?" They say with a bit of annoyance in their voice. "Let them tell everyone. I'm used to the talking, the whispers."

Yikka shakes her head; there are tears in her eyes now. "But I am not! Ohhh…"

They reach for her again, but Yikka turns. "I have to get going, Atreyen, I will see you tomorrow…" She says, rushing to the door their voyeur had used, her head down and arms wrapped around her torso.

“Yikka, wait!” They cry after her—but she is gone.

They look down at the bracelet Yikka had given them, stroking it and holding it up to their face. They press the cold plastic and glass of the gift against their cheek, smelling her essence on it; it is already fading, like an old sweet memory. Tears start to bead from their eyes, running down their green cheeks.

“Well, that could have gone better,” a voice sounds from the shadows.

“Who’s there?” Atreyen cries, suddenly afraid.

A figure emerges from the darkness outside of the spotlights, walking up and onto the stage. They are dressed in a strange robe—the color of which Atreyen cannot place. A genderless green face peers at them from beneath a hood; in their hand is a large staff, topped with a black orb, green specks of light dancing within. It is the figure from the park—the one who smiled at them.

“Do not be afraid, Atreyen,” the figure says, their voice strange, sounding neither male nor female. It is beautiful to the ears.

“Oh, and why should I be afraid of some weirdo who watches kids in the dark?” They say, trying to sound brave. “What do you want? Who are you? I’m not in the mood for games… honey,”

The figure approaches and then stops; they are within reaching distance. Atreyen can see the stranger’s eyes; they match the orb at the top of the staff—black with dancing green lights, like the fireflies in summer they used to catch as a child.

“Who am I? You can call me Janus. As for what I want, I want to help you. I want to help you become who you were meant to be. I want to help free you from a world of constraints; it is holding you back from your true purpose.” The stranger says earnestly.

“It is—”

Double Trouble suddenly snapped out of the memory as something drew their attention. It was subtle, but they could feel it.

There was a strange little hand in one of their pockets!

* * *

Flit scanned the crowd currently coursing through the mega-market; the off-work cycle day was perfect for what she wanted to do. From the second floor of the tiered balcony, the little girl was able to peer down at the crowd on the main floor, giving her the height advantage needed to acquire a target.

Flit had spent the past two weeks living with her new patron—no, her friend—Panga, the experience turning her little life around for the better. Panga had given the little girl a warm, dry place to sleep at night, plus food, new clothes, and more importantly—kindness. It was the one key ingredient in Flit's life that the little girl realized she missed more than all those other creature comforts, be it a smile, kind words, or the many hours Panga spent brushing the tangles out of Flit's hair and fur.

Flit had flourished under Panga's care; it was almost like being with her mother again—but Flit thought that was funny, imagining Panga as someone's mother. Flit's mother had always been so gentle and peaceful. Even though Panga had shown her kindness and gentleness, Flit knew there was another side to the warrior woman—a harder side.

She knew Panga was from far away, from another world—much like Flit was—but the warrior woman's planet was called Elysia. She heard Panga refer to herself as a 'Star-Hunter,' telling Flit that she was sent to this planet to help people. Flit knew this to be true, for Panga had fought off all those thugs with such ease the night she was rescued.

Panga would be out most evenings and late into the night, helping people and performing heroic deeds. Usually, when Flit woke in

the morning, her friend would be asleep next to her, making a soothing purr-snore sound. The late afternoons were Flit's favorite, for that was when Panga woke up and spent time with her—but Flit was on her own for the majority of the day. She didn't mind, though; life was so much better with Panga around.

Flit had grown to care for Panga as much as Panga seemed to care about her, and Flit found that the more she was around Panga, the more she worried for her.

Some evenings when Panga woke, she seemed stiff, or when Flit ran to greet her with a hug, she would wince or stifle a hiss. The nightly forays were taking a toll on Panga's body, and on top of that, Panga had to share what little food she had with Flit, food that Panga's body desperately needed in order to get up every night and fight. The little girl did not know how Panga got the food or even how she had any money to pay for it, but she was sure that it was by honest means. If the warrior woman wanted to take what she needed, Flit knew she could; she just chose not to—Panga was just too good.

Flit had resolved not to sit by and watch Panga deteriorate; the little girl decided she would do something about it.

Having to take some pretty desperate measures to get by while living on the streets, Flit had learned some pretty unsavory skills. She found out pretty quickly that when you are small, people tend not to notice you. It was perfect for moving about large crowds and getting close enough to someone, reaching into their pockets to take whatever you wanted.

Flit became pretty good at pickpocketing; only her guilt kept her from doing it too often. The little girl didn't like having to steal, only doing it when absolutely necessary—like now. She would steal *just enough* to help secure more food for Panga, and that was it.

Well… maybe a few special treats for myself and something nice for Panga. A new outfit? Panga is always wearing the same thing

every day, that suit made of weird black and green stuff. Flit thought she continued to scan the crowd. *I don't know how it doesn't even stink; she never washes—*

Flit suddenly saw her target; it looked like a juicy one too—fancy and decadent. They were dressed outlandishly in a brown and green plaid jacket, shoulders, and arm-backs covered in bushy green fur. They were moving elegantly through the crowd, and Flit was unable to see their face covered by a large-brimmed sunhat.

They look like some kind of green fashion monster, she thought to herself, giggling.

Scampering on all fours towards the automatic stairway, Flit selected the one that went down, not bothering to wait for its movement as she dodged and weaved between people standing still. No one noticed the little girl as she exited the bottom of the stairs, zipping towards her quarry's last known location. Flit soon saw them, haggling for some commodity with a vendor. They were distracted, admiring their new purchase as she snuck up silently on little clawed feet.

Flit saw a long green tail sticking out of tight-fitting green pants—and as she got closer—spotted a pocket in the jacket, just barely out of reach. Lifting herself on her tail, the little girl slowly reached her hand up and into the pocket, nice and gently.

Abruptly something wrapped around her, making Flit squeak in terror. It was the tail, holding her fast as she was lifted up and around to gaze into a pair of green and yellow-slitted eyes.

"My, my, what do we have here?" They said in a voice that was neither male nor female. "Is it a little mouse? Looking for crumbs in my pocket, darling?"

They smiled at Flit, exposing two rows of sharp white teeth—like a predator.



In a fit of terror, Flit opened her mouth to bite the tail, but the appendage squeezed tighter—making her wheeze, gulping for air.

"Don't you even *dare* bite me, you *naughty* little creature." They scolded, loosening their grip minutely. Flit gasped, able to breathe now.

"Please let me go. I'm just hungry, looking for money to buy food." The little girl said. She had used this ploy before and usually worked, most likely because it was true. Well, it was true this time, but not *as* true as before.

"*Little liar*, I know when the truth is being told, that was just a half-truth. Try again." They said, eyes hooded and giving her a little squeeze for emphasis.

"Okay, okay, I want to be able to get more food for a friend. Someone who is helping me, who is kind and helps others. Someone who is too good to steal for themselves, even though it is what they need." Flit pleaded.

At this, a distant look on the stranger's green face, but it passed suddenly, leaving them to consider her thoughtfully. Then they smiled.

"Soooo… looking supplement your income, eh? Looking to make a little extra on the side? I can respect that. Good for you, darling!" They laughed, lowering the little girl and releasing her. Flit stared at them, not making a move. It was too good to be true.

"So… you're not going to eat me?" Flit asked in a small voice.

The stranger balked at this, eyes widening. "Oh, good heavens, no!" They cried, before making a 'bleh' sound.

"No, I have something better in mind for you. How would you like to make some money for yourself and your friend—without the stealing? You would work less—without having to worry about being caught—all the while making more in the process. What do you say, Little Mouse?"

Flit looked up at the scary stranger who tried to squeeze the breath out of her with their tail. She *did* try to steal from them,

and considering what others had tried to do to her when she was caught, being squeezed wasn't all that bad. There was something about them, underneath the façade of the outlandish clothing and their predatory appearance, that made Flit want to trust this person.

"Okay, I'm interested. Tell me more," Flit said in a small voice.

"Fantastic, my dear!" They said, beaming down at her. "And what is your name, Little Mouse?"

"It's Flit."

They gasped, bending at the waist towards her and holding their hands together next to their cheek.

"Oh, what a marvelously adorable little name!" They cried with a laugh. "I am Double Trouble, and I'm *so* pleased to meet you!"

* * *

The stranger—or Double Trouble—took Flit by taxi speeder to their abode, not too far from the mega-market, in a seedier part of the sector. Flit was familiar with the area, for she had been driven there by law enforcement when living on the streets. It was deep down between tall buildings, just above the city's substructure, tucked away and out of the rain.

A complicated drainage system twisted through the bowels of Thenlor, and by the time the collected rain had reached the level of Double Trouble's abode it had amassed into rivers. One of these vast drainage pipes discharged a torrent into an upward-facing spout, splashing the buildings and road nearby. Even though it looked disgusting, seeing the flowing water gave Flit a pang of homesickness for the huge clean, sparkling rivers of her home world.

Double Trouble directed her to the corner of a large building—there, a small shop was located. Large round windows ran in a line from the left of the entrance and extended around the corner.

By the front door hung a broken sign—what was once written or displayed upon it, Flit could determine, so marred it was by undercity filth and grime.

Upon entering the storefront, Flit spotted a glass counter in the center of the space, sad empty shelves lining its interior and an old machine at one end—once used to count and store currency. There were more shelves mounted on the walls of the store, but instead of products consumers would purchase, cobwebs and dust were the only items on offer. To cement the feeling of misery, the store smelled musty and was dimly lit by a pair of grimy, phosphorescent yellow lights.

"Come, come, my dear," Double Trouble said, walking around the glass counter and to a door frame covered by a curtain.

They pulled the drape aside with one hand and motioned for Flit to enter with their other hand, smiling sweetly at her. Flit gulped as she proceeded through.

It was a larger—and gloomier—room, lit by the same lights and surrounded by rigid, moist concrete walls. It was empty except for a large, rusty desk and a few chairs positioned in the middle of the space. On the desk were three large, black bags. They appeared to be nice-looking bags, too, made of shiny new leather with two large straps on either side of a closed zipper.

Double Trouble walked over to stand by the bags, gesturing for Flit to sit in one of the chairs. She did, looking at Double Trouble expectantly.

"I am something of a businessperson, my dear. I've been given the responsibility to sell a… product. A very… *nice* product that everyone is going to want to pay for." They started to explain.

"Like candy?" Flit asked, hopefully.

Double Trouble laughed, but without any mirth.

"Well… perhaps like candy. A very delicious candy that you would immediately want more of. It's called Sable, and these bags are full of it. But I have a problem. I need to sell all of this in two weeks, and I cannot do it myself. So that is where you come in." They said, pointing a long green finger at Flit before continuing.

"I need you to approach people and sell it to them. I need you to be my little salesperson. If you do this for me, you will be compensated. How does that sound? Perhaps you know of other little ones, like yourself, who would like to come work for me. Doesn't that sound nice? For each new employee you bring to me, you will be paid extra."

Flit's eyes widened—it sounded more than nice. It sounded fantastic. She could make enough for her and Panga to live like queens. Perhaps even get a real apartment to live in; the hideout Panga resided in was okay, but small and drafty. The utilities were not reliable, sometimes the hot water would be cold, and sometimes it would be billowing steam. Sometimes the lights didn't work, and they would have to sit in darkness.

Flit stopped her daydreaming, suddenly suspicious. "Can I see this product? She asked.

Double Trouble looked unsure for a moment before smiling brightly.

"Of course, honey!" They said, moving over to one of the bags.

Slowly—almost reluctantly—they opened the zipper and reached in. Removing their clenched fist, Double Trouble approached Flit and opened their hand, face up, offering it to her. Resting upon their green palm was a shiny, black stone—like a chipped piece of black glass. Flit took it from them, inspecting the object—it was cold as ice.

"What does it do?" She asked, cocking her head.

"Well, you are supposed to hold it up to the light and try and look through it. When you do that, something nice happens." Double

Trouble said in a whisper.

Encouraged by this, Flit held it up towards one of the dirty lights and squinted, peering through it.

“Like this?” She asked.

Suddenly Double Trouble’s eyes widened, and they lunged toward her.

“NO!” They screeched, snatching the Sable out of her hand. Flit squeaked as she jumped off the chair to hide behind it, staring at Double Trouble with fear in her eyes.

Regaining their composure, Double Trouble smiled down at her.

“I’m sorry, but you mustn’t use the Sable, you will… ruin it. Each one is very precious and expensive. Do you understand, Little Mouse? I’m sorry to have frightened you so,” They said, seeming genuinely sorrowful, putting Flit back at ease.

Double Trouble gathered more of the Sable from the bigger bag and took out a small black sack, filling it with the stones. They tied a drawstring, closing the bag, and held it out to Flit.

“What do you say, Flit? Partners?” They asked, hopefully.

Flit took the proffered bag.

* * *

The Imp watched the little girl leave with a mixture of relief and trepidation. Relief for they made some headway in their infrastructure problem; Flit will tell other greedy little children who will come scurrying to work for the Imp, basically doing all the labor for them.

But Double Trouble remembered how terrified they felt when Flit was about to use the piece of Sable—*why had they feel like that?* They had lied when they said it was rare and expensive, for they

had no idea as to if it was rare, and its monetary value was yet to be determined. Double Trouble remembered the feeling after the intense rush of pleasant emotions—the *taking*. Were they horrified by the idea of that happening to the little girl? There were thousands of shards of Sable in those bags. The Imp planning on having that happen to more people than just one small, inconsequential child, especially if they wanted to make a profit.

They shook their head. *Don't be weak, Atreyen, don't be delicate. You never did like children anyway; why would you care about this one?*

It was true that Double Trouble had never been a fan of children, but that was because it made them think of being a child themselves and how hard childhood was for them. Their childhood was full of suppression—their overbearing mother, always scolding them to be normal and proper little girl.

That was until… that day… when I was finally free.

The Imp smiled and remembered when they first felt bliss.

Chapter End Notes

Illustration by Henar Torinos, a.k.a. ilikeyoucatradora on Instagram and Twitter.

Transition

Chapter Summary

> Many years ago and in an entirely different realm, a cast-out child was given a chance to escape their prison and realize their ultimate dreams.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Many years ago, and in a dimension separate from the one Etheria currently resides in…

It was oppressive and hot as Atreyen walked down the sidewalk towards home, on their way back from an especially hard day at school. Whoever had seen their kiss with Yikka last night wasted no time in informing the entire school of their transgressions. Atreyen had received even more antagonistic stares and whispers than usual, catching the terms 'weird' and 'freak' as they were spoken of a little more boldly than usual—even Atreyen's teachers seemed outwardly hostile to them. The worst part of their whole experience today was their brief interaction with Yikka.

Atreyen had finally caught up with her in the hallway, between classes, trying to get in and out of her locker as fast as possible. They were so happy to see her; if Atreyen only had Yikka on their side surrounded by a whole world that despised them, they could live with that.

FAR AWAY

"Yikka?" Atreyen said as they placed a hand tentatively on her shoulder. "Are you okay?"

Yikka stiffened at their touch, acting as if it burned her—then cringed. She would not look at them, just stared into her locker, her head tilted down.

“Yikka, it’ll be okay, I promise. I deal with this kind of thing all the time.” Atreyen implored.

Her head swayed towards them, and Atreyen could tell that Yikka had been crying—probably ever since she ran out of the auditorium last night. Her eyes were haunted, filled with infinite sadness.

“I don’t want to get used to it,” she mumbled in a small voice before closing her locker—then turning to walk away.

Atreyen had felt the center of their chest turn to ice as their heart broke, watching Yikka leave them, not looking back. They would never see her again.

Clenching their fists, Atreyen continued down the sidewalk, not just in sadness and hopelessness—but now in anger.

Yikka was my friend, my… and she turned on me? How is this possible? I thought we would be inseparable... they thought as tears formed in their eyes. Atreyen had hoped— foolishly, it seemed now—that they and Yikka would run away together, away from this town, to one of the big cities where people like them seemed to be more accepted. But Yikka was going nowhere with them; she wanted nothing to do with them.

BREAK-UP

Stomping past their neighbor’s houses, Atreyen suddenly shrieked in fury—faces instantly turned towards the sound as curtains were drawn aside, everyone interested in observing the spectacle currently in their midst. None were surprised when they learned who it was— *the freak*.

“I HATE YOU ALL!!!” Atreyen screamed at the watchers, running as fast as they could towards their home, trying to escape the judging stares.

Atreyen burst through their front door, and in their anger, tripped on the rug, falling flat on their face. Wincing, they lifted

themselves to their hand and knees—looking up—Atreyen noticed both of their parents sitting on the couch, their mother and the father they rarely saw. He was usually too busy working at his engineering job to spend time with them—it must be important if their father was there. Important and very bad.

"Mom! Dad! Are you waiting for me?" Atreyen asked, but they already knew the answer. They immediately recognized that their mother had been crying, something she rarely did—usually when she was very disappointed or frustrated with them.

"We got a call from the school today, Atreya. They said you were seen in the auditorium last night, doing something… *obscene* with your friend, Yikka," their mother stated calmly. "Is this true?"

The rage came boiling back up at the mention of Yikka.

"Yes! But you don't have to worry about her anymore. We are not friends anymore." Atreyen said, scorn and fury in their voice.

Their mother burst into tears, burying her face in their father's chest. He looked at Atreyen with anger—anger plus maybe a little hatred. They suddenly felt afraid, very afraid, as if true fear had never really been felt before. Their father did not say a word as he continued to blaze into them with his yellow eyes.

Finally raising her head, their mother stifled her tears as their father looked at her—both nodding at the other.

"Atreya, please just go to your room. I will bring your dinner later, and I want you to stay there until morning." Their mother said calmly.

Fear rose in Atreyen's chest.

"Why? What are you going to do with me?" They asked cautiously.

"What we should have done with you a long time ago," their father coldly replied.

Suddenly it struck them—they knew what was happening—and Atreyen leaped to their feet.

"NO!" They shrieked. "You're not sending me to the Conversion Center!"

The Conversion Center was a place their parents had been threatening to send them for a while now, where 'different' and 'strange' people were sent to be 'set straight.' Atreyen had heard the horror stories—starvation, forced medication, shock therapy, and even brain modification surgery. It was a death sentence for them, for they would rather die than change who they were.

"How could you possibly think about doing this to me? You're my parents! You are supposed to care about me!" Atreyen screamed.

"Who are you to dare tell us what we are supposed to do as your parents?" Their father said, cold fury in his voice.

Their mother was crying again as she stood up and walked to Atreyen, placing her hand on their cheek almost tenderly.

"This is for your own good, Atreya. We are doing this because we love you." She said earnestly.

The fury came back, suppressing the fear.

"YOU DON'T LOVE ME! I HATE YOU!" They screamed, slapping their mother in the face.

Their mother stumbled backward, holding the cheek Atreyen had just struck, surprise in her eyes.

"You hit me? You hit me..." She gawked as if trying to wrap her head around the concept before the cold fury returned to their mother's eyes. "You've always been trouble for me. You've *always* been trouble," she said evenly and without emotion.

Atreyen laughed at this statement. "You said 'trouble' twice, mother. Why don't you just call me *Double Trouble*?" They

snarled.

Her mother hissed in annoyance.

"Double the trouble and a smart mouth. Just go to your room. I don't want to even look at you." She dismissed, turning her back on her child.

Atreyen tried to bolt for the door, but their father was already on his feet, leaping towards them to catch them by the shoulder to pull them back. He slapped Atreyen soundly, making them momentarily see stars as they fell to the ground—stunned. Picking them up roughly, their father tossed them over his shoulder as he began to walk towards the stairs and to their room.

Atreyen began kicking and screaming, beating their fists into his back—but he only held them tighter for it. Stomping up the stairs and through the hall, their father practically threw them into their room to bounce off their dresser, giving them a long cut on their arm before falling to the floor.

Screaming in rage, Atreyen leaped to their feet just as the door slammed in their face—trying to open it—they found it wouldn't budge; their parents must have placed a lock on the outside, foreseeing this outcome. Atreyen tried the window next, only to discover that bars had been installed on the inside—they yanked on them with all their strength—but the metal rods wouldn't budge. Their father must have put them recently as well.

Atreyen ran back to the door, slamming their body into it repeatedly until finally—battered, bruised, and out of breath—they fell to the floor, gasping.

It was over. They were trapped, and come morning, their life was over. Atreyen curled up into a ball, wrapping their long tail around themselves as they cried themselves into unconsciousness.

DESOLATION

* * *

Atreyen… wake up…

Atreyen…

…wake…UP!

Atreyen opened their eyes—it was gloomy in their room; phosphorescent light from streetlights outside made their normally cozy space appear nightmarish. They always hated the amber lights; they made the world around them seem duller and drained of life.

Atreyen whined as they pushed up into a sitting position. They were so unbelievably sore—on top of the violence done to them by their father—they had almost broken bones from throwing themselves against the door. Atreyen moved backward on their rear until they could rest their back on the dresser with a groan.

What am I going to do? They thought miserably. *I have to get out of here. It can't end like this.*

Suddenly their ears popped, reminding them of flying on an airship; Atreyen stuck a finger in one of their long, green ears, trying to relieve the feeling of pressure—but then they heard it—a faint voice, like a whisper.

"*Atreyen…*"

Atreyen felt a jolt through their core, wondering if they were going mad. With the day they just had, who would blame them?

"*Atreyen…*"

Atreyen suddenly felt brave, for what did they have to lose?

"Hello? I can hear you. Where are you?" They responded into the darkness.

In one of the corners of the room, where the shadows seemed to collect and sit like a pool, two green eyes flashed, making Atreyen

gasp. A figure appeared, walking slowly out of the dark; they were hooded and robed, holding a staff with an orb at the top. A genderless face gazed upon them with black eyes—green motes dancing in the inky orbs.

It was the stranger who haunted their steps.

"Janus!" Atreyen exclaimed in surprise, a touch of hope in their voice.

The last time Atreyen had seen this stranger, Janus had offered them something obscure. They had talked about freedom, and at the time, it sounded crazy to Atreyen. Why would they listen to some weird person who showed up in the middle of the night in a school auditorium? Atreyen had left Janus and their offer behind—but that was then, and this was now. *Now*... they were desperate.

"Have you thought about my offer, Atreyen?" Janus said, gazing down at them.

"Can you help me get out of here?" Atreyen asked hopefully. "My parents are sending me away to a horrible place!"

Janus nodded. "I know, my child. I know. This world is so blinded by the limitations it places on itself, your parents and all the other grownups here are victims of their environment. Their children end up being the greatest victims of all." They said sorrowfully.

Atreyen looked back at them, confused. "So… is that a yes? No? … Maybe?"

Janus just laughed in reply, adding to Atreyen's confusion and making them suddenly think of an old story. It was from their world's one religion, about a person claiming to give enlightenment only to lead the unwary to damnation.

"Why are you here, Janus?" Atreyen asked, a little suspicious.

Janus' eyes flashed at this, and their smile widened.

“To help you, of course! To help children, whenever and wherever I can. I am the keeper of a… *power*,” they say, indicating the sphere at the top of their staff, “And I use this power to travel the realms of every existence*, seeking*. Upon entering your realm, I sensed you and decided to help.”

Atreyen felt hopeful but tried to be cautious.

“But why me? What makes me so special?”

“Because you’re a kindred soul to mine, one who longs to be free. More importantly, I sense your pure and good heart. It longs to love and to be loved, as is the wont of all, young and old. I would like to give you a part of my power. It will free you, and someday, you will use it to help free others.” Janus explained.

“What is this power? Is it good? Is it evil?” Atreyen asked, still thinking of the old religious stories.

Janus rocked their head from side to side, pursing their lips.

“It’s neither good nor evil. It’s up to the bearer to choose how it is used. That’s why I selected you, for I know you will use this power well.”

Janus tipped their staff forward so the green-glittering ball on the top was held out towards Atreyen.

“This,” Janus said meaningfully, “Is the Orb of Entropy, and I am its bearer. It is my ward.”

Atreyen gazed at the orb, the green lights dancing within had no pattern in their movement, no reason—they just followed the course of their desires. Mesmerized, Atreyen tentatively reached up to the orb, but Janus pulled it back slightly.

“If you choose this course, Atreyen, you will be leaving your old life behind, your family, friends, and everything you know. Nothing will ever be the same. Is that what you want, my child?” Janus warned.

Atreyen didn’t answer, only reaching now with pure intent, almost desperate to touch the orb. They placed both of their hands upon it, their long green fingers wrapping around its mass.

There was an immediate feeling of being pulled, of being absorbed but also absorbing.

There was a flash of green—

—then there was nothing.

* * *

BULBFORM

Leaving, moving upwards, they look down at a home nestled amongst many lookalikes. They turn away, feeling no sadness as they pass through a barrier.

Atmosphere

They continue, passing three huge round balls. They are moons—they recognize them somehow. They continue traveling, increasing speed, passing other round balls, all dancing around a burning orb. They pass through another barrier.

Solar system

Their speed increases even more, lights zip past them—other burning orbs that are far away, many with their own round balls. They hope that none of these balls is anything like the one they left. They continue, passing through another barrier.

Galaxy

They see infinite darkness, and looking back, a lovely misty swirl behind them, getting smaller and smaller in the distance. Somehow, they know they are moving faster than before, even though there is no real frame of reference in all that blackness. That is, until other misty objects appear, like the one they left

behind. They all seem to be coalescing into one configuration as they get farther away. This form is of a large, round sphere. Another barrier is crossed.

Universe

Speeding up so incredibly fast now, a flash of white light and then colors—all the colors of the rainbow—plus others of unknown description, all streaking by in a kaleidoscope of wonder. They pass yet another barrier.

Time

And then soon after, another.

Dimension

They are now somewhere outside of everything. They perceive their surroundings by neither touch, sight, sound, smell, or any other mortal sense—yet they have an even greater sense of where they are. They can perceive it better for is directly felt in their very soul. They are in a place of magic—chaos—of infinite possibilities and change. They are where they were always meant to be, and they take it into themselves, making it ***them****. They transition. They are free. They float—drift—feeling their new being drawn out of the place of entropy, back towards their origin point.*

No, I'm not going back.

But they sense other places, other possibilities, and one in particular pulls at them more than others. They choose and move in that direction, passing through the barrier.

Dimension

And then.

Time

Their new location is completely different than the one they left. They are in a place of strange swirling mist, the color of shimmering blues, reds, and purples. They are moving fast, but their speed slowly decreases, and an object comes into focus. It is a large, beautiful ball—swirling white clouds cover a lush landscape surrounded by a blue ocean. There are twelve smaller balls of various sizes surrounding this ball, orbiting it in a perfect dance. They pass through a barrier.

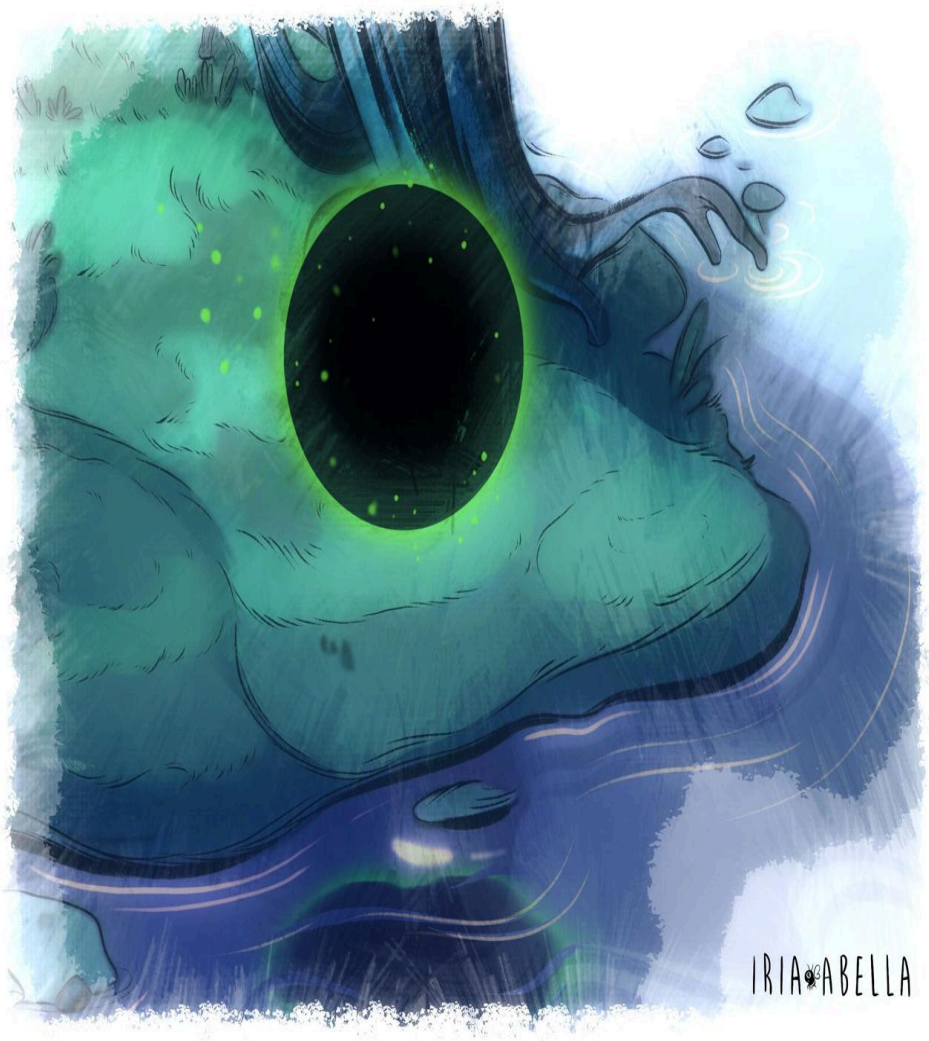
Atmosphere

They reach their destination.

* * *

After a brief moment of disorientation, Atreyen found themselves floating above a bed of lush green mossy grass. Somehow, they were now able to perceive all directions simultaneously, discerning a beautiful forest all around them. Continuing to float in the air, they began to move towards a small pond as insects danced in multicolored clouds about them. Reaching the pool, Atreyen discovered a small herd of bipedal creatures drinking nearby, completely undisturbed by the presence of the strange being in their midst. One of the smaller ones, an adolescent, even approached and sniffed Atreyen—but then snorted and turned away, returning to lap at the cool water with a long pink tongue. Focusing their expansive gaze upon the mirror surface of the pool, Atreyen was immediately shocked by the image reflected back out at them.

They were not much bigger than the animals nearby, in the shape of an orb—just like the orb on the top of Janus' staff, all black with green motes dancing within.



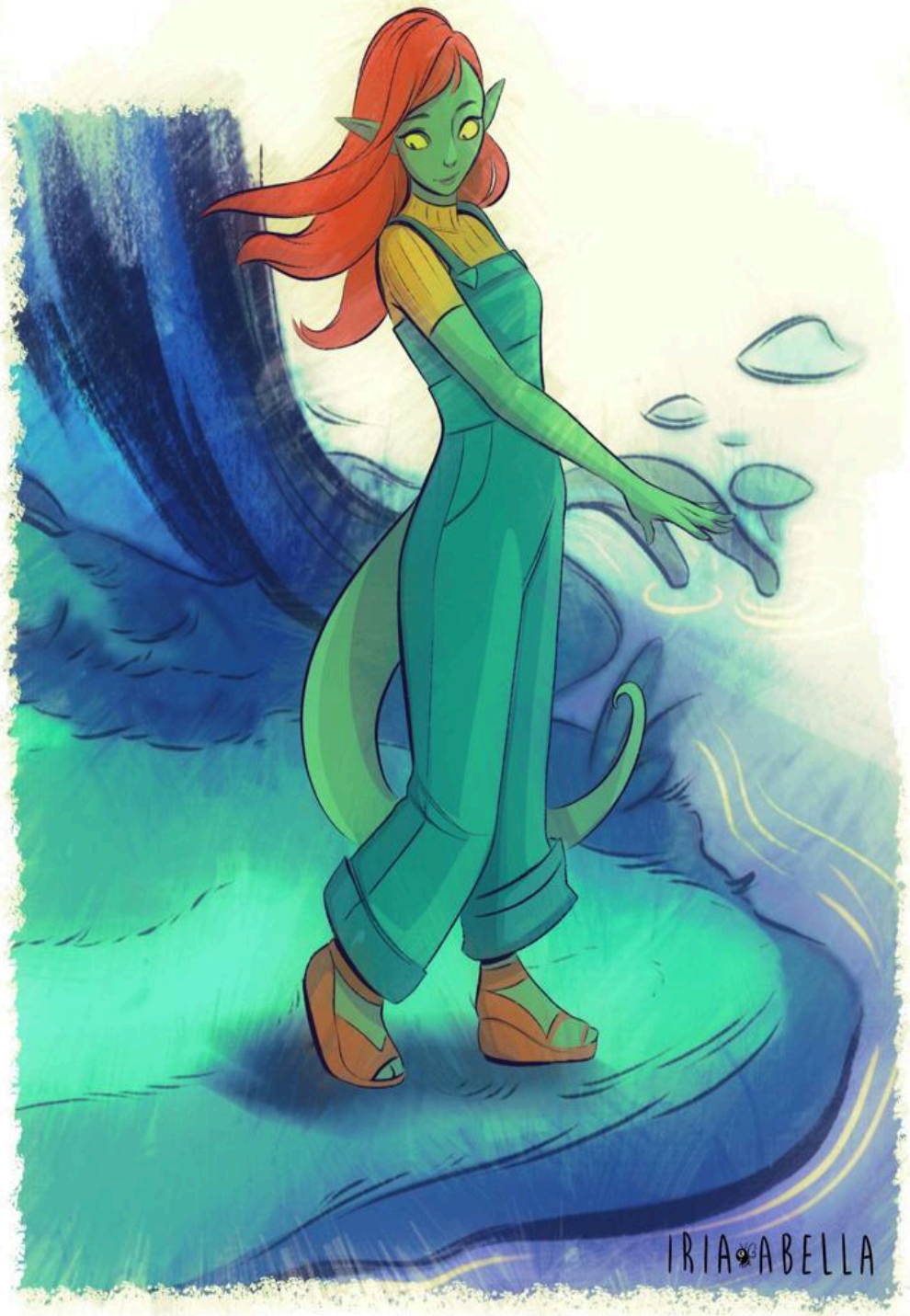
What did Janus do to me? Atreyen thought, now panicking. Janus must have tricked them, and just like the old religious stories warned, they were damned now.

No! No! No! They yelled internally, for without a mouth, how could they scream?

Even though they hated their old appearance, Atreyen suddenly focused on it, wishing to see their old countenance. The contours of their round shape suddenly wavered and shrunk into itself—Atreyen panicked, losing their train of thought—and the outline solidified back into the perfect orb.

I did that, didn't I? Because I was thinking of my old body. If I concentrate again, maybe I can…

Focusing on their familiar appearance, they willed their aspect to change, and when their outline started to waver and shrink again, they focused harder. Atreyen's outline shimmered and flexed, finally taking the form they remembered. Once the outline was complete, their green skin, red hair, slitted eyes, and clothes appeared, and the black with the dancing green lights subsumed into nothingness. They were back to their old self.


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“Never thought I would be happy to see this face again,” Atreyen said ruefully to their reflection.

Then a thought struck them. They remembered being in the place of magic, of entropy, of infinite possibilities. *Why do I have to settle for this old body?* Atreyen considered.

They concentrated again, now remembering Janus’ appearance—the genderless quality of it. They mixed it with some of their features, for they did not want to become Janus—they wanted to become *them*.

Their mass became the now familiar transitional black with green lights, and their outline changed. Their hips became a little slighter, their chest receded, and they gained a little height. The transitional aspect disappeared, and Atreyen’s heart leaped at the image reflected.

A truly genderless face, neither male nor female, looked back at them. They grinned like a fool at themselves, showing off all their sharp teeth.


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"Marvelous," they whispered in a voice that was like their own, only slightly more masculine. Then they grimaced as they looked up at their red hair.

"Mmmm… need to do something about this hair… but I think I will wait for some inspiration," Atreyen said thoughtfully.

* * *

Atreyen had been walking through the beautiful forest for some time, still trying to wrap their mind around this strange new place they found themselves in. It was so vibrant and colorful, the sky a deep blue—though seemingly without a sun to light it. The air was sweet, rich, and full of promise—the scents summoning different pleasant emotions within Atreyen, some they could not place a finger on.

When Atreyen had finally gotten hungry, they found a strange, purple fruit nearby. It was ripe and appeared appetizing, and they picked it easily. Staring at it in their hand, they were surprised that they felt unconcerned with whether it was edible or not. Atreyen took a bite—it was delicious and juicy, and the meat of the fruit had filled their hungry stomach. When they were thirsty, they drank from a stream nearby; it's cool water was immensely satisfying, quenching Atreyen's thirst.

There was something so inviting about this new place. It was so… *kind*, and behind it all, they sensed it—*magic*. It surrounded Atreyen; it was in the ground, the air, the trees, and the air they breathed. It was wonderful! They could feel the magic, for it resonated with the magic that was now within them since their transition into their new being.

Atreyen let out a cry of pure joy as they started to skip through the woods, completely carefree for once in their life.

Night came, and Atreyen found a comfy patch of moss to lay upon. They settled into it upon their back, completely undisturbed by any creature as they gazed through a break in the trees to the

night sky above. Two unknown moons cast soft light upon Atreyen's supine form as they faded into a sweet sleep.

Morning appeared as a sweet, warm glow, and after a lazy stretch and a long yawn, they continued their wandering, completely unconcerned with whether or not they found anyone.

That was when Atreyen stumbled upon the town.

In a broad clearing, odd-looking houses were clustered around a large building in the shape of a gigantic, curled-over leaf—under this tent-like canopy—a solid purple wall was erected, two doors acting as the primary ingress.

As Atreyen made their way to the entrance, a commotion could be heard from within; lively music was playing, the sound of which was mixed with voices raised in merriment. Atreyen tentatively opened the doors, gasping at what they witnessed inside.

Strange beings were dancing and singing within—it was some kind of party. The people were like nothing Atreyen had ever seen before; they had noseless faces, and above their large eyes, two gossamer appendages swept up from soft brows—like wings. The people's skin color varied from pink to light purple to peach, and each was dressed in their own style.

The music stopped abruptly as every single occupant turned to the newcomer, surprise written on their beautiful faces. Atreyen stood stock-still, not knowing what to do. After an awkward pause, they spoke.

"Uh, hello? Can I come in and join you?" Atreyen asked timidly.

"Of course! Welcome to Elberon!" An older woman greeted.

She walked over to Atreyen with arms outstretched, the others returning to their merrymaking as the stranger was integrated into their number. These people were completely unconcerned by Atreyen's foreign appearance—as if the arrival of people alien to

themselves was a daily occurrence. Atreyen liked the thought of that.

“Come, come, stranger, sit with me. Get off your feet and rest. You must be exhausted from your long journey.” The woman gestured to a nearby table. Atreyen sat across from her as the woman took a seat, snapping her fingers.

“Flutterina! We have a guest! Get over here and get them some food and drink. They must be thirsty and starved!” The woman called.

Something about what she said caught Atreyen’s attention.

“Wait a second… did you just refer to me as ‘they’ and ‘them’?” They asked in shock.

The woman made an incredulous expression.

“Yeah… why, is there something wrong with that?”

Atreyen smiled. “No, honey, there is nothing wrong with that at all. Where am I? What is this wondrous place called?”

The woman looked at them, confused. “Didn’t I tell you? It's Elberon.”

“This whole place is Elberon? The entire planet?” Atreyen asked in wonder.

The woman shook her head, her brow wings bobbing.

“Nooo… our town is called Elberon. The planet is called Etheria.” Suddenly she looked suspicious. “Wait, you’re not one of the invaders, are you? Are you from the Horde?”

Atreyen looked confused, not knowing what ‘The Horde’ meant.

The woman continued, prompted by Atreyen’s confusion.

“You know... The Horde? They showed up half a year ago, saying they were going to take over the planet?”

Atreyen shook their head no, still a little confused.

The woman shrugged, moving on. “Well, so anyway, I’m the Mayor around here, and you can just call me that or by my name, Lydia. What can I address you as?”

Atreyen thought on this, feeling reluctant to give their actual name. Their real name was a part of their past, and they wanted to bury that deep within themselves.

This place was new, a place to start over. They needed a new name, and for some reason, their mind seized on the last words they had spoken to their mother. Words that had been spoken cruelly and meant to hurt them—but Atreyen was done being hurt by those they thought had cared for them. They would take their mother’s hateful words and garb themselves in them, creating an outer shell of armor in which to protect their wounded heart.

Atreyen smiled.

“You can call me Double Trouble, my dear.”

Chapter End Notes

Illustrations were done by Iria, a.k.a. ilikeyoucatradora, on Tumblr and Instagram.

Author's note - the song 'A Warm Place' by NIN has a meaning to me—I would not say it has a special meaning since the memory is not great. I had been kicked out of my house (one of many times) and was walking from school on my way to this rented room I was staying at in town. It was the dead of winter, and as I walked away from school, I listened to this song on a Walkman (yep, I know). There was a field nearby, and the wind had gathered up the snow into a small cyclone to spin across the crystalline white surface of

the ground---the experience perfectly encapsulating the feeling of complete desolation I felt as an unwanted child.

Also, the scenes of violence Atreyen underwent at the hands of their father may seem rough, but that was an actual experience that I had. I feel that gives me the right to put it into my story.

Candy Cane

Chapter Summary

> Just as they are getting thier first taste of success, new problems appear on the horizon for Double Trouble.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Leaning over the countertop of their recently refurbished storefront, Double Trouble flipped through the pages of one of Thenlor's numerous fashion magazines. This part of their new business—'maintaining appearances'—was so dull for them, and any silly diversion was appreciated. Spying a delicious new fashion, the Imp unconsciously stuck out their tongue, twirling their hair while humming an old show tune.

As part of 'maintaining appearances,' Double Trouble had changed their personal attire to one that was much more in keeping with the storefront. Out of their sleek and glossy pants and jacket, they now wore a skintight white jumpsuit composed of a singular design—a uniform red spiral running from the tips of their boots to the top of a floppy chef's hat. Besides their tail, which was a copy of the jumpsuit, their skin and hair color changed to match the color of the red stripe. The entire effect made them appear as if they were one big piece of candy—which was perfect—for their new storefront was, in fact, a candy store.

Flit was a fabulous employee for Double Trouble—not only did she sell her weight in Sable, but had found thirteen other children interested in working for them. All combined, the efforts of the new workers exceeded all the expectations placed on the Imp, bringing in double the profits, and earning a bonus for them. This, plus Double Trouble's cut in the profit, enabled them to spruce up their property substantially.

Double Trouble had sealed up the leaky walls in the main work area behind the storefront and installed high-tech lights, bringing a much needed radiance to the gloomy space. They had purchased long tables and placed them in the newly redecorated work area; they were perfect for the proper organization and packaging of the product, which the children took turns doing when they were not out selling.

The apartment connected to the workspace was where Double Trouble put the most effort. Besides replacing the lighting, they had the walls covered with paper decorated in chic designs. Plush carpeting was added, and the bed was replaced with a much larger canopy version, with as many pillows as they could physically place there. Other creature comforts were purchased, adding to the luxury of Double Trouble's personal area—scented misters, decadent music players, and, of course, mirrors.

It took a day for Double Trouble to figure out what to do with the storefront. When Flit and the rest of the little workers came piling through the front door at the end of the day, the thought struck them; what kind of place always had children coming and going?

A candy shop!

The Imp had the walls painted in sickeningly bright colors and the glass counter filled with fudge and bonbons. The dusty and cobwebbed shelves were thoroughly cleaned, making them the perfect accommodation for other goodies. Last but not least, the obscure sign by the front door was replaced by one touting the store's name in neon pink—*Delicious Trouble*. The entire effect was very pleasing and unassuming to the eye, and Double Trouble was now the proud owner of a candy shop.

Now was when Double Trouble's 'Little Mice' started coming back—pockets full of currency. It was the Imp's favorite time of day, as the children would dump their earnings on the back table, forming a pile, which Double Trouble would run their greedy green fingers through.

By their association with money, Double Trouble was also starting to grow fond of the 'Little Mice'—something they never thought would happen. They would pat the youngters on the head, giving each one a treat from the shop before leaving for the day. Double Trouble would even let some of the children sleep in the main work area when the rain was especially hard, making little nests for them out of the large packaging containers that the candy was shipped in.

Maybe I should get them little beds, or bunk beds. That ground is so cold back there, they thought as they absentmindedly stuck their long prehensile tongue out, snatching a bonbon from behind the glass counter and drawing it into their razor-toothed maw.

Abruptly, the door opened forcefully, making the little bell above it chime with a piercing ring. Double Trouble looked up with surprise—which then turned into a smile.

"You know, you shouldn't be sampling your own goods, Fancy Pants Lizard," Canens grunted, crossing her beefy arms over a broad chest.

Double Trouble beamed. "Oh, hi daring, long time, no see," they cooed.

Canens smiled back at them. She had grown to like the 'Fancy Pants Lizard' after observing how well they handled themselves during the heist at Xayide's penthouse.

Canens had been given her own sector to run, as had Tibernus and Fontus, who ran the same one together. None of them had the same success as Double Trouble, but there were no hard feelings, especially from Fontus and Tibernus. If not for Double Trouble, Fontus would still be in the unkind clutches of Xayide. He owed the Imp.

Canens glanced around the candy shop while Double Trouble twirled their hair, her gaze coming to a rest on the red and white Imp before her. She shook her head, mirth written on her face.

Double Trouble leaned on the counter, placing their chin in their hand.

"Notice anything you like, honey?" They asked innocently.

Canens let out a bark of laughter. "No—I don't. Not a thing."

Double Trouble shrugged. "Well, what can I do for you, my dear? I'm sure you're not here for chit-chat."

Canens nodded, a more serious look on her face. "Yes, well—"

Before she could continue, the door opened again, and Flit entered. The little girl immediately halted upon spotting Canens, eyes widening as she took in the size of the woman. It didn't help matters that the intimidating Canens was not hiding her annoyance at being interrupted.

"My *darling* Little Mouse!" Double Trouble cried, coming around the counter to squat down next to the little girl. "My most profitable employee! Oh, don't mind Canens here, darling—she is an old friend," they soothed, trying to put Flit at ease. Canens was not helping with the look of disgust on her face.

"I hate children," the muscular woman said flatly.

Double Trouble gasped, placing their hands over Flit's ears protectively.

"NO! *Good heavens!* Not in front of my *darling* Flit. Shame on you, woman!"

Canens shrugged and turned away, looking at some rainbow-colored sugar candy on a nearby shelf.

Double Trouble held their hand out, palms up as Flit rummaged through her little pockets—finally pulling out a fist full of Thenlorian currency and depositing it into the Imp's waiting hands.

“Very lovely, darling, oh how wonderful! You outdid yourself! You may pick out *two* treats today!” Double Trouble exclaimed happily.

Flit beamed and scampered behind the counter—Canens turning from her inspection of the merchandise to watch the interplay between Flit and Double Trouble. She cocked her head, narrowing her eyes as Flit came back with two large hunks of fudge.

“One for me and one for Panga!” She said happily.

Double Trouble put a finger to their lips.

“You really should bring your friend around to visit, Flit. I would like to meet this Panga. Maybe she would like a job, too?”

Flit’s eyes widened at this prospect. “Uh… no, I don’t think so, Double Trouble. Actually, I have to get going, she is going to wake up soon, and I want to be there when she does.” Flit said, nervousness plain in her voice.

Double Trouble shrugged. “Okay, Little Mouse, run along now, and I will see you tomorrow,”

Flit nodded, and before the little girl scurried out the door, she turned to wave back at her employer.

“See you tomorrow, Double Trouble!” She sang happily. Her eyes widened when she turned to Canens, the woman scrutinizing the little girl with a hardness in her eyes. Flit spun, bolting through the door—and was gone.

“You weren’t very nice, Canens, my dear,” Double Trouble said with a hint of reproach.

“Who do you think this ‘Panga’ is? Someone we have to worry about? She could be part of Xayide’s crew.” She said suspiciously.

Double Trouble waved their hand dismissively. “No, we won't have to worry about her. Probably just some single mother trying to

make ends meet. Not likely to show up and cause problems for me."

* * *

Panga woke with a groan.

"Unnnn… that time already?" She hissed out loud.

Sitting up slowly, Panga rubbed at her tender side.

How did I get this bruise? I'm starting to forget where I get these injuries from. They all seem to—Oh, that's right! I was hit by a shock-maul last night! I'm getting sloppy, the warrior woman thought ruefully.

Continuing on that train of thought, Panga could feel herself slowly wearing down over time. Her battle injuries were adding up and not given the proper time to heal, causing Panga to be in pain all the time and weakening much-needed fighting skills. But she could not take a night off—wouldn't even consider it.

Am I trying to kill myself? Panga thought—but dismissed it right away. She had Flit to take care of—a child who needed her.

Well, I think we need each other, actually. If it weren't for Flit and her job at the candy shop, I probably would have run out of food and driven myself to exhaustion, she thought, suddenly feeling guilty that the little girl was working.

Panga had tried to dissuade her, but Flit was stubborn and left their hideout against her friend's wishes to go to her job. Panga eventually gave in—for how could she fault someone wanting to help? It was good the little girl had something to occupy her while Panga slept. She just hoped Flit was being careful when she walked the streets of Thenlor, on her way to and from whatever this job was.

Panga stood slowly out of bed, placing her hands on her lower back and leaning backward in a stretch. After giving her

hindquarters a good scratching, she cast about for any sign of Flit.

"Flit?" She called out. There was no answer.

Hmm… that girl has been working later and later, she thought, starting to pick up small pairs of pants and shirts. *Leaving a mess, too.*

As she was leaning over to scoop up another stray article of clothing, Panga spied a black sack under the bed. Curious, she got on all fours to reach for the bag, extracting it from beneath the mattress frame. As Panga sat down to inspect the small package, she hefted it with one hand, feeling the weight. It made a sharp sound—like pieces of glass knocking together.

Is this some kind of rock collection? I remember Chhaya liked to do things like that. Panga thought as she untied the drawstring, overturning the bag into her hand. Five black stones fell out, like chipped pieces of obsidian, making her hand feel cold—like she wasn't holding stones but pieces of ice.

"Strange..." she said, picking up one of the strange objects. Holding it between her index and thumb claw, Panga held it up to the light, trying to discern whether it was translucent or not.

She instantly gasped.

A mother's gentle touch, a first kiss, a first love, induction into the Star Hunters under the Great Chailendra Tree, Maira's passionate embrace, Chhaya's arrival…

Panga shut her eyes and moaned, dropping the stones as she hugged herself. It felt so good to feel those old memories—those old emotions—but also so intensely sad. Panga began crying as she reached for the stones again.

But before Panga could touch them, she caught sight of her tail—sweeping back and forth behind her—on the ground in wide arcs. But that was not what caught her attention—no, it was the fact it

was twice its normal size; the cream and brown striped fur was standing completely on end.

A good Star Hunter always listens to her tail, Panga's mentor once said. *Ignore what your tail is telling you at your own peril.*

Something was terribly wrong, and somewhere deep inside herself, Panga knew it. She picked up one of the smooth chips again, and keeping it away from the light, studied it intently.

It was so frigid that it made the bones in her fingers ache. She sniffed it. No discernible scent could be detected, but there was something there, something she could just barely sense… it was familiar… like when she was fighting the Shen'Aan-war's acolytes.

Death Binders. Evil.

Panga felt the fur on her shoulders stand on end, just like when she was in the presence of the Death Binders—the Shen'Aan-war's sorcerer caste. The users of Death Magic. These obsidian chips were fragments of something… something horrible. Worst of all, Flit was involved in it.

Oh, Flit, what have you gotten yourself into? Panga thought as she picked the shards up, one by one, placing them back into the little sack.

Panga was raising herself stiffly with the bag still in her hand when her long ears perked—there was a scrabbling behind the cracked plaster of the wall. By the delicate sounds of small claws scratching old plaster, the feline warrior could tell it was Flit who was approaching.

It wasn't long before the little girl appeared through a hole in the wall—the one she used to get in and out of their shared living space. There were no entrances to the Panga's hideout —it was sealed from the rest of the building—just as the warrior woman liked it.

“Hey, Panga, I got you a treat!” The little girl cried—but abruptly halted when she spotted her friend standing there, holding the black bag.

“*Uh—hey*, Panga, I’ve been looking for that. Can I get it back?” Flit said, trying and failing to disguise her anxiety. The little girl approached Panga with her hand held out, but the woman held it out of the girl's reach; it was then that Flit noticed Panga’s tail sweeping back and forth—out of distress or irritation. Or both.

“Panga? What's wrong? They’re just stones.” Flit said innocently.

Is she lying to me? Panga thought incredulously, then out loud, “Have you been using these, Flit?”

The little girl shook her head emphatically.

“NO! Double Trouble said to not—” She started, then stopped herself from continuing, dropping the fudge and placing both her hands tight lips. She stared at Panga, eyes wide.

“Who is Double Trouble? Wait—you are hanging out with someone who calls themselves ‘*Double Trouble*?’” She asked, annoyance plain in her voice and not just in her tail. Flit only stood there, stock still and seeming terrified.

Right away, Panga clamped down on her irritation. It never helped to be angry when speaking to children, especially when you want them to open up to you. She started again.

“Flit, where did you get these… things? Please tell me—I’m not mad.” She said, putting calm in her voice. Flit removed her hands from her mouth but continued to watch Panga’s tail beating the air. The warrior woman snatched her tail and held it fast, forcing a sweet smile on her face.

“From Double Trouble, at the candy shop. It’s how I make money for us,” Flit responded meekly. “What did you think I was doing?”

“You *sell* these things in a candy shop? People buy them?” Panga said, panic plain in her voice as her long ears lowered.

Flit shook her head. “No, I go out onto the streets. Me and the other children,”

Panga felt her heart pounding in her chest and the anger starting to rise.

What kind of monster would have children selling this evil? Making money from spreading corruption to the world?

Panga tried with all her might to suppress her fury as she knelt down in front of Flit, staring into her eyes with her large yellow ones.

“Flit, listen to me carefully. These things are bad. They are evil. No money is worth putting them into the world. Do you understand? It’s not worth you risking your life and soul for, little one.” She slowly enunciated each word.

Flit looked back at her, tears starting to mist in her eyes.

“*You're* worth it to me, Panga.” She said in a small voice.

Panga could not help herself as she reached out and gathered the little ball of fur into her arms, pressing Flit into her chest. She laid her cheek against the top of Flit’s head, tears starting to flow down her face and into Flit’s hair.

“Nooooo… *baby*, I’m not. Please promise me… promise me you won't go back to this candy store. Please?” Panga practically begged. “I don’t want to lose you too.”

Flit lifted her head to look up at Panga with questioning eyes. “What do you mean? Who did you lose?”

Panga looked uncertain for a moment, then quickly made a decision.

“I had a little one like you once—my daughter. Her name was Chhaya.” Panga said, running her white claws through Flit’s hair. “But she’s gone now, and I don’t want to lose you like I lost her.”

Flit looked down, pondering what Panga just told her. She knew what it was like to lose people close to her—the loss was so very painful. She didn’t want Panga to have to feel that again. Flit gave a little nod of assent.

“Okay, Panga, I won't go back. I promise.” She said.

Panga beamed. “That makes me so happy to hear. Hey, how about I stay here tonight? I need a break, and we can just eat fudge and tell silly stories all night. How does that sound?”

Flit jumped for joy and hugged Panga.

“Yay!” She exclaimed. Then she suddenly looked downcast. “But what about Double Trouble? Shouldn’t I tell them I won't be working there? I don’t want them to worry.”

Panga suppressed a growl—turning it into a purr.

“No, that’s okay Flit. I will go tell them. I have a few things to talk about with them anyway.” Panga stated meaningfully.

* * *

“So anyway, my dear, what did you want to speak to me about? Double Trouble said.

The Imp strode back to the counter, hopping up to sit as they regarded Canens with their typical insouciance. Right away, the muscular woman went into the explanation and reason for her visit.

“Yes, right, well, Borpt has another job for us—another task Janus himself wants done. We are to meet Borpt tonight at an old starport. One of our competitors is sending a large quantity of Sable off-world, and we are to intercept it.” Canens said, giving

Double Trouble a questioning look as she watched them snatch another bonbon with their long tongue.

Double Trouble groaned. “Really? Another task? Didn’t we already prove ourselves? Plus, make tons of money for the man? *So greedy!*” The Imp griped.

Canens shrugged and pulled out a datapad. “Whatever. If Janus wants it done—we do it, no questions. Coordinates and meeting time are on the datapad. Don’t be late.” She said with finality. Canens moved towards the door but then stopped, turning to look back at Double Trouble.

“You know, you're pretty good with them,” she said, a crooked grin appearing on her lips.

“Huh?” Double Trouble answered, completely confused. “Good with who, darling? Please don’t tell me this is a riddle. I hate riddles,”

“Kids. I watched you with that little girl. You have a way with them. I mean, you have them all working for you and all.” Canens said simply.

Double Trouble let out a high-pitched laugh. “*Oh, darling!* You are too much! I absolutely can't stand children! It gives me joy whenever I watch the little devils fall on their little faces. Stop!” Double Trouble cackled, waving a limp hand at Canens as their tail twitched.

Canens looked unconvinced. “Whatever. See you tonight, Fancy Pants Lizard. Don’t be late. We need you.” She said as she walked through the door.

Double Trouble watched her leave with confusion smeared across their face, tail continuing to flick. The words Canens spoke were having an unwanted effect on them—they did not like it.

You know, you're pretty good with them,

You have a way with them.

We need you.

Double Trouble scowled to themselves as another word appeared in their mind.

Attachments.

Double Trouble started tapping their fingers on the countertop as a memory came floating to the top—of when they made a final verdict on their stance concerning attachments.

They run down the alleyway, Alix not far behind, both laughing gleefully as they flee from the enforcers. The two of them had just pulled off their boldest heist to date and were eager to escape.


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With a shout, one of the enforcers hurls a long spear through the air, its whistling trajectory taking it straight towards Atreyen's back. But before it could hit its mark, Alix extends his long prehensile tongue, using it as a lash to send it spinning away.

"Thanks, darling!" Atreyen gasps over their shoulder, giving Alix their most winning smile.

He laughs. "They don't call me Tung Lashor for nothing!" He cries back.

Atreyen giggles as they skid around the corner—immediately—they spy an alcove in the side of a building. Recognizing it as a perfect hiding place, they quickly make their way into it. Once safely inside, they lean out and grab Alix as he sprints by, pulling him into the tight confines with them. Shortly after, the enforcers dash by, not noticing the hiding place as they search for the escaping criminals.

The two of them are pressed together tightly in the small space, Alix's heavily muscled and scaly chest heaving in exertion against Atreyen. They can feel his heart hammering against their chest, almost in sync with their own heart—they look up into his eyes—there is an intensity they find appealing there.

Atreyen reaches up and pulls his head down, lips meeting for a passionate kiss, which Alix responds to. They can still feel his heart—it is beating faster now as theirs slows, finding harmony with each other. Atreyen pulls away, giving him a playful slap on the cheek.

"You can have more later, lover boy. We need to find a safer place than this," they whisper.

Alix grins down at them, revealing rows of sharp teeth. His green, slitted eyes meet Atreyen's green and yellow ones as they smile back at him, showing all their sharp teeth in return.

As Atreyen and Alix exit the alcove, they both scramble up a ladder to a nearby rooftop —there, they have a wide view of the rest of the town. It is not much to look upon—just one of many slums that dot the Crimson Waste. Atreyen extracts the gem they had stolen from the burlap sack, holding it up to the bright day—it glitters in the light.

They have come to enjoy stealing, not so much for acquiring material items, but for the chaos it causes. Taking something precious from someone else creates a cascading effect: someone has something dear to them, and everything is fine, dandy, and calm—then they don't. The person becomes anxious to get it back, doing things they don't usually do, deviating from their standard path—creating chaos.

It is just one of the things Atreyen does now, for chaos's sake. They don't know why it appeals to them so much now; they were never like that before their transition. It must have something to do with their new form—the magic they have taken into themselves.

The magic of entropy.

They toss the gem to Alix, who catches it deftly. He hefts it in his hand, grinning.

"You know, Double Trouble, we make a good team. Why don't we join forces, permanently? I'm putting a gang together; it will be the biggest, meanest gang in the whole Crimson Waste! We can run it together! You and me—what do you say?" He says, holding his hand out to them.

Atreyen glances at his open hand and then gazes into his eyes. They notice it now, in his eyes—and using their abilities—they can sense it. He is falling for them, falling for them hard, and he wants something more permanent: attachment.

Atreyen remembers attachment and what it got for them. Yikka turned on them, and their own parents—whom they thought loved

them—tried to send them away to be destroyed. No, they have no need for attachment. Not one bit.

Atreyen runs their hand through their hair—it is still long, streaming down their back, but now with sides shaved. It retains the original bright red color, Atreyen not having not settled on a new color yet.

"Sorry, honey, I'm not looking for a partnership at the moment. Let me know when another job comes up—I might be interested," they shrug nonchalantly.

Alix's face falls, and after a moment, it turns bright red. He is furious.

"I hold out my hand and you slap it away?" He says, incredulous.

***Ugh, we have a crybaby,** Atreyen thinks. "Oh, darling, don't be dramatic. I never made any promises," they scold.*

Suddenly, Alix flings his long tongue out, wrapping it around Atreyen's wrist, holding them fast. "Ur na goin enywhere." He mumbles around his extended tongue.

"Ughhh… didn't anyone tell you not to talk with your mouth full," they say, holding up their free hand; razor-sharp claws appear on the fingertips. "This is why our relationship wouldn't work. I prefer a boy with some MANNERS!" They say, slicing through his tongue.

"UNNNNGGGGGG!!!!" He screams, holding his mouth.

Atreyen turns and leaps off the rooftop, extending their arms. Fleshly green membranes— like bat's wings—form, and they glide through the air. But the transformation is not perfect—they have not truly figured out flight yet. They descend rapidly, hitting the ground with a shriek.

Double Trouble snapped out of the memory as the door chime rang. Looking up, a sharp-toothed smile split their lips as they recognized the newcomer.

“Dexy! My dear Little Mouse, come in, come in!” They cried, gliding around the counter to kneel in front of the child. It was now absolutely pouring rain outside, and Dexi was shivering. He reached into the fold of his wet clothes and pulled out his earnings, a sorrowful look on his face.

“I’m sorry, Double Trouble, but this is all I could make. I will do better tomorrow. You’ll see.” He apologized earnestly.

Double Trouble pressed their lips together as they suppressed an unwelcome emotion.

“Now, now, my little pet, don’t fret. It's okay,” they say, taking the proffered currency. “You’ll still get a treat,” they gestured to the walls, indicating that the child could pick whichever candy he wished.

Dexy beamed and snatched a bright, sugary concoction from a nearby shelf, cramming it into his mouth as fast as possible. As the child munched on his treat, he gazed mournfully out the window at the sodden street. He was not looking forward to going back into that, nor having to find a place to sleep. Sensing what Dexy was feeling, Double Trouble turned his face gently by the chin until he was peering into their eyes.

“I have some errands to do tonight. How about you stay here and watch the shop— hmmm? And if any of your other little friends show up, make sure you collect their earnings and tell them they can sleep in the back. How does that sound?” They said gently.

A huge open-hearted grin was the boy’s reply, and Double Trouble patted him on the head.

“Run along now; get yourself some candy. Can’t have you wasting away, can we, honey?” Double Trouble said to the boy. The Imp suddenly looked thoughtful, placing a long green finger to their chin.

Hmm… I really should get some bunk beds. They decided.

Chapter End Notes

Illustrion done by Iria, a.k.a 'ilikeyoucatradora' on Instagram and Tumblr.

The Unusual Suspects

Chapter Summary

Double Trouble takes on yet another mysterious assignment from Janus.

What they discover during this heist is more precious to them than any jewels, gold, or currency.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Late evening found Double Trouble strolling down the sodden back streets of Thenlor, humming tunelessly as they attempted to find the flavor of an elusive melody. It was a rare night, one of those occasions when the rain had finally ceased, filling the air with the sounds of dripping water. Hidden amongst this background noise, the Imp could almost hear a kind of familiar song, and they strained to recollect it, sensing it would lead them to an insightful recollection.

But try as they might, they could not place a green finger on it—even after switching between show tunes of various harmonies, vocal ranges, and emotions—they still failed to recapture the rogue melody.

The street Double Trouble was currently traveling on was in one of the more unsavory areas of this particular district, one adjacent to the sector they were responsible for. It was Canens' territory—but more importantly—it was the location of the old starport where the Imp was expected to meet the other members of their party. Double Trouble was supposed to be there half an hour ago, but they were so easily distracted.

Using their magical abilities of transformation, they modulated their vocal cords to reach different ranges in pitch, achieving highs and lows that most beings could not attain nor hear. But even

with the added inspiration, Double Trouble was starting to get annoyed—they just could not place the feeling of déjà vu. The frustration of it being just on the tip of their tongue was about to force them to scream when they spied it—neon lights shining down from a floating display blimp in purples, blues, and magentas.

Ah… yes, now I remember—the Princess Prom! The Imp thought with a snap of their fingers. *When Peekablue and I tried to steal the Fractal Flake!*

Double Trouble smiled with delight as they continued down the street, the memory coming to them fully now.

THE PRINCESS PROM

The icy chill of the entranceway is unpleasant, as is the constant background drip of melting ice, but Atreyen moves through the antechamber and towards the sounds of music that drifts from the main throne room ahead.

They wear a short dress with a fur coat worn loosely about their shoulders; it is perfect for the party atmosphere—but since the fur coat is actually a part of them, it does not provide much warmth, causing Atreyen to push closer to the person next to them. With one arm in theirs, he turns and grins at them; Prince Peekablue.

He is the most beautiful man Atreyen had ever laid eyes upon; with lovely short pointed ears and soft teal skin and hair, Prince Peekablue is a vision. His almond-shaped face belies a smooth bone structure, while his eyes contain the softness and color of his skin.

For the past year or so, he has been their constant companion—their lover—but nothing deeper than that. Neither of them wants any permanent attachments; they both seek pleasure in all forms and maintain a superficial relationship—nothing more.

Atreyen is not actually sure what Peekablue is Prince of since he doesn't exactly have a kingdom. He seems to wander about—like

them—hanging around anything that is fashionable or involving himself in the theatre arts. The pair of them are so alike in nature that sometimes Atreyen takes his form—which Peekablue loves—for he is a narcissist to his very roots.

Currently, both of them are attending the All Princess Ball—or 'Princess Prom" as it is also known—with Atreyen going as Prince Peekablue's plus one. It seems like the perfect diversion and the chance to cause mayhem for the two degenerates. Prince Peekablue is a true kindred spirit to Atreyen; he also enjoys sowing chaos whenever he can, so when the All Princess Ball invitation arrived, he hatched a bold plan—stealing the Fractal Flake. It is the source of Princess Frosta's powers, and the entire kingdom will fall into disarray without it.

His plan is for Atreyen to take Frosta's appearance and gain entrance to the Fractal Flake chamber while he enchants the young Princess, keeping her distracted with his charms.

Quite simple—or so they think.

Atreyen and Peekablue enter the main throne room. It is a fantastically huge space filled with blue, purple, and magenta lights—various beautiful people dancing and enjoying themselves. Atreyen feels a momentary pang of sadness that they cannot just have fun and turns to Peekablue.

"Oh, precious lamb, why don't we just forget the Fractal Flake nonsense and have fun?" They ask with a pout.

Peekablue turns and favors them with a smile. "Oh, nonsense, you silly dear. Stealing the Fractal Flake IS fun!" He says with a pat on Atreyen's cheek. "Now, here is where we split up. Good luck, my darling!"

Prince Peekeablue glides away, down the stairs and towards the crowd of people dancing. Knowing him, he will catch a dance or two on his way to the young Princess's throne, giving Atreyen plenty of time to dawdle.

They continue down the stairs to mingle with a crowd; Atreyen loves other people and wants to be close to them, especially such a fashionable group as this. They soon spot people they recognize—Princesses Spinnerella and Netossa are known to them, as is the sparkly Princess Glimmer—but she is with a person they had never seen before—a young blonde girl, very pretty in a red gown. Whether or not the blonde girl is Glimmer's date is unknown.

Atreyen perceives other people they don't recognize: a strange young woman with long purple ponytails wearing unfashionable purple coveralls, a large woman with white hair in a black gown and two red claws for hands. But one stranger catches Atreyen's attention.

She is near the back of the crowd, seeming to be studying everyone while trying to be inconspicuous, wearing what appears to be a purple tuxedo. This female is breathtaking to Atreyen; a wild stone-gray mane frames an angular face, with two large black ears appearing from behind a fierce crimson face mask. She is covered in fine cinnamon-colored fur with a dark tail twitching from behind—but it is her heterochromatic eyes that are the most striking to Atreyen—one blue and one yellow—and slitted like cat's eyes... like Atreyen's eyes.

Atreyen is transfixed by this stranger and continues to track her. The feline woman moves gracefully about the room, placing objects against pillars and other weak points in the wall, all the while watching someone—the blonde girl in the red dress.

Hmmm... a jealous ex-girlfriend? *Atreyen thinks to themselves.* ***Those metallic objects she is placing everywhere must be explosives. Perhaps I don't need Peekablue's distraction after all. I should hurry since she is going to blow the place up.***

They make their way up the stairs to the balcony, passing the beautiful feline woman, who watches them suspiciously and sniffs. Atreyen gives her their most charming smile as they saunter past her, on their way to the exit. Once they are sure no one is looking,

Atreyen changes their appearance to that of the young Princess Frosta.

In their new form, they amble through the hallways while trying to maintain the stately pose of a Princess. Every once in a while, a guard passes and salutes them, but so far, no one is the wiser to their disguise. Since their first arrival to Etheria, they had come a long way and completely mastered their transformation skills—well, besides the flying part. And magic. Atreyen could take someone's form, but could not copy that person's magic.

Finally, they make it to the Fractal Flake chamber—in the end, it was not hard to find; they just had to follow the steadily increasing sense of cold.

Besides a deadening chill, the Fractal Flake is stunning to gaze upon. An aura surrounds a mass of gem-like glittering slivers as it floats in the air like a small star. The Fractal Flake emits a constant tone, like chimes; its harmony is pleasing to their ears.

Keeping the form of Frosta, Atreyen approaches the Fractal Flake, reaching out to grasp its form. As their hands get closer, the tone changes, becoming unpleasant. When their fingertips brush the aura, their hand is repelled, and the Fractal Flake shrieks with a tone of utter disapproval—flashing red. They try again with the same result.

"I am Princess Frosta, and I command you to obey me!" Atreyen says in a perfect imitation of the real Princess.

The Fractal Flake gives the same buzzing disapproval tone, lighting the room in angry red hues.

Before Atreyen can make another attempt, the cavernous space is rocked by an external detonation—they fall to the ground as chunks of ice, snow, and other debris rain down.

Looks like the angry cat-lady is enacting her revenge, *Atreyen thinks.* ***Oh, well, this was a long shot—time to collect Peekablue and get out of here.***

They change form to one of the castle guards before racing down the corridor, in the direction of the throne room chamber. As they turn a corner, Atreyen catches sight of Princess Frosta running towards them—

"Hey, Fancy Pants Lizard! Thanks for showing up!"

Double Trouble grinned as they caught sight of the speaker—it was Canens, waiting alongside Fontus, Tibernus, and Borpt. All three of the Imp's previous heist-mates were pleased to see them—whereas Borpt appeared put out. The group was huddled near an old plate fence; on the other side was a starport much different than the one Double Trouble had arrived in—smaller and dingier—the lading platform covered in rust streaks. Only four starships were docked there, as far away from each other as possible—privacy was more valued than aesthetics here, it seemed.

"Hello, my darlings, thank you so much for waiting for me!" Double Trouble cawed.

"You are late. You were supposed to be here at duskfall," Borpt said by way of greeting.

The Imp waved him off. "Oh honey, don't you know you shouldn't rush the talent?" They said with such sass that Canens burst out laughing.

"I know, right? This little man is *always* telling me to hurry up!" Fontus replied with equal cheek.

"Okay, enough," Borpt bit off. "We have a job to do, and we are late enough as it is. Let's get down to business."

Double Trouble gave Fontus a wink as he grinned back, but they both remained silent, acquiescing to their diminutive leader.

"So I'm guessing that is the ship we are boarding? The one with all the security forces on the outside?" Tibernus asked, indicating the nearest starship. Besides the six armed security guards

patrolling the outside, it was also the largest and most imposing vessel in the starport— long and ovoid, with a bulbous prow and two long fins running along the sides. It sat upon four landing claws with a ramp leading up to the airlock beneath it.

Borpt nodded in assent. "Now, the plan is for Fontus to create a distraction—drawing the external security forces away from the ship. Tibernus will then hack the outer door panel, giving us entry. Once inside, Canens and D.T. will handle the rest of the security forces." He said.

"Hey, I don't need Fancy Pants Lizard's assistance!" Canens protested.

"Oh, don't be sore, honey. Why would you turn down the extra help?" Double Trouble said—then morphed—becoming slightly taller and stockier. When the Imp finished, a perfect copy of Canens stood before her, ginning as they wiggled black eyebrows.

Canens studied the doppelganger, chin in hand. "Not bad. Wow! I am really quite stunning—"

"Enough!" Borpt interrupted, even more annoyed than before. "Fontus, if you please?"

The slight man nodded enthusiastically before scurrying under a hole in the fencing. Right away, Double Trouble went to their hands and knees, eager to take in the performance they missed back at the penthouse—unfortunately, the Imp was about to be disappointed.

After kicking off his shoes, Fontus removed his pants and shirt—then flung his clothes in the direction of the security forces.

"Hey, jerk-faces!" He screamed, turning and shaking his bare behind at the armed guards. "Come and get me!"

All six guards snapped their heads in the disrobed man's direction before promptly removing stun batons or shock mauls from their

belts. Fontus shrieked at the weapon's sharp crack of activation and ran—the security team in hot pursuit.

"He sure is good at his job," Tibernus marveled as he crawled through the same hole in the fencing Fontus used—who by now—was halfway to the opposite side of the starport with the guards in hot pursuit.

Swiftly passing through the gate, the rest of the team made their way to the now-unguarded spacecraft. Hurrying up the ramp and into an alcove in the bottom of the craft, the group stopped at the sealed airlock. Tibernus removed a datapad from a backpack, withdrawing wires recessed within to plug it into an access port in the side of the door. The device beeped and chirped while the technically savvy man waited, nervously tapping his foot.

"Come on… come on…" He pleaded.

Tibernus emitted a cry of alarm when the data pad suddenly fizzled and smoked; he dropped it to the ground to smolder in a heap.

"Curses! That was a triple-max level security hacker! It should have worked!" He cried, picking up and cradling his smoking device like a wounded lover.

"So now what?" Canens asked.

Borpt glanced at Double Trouble. "Anything from your end? You always seem to have some trick up your sleeve." He said to them.

"Mmm… technology is not really my thing," they said with a shake of their head, then clicked their tongue as a thought struck. "Wait! I want to try something; this may or may not work." Double Trouble warned.

The Imp once again took on their transitional form of all-black with dancing green lights—then shrunk as their tail disappeared, their form taking on a more feminine aspect. When Double Trouble had completed their transformation, a short young woman

with purple and pink sparkly bobbed hair stood before Canens, Borpt, and Tibernus. The three stared at her dumbfounded as she peered back with sparkling purple and pink eyes.

“Who are you supposed to be?” asked Canens.

“Oh, a Princess from Etheria whose wedding I once ruined,” Double Trouble said in a perfect imitation of Glimmer’s voice.

“Is she a technical wizard?” Tibernus asked hopefully.

The Glimmer imitation shook their head. “No, she is not a technical wizard; she is a Princess!”

Double Trouble closed their eyes, reaching within themselves. They felt the magical nature that had always been there ever since they touched the Orb of Entropy, but now another source was tethered to them; the Jacket. It was like a booster to their powers, or an addendum, modifying their transformative powers and giving them full access to all their subject’s abilities. Double Trouble felt inward to grasp Glimmer’s powers much as she would —with a flex of their mind—the Imp disappeared in a haze of sparkles.

Borpt, Canens and Tibernus all gasped, staring dumbfounded at the spot the Glimmer imitation vanished from, then jumped in unison as the airlock abruptly opened. Standing there grinning at them was none other than Double Trouble.

“Ta-da!” The Imp exclaimed, then started bowing, “Thank you! Thank you!”

“Wow!” Canens exclaimed. “You’re a Fancy Pants *Magic* Lizard!”

Double Trouble waved a limp hand at her. “Oh honey, you don’t know the half of it,” they smiled coyly.

“Good job, D.T.!” Borpt said, pleased now for once. “Everyone inside, we don’t know how much more time we have!”

The group entered the ship, navigating their way through sterile-smelling metallic halls bathed by overhead red lighting. It wasn't long before the interlopers found the security team tasked with guarding the inside of the spacecraft.

Three guards in body armor approached, their faces fully covered by helmets adorned with grim faceplates. Held outward in a clenched gloved fist, each guard had an activated shock maul—a nasty clubbing hammer with a power field that magnified the bludgeoning force. None of the armed guards spoke a word as they approached the intruders.

Canens started towards them, but a gentle green hand held her back.

"Canens, honey, let me deal with them," Double Trouble assured.

"Sure, sure. I need to see this," she laughed, clearly dubious that the Imp had any sort of fighting ability.

Walking forward, Double Trouble reached within their shimmering black jacket, withdrawing the laser sword they had taken from Xayide. Pressing an activation stud set on the hilt, there was a *snap-hiss* as a black beam shot forth from the end of the metal cylinder, ending in a sharp tip.

All three guards hesitated at the sight of such a dangerous armament, but only for a moment, then charged Double Trouble, shock mauls raised. The Imp leaped, somersaulting up and over them while delivering a downwards slash with the laser sword, slicing through the hilt of one of the mauls—deactivating it. The disarmed guard attempted to hit Double Trouble in the back of the head as they landed—but the Imp kicked backward—sending their would-be attacker careening into the sidewall and rendering him unconscious. He slid face-first down the hard surface to lie crumpled on the deck.

The two remaining guards spun simultaneously to strike at Double Trouble with their weapons—but the shock mauls were halted by

the humming length of the black laser sword— their power fields sizzling against the beam of pure energy.

The Imp took a moment to give their opponents a toothy grin as they withdrew from the exchange, holding the sword up, one-handed. Abruptly and lightning-fast, the Imp reached out and grabbed one of the guards by the throat, pulling him towards them. He cried in alarm, dropping his weapon as Double Trouble slammed him into the wall, holding the unfortunate man there by the neck. Right away, the remaining guard hammered away at Double Trouble, trying to distract them enough for his fellow to escape. But every blow was blocked by the laser sword, bringing forth a weaker and weaker spark from the shock maul; its power source was beginning to fail. Eventually, the energy field fizzled out, and as the deactivated maul struck the black blade, it burst in a shower of sparks.

Double Trouble could feel the guard's sense of hopelessness as he gazed at the hilt of his ruined weapon. The Imp laughed as they threw his companion directly at him, the momentum enough to knock them both completely insensate.

The Imp grinned at their companions as they deactivated their weapon, tucking it back into the folds of their jacket.

"Okay, I'm officially impressed." Canens said as she squatted next to all three unconscious guards. She rapped her knuckles on the side of the helmet of the one closest to her, making sure he was actually out cold.

"It would have been better if you just used that weapon to kill them," Borpt said disapprovingly.

Double Trouble hid their shock at such a callous statement, once again feeling disgust for the short, horrible man.

"I don't like messes, Borpt," they said matter-of-factly and without their usual good nature.

Borpt waved them towards the back of the ship. “Let's go. The cargo hold is this way—that is where they are keeping the Sable.”

The four intruders hurried through the red-lit corridors, now not bothering to keep quiet, for they were now the only ones on board the vessel… or so they hoped.

“In here! In here!” Borpt cried excitedly, indicating the closed door ahead of him. The door slid upwards as he turned the control knob, revealing the space behind.

It was empty.

“All of you spread out! Canens take the foredeck, Tibernus the aft, and D.T. below-decks. I will take the upper cabins! Now move! We don’t have much time.” Borpt said, anxiety evident in his manner and voice.

Discovering the stairway down, Double Trouble proceeded to the lower decks; it was filled with auxiliary rooms for life support, waste processing, and other systems necessary for space travel. The Imp moved quickly from space to space, gliding fluidly through the corridors on their mission. Finally, they came to the last and largest section of the below-decks—the engine room. It was Double Trouble’s least favorite space—densely packed with machinery, cabling, and hot pipes, it reeked with the acrid scent of ozone. Worst of all, it was horribly noisy.

They peeked, poked, and prodded throughout the machinery, using their magical abilities to manipulate their body, becoming smaller and thinner to fit in hard-to-reach places, but there was no sign of any of the Sable they had come for.

The Imp had just given up their search when Tibernus and Canens entered the space—the two were arguing angrily and loudly with each other, trying to be heard over the noise of the engine room.

“Where’s Borpt?” Double Trouble prompted.

“I don’t know,” Tibernus said offhandedly, “There's no Sable.”

“What?” Canens asked, incredulous.

“You heard me, you idiot—there's no Sable!”

Canens grabbed Tibernus by the front of his shirt. “What do you mean, there’s no Sable?” She screamed into his face.

“I’ve been over this whole ship, I’ve been in every room. THERE IS NOTHING! NOTHING!” He screamed. “THERE IS NO FREAKING SABLE!”

Canens let him go in resignation, turning her back to him and leaning over a rail. Then she spun to face Tibernus and Double Trouble.

“This whole thing is a mess, and it doesn’t smell right. I’m getting out of here. You two coming?” She asked.

Tibernus nodded. “Yeah, let's grab Fontus on our way out.”

“I’m going to find Borpt,” Double Trouble said, a rare hard expression on their face, “he better have some answers for me.”

“Whatever, Fancy Pants Lizard—we’re outta here. Good luck.” Canens said as she and Tibernus hurriedly made their way out of the engine room and on their way to the airlock.

Double Trouble followed them out of the engine room but diverted their course, heading for the stairs leading to the upper decks—where the crew quarters were located. They strode purposefully down the corridor, their anger starting to rise.

I’m going to wring some answers from that little schemer's neck, the Imp thought, fuming to themselves.

When Double Trouble spotted an open door at the corridor’s end, they proceeded in that direction—but stopped with a gasp as they discovered what was inside.

It was Borpt, standing with his back turned next to a body of a well-dressed woman on her stomach. Double Trouble instantly recognized her; it was the woman, Olistene, from the penthouse heist. There was not a mark on her, but she was obviously dead; her face turned to Double Trouble, staring at them with glassy eyes.

"What is this, Borpt? You killed her?" They asked in a whisper.

The diminutive man spun to face Double Trouble, surprise written on his face—which then solidified into firm resolve.

"Yes. She was a traitor to the Vibrissa. She was going to give all our secrets away to our enemies." He stated coldly.

Double Trouble's mind reeled with questions, and they stumbled out of their mouth.

"What? Why did you… *How did you…?*" They blurted, but then their anger came back. "So this was all some trick? Using us to get on board so you could assassinate someone?"

Borpt nodded. "Yes, that's right. You are all good members of the Vibrissa, but every one of you lack the nerve to do what was needed to be done. So I had to come up with a reason to board this ship. These fools could never get their hands on our product —that's impossible. However, with Olistene's help, they could have done some serious damage to our organization. I apologize for the ruse." Borpt said evenly and without any apology in his voice.

"You *apologize?*" Double Trouble replied incredulously. "*HOW DARE YOU*!" They screamed. With a reptilian hiss, they lunged at Borpt, snatching the little man up in their claws and slamming him into the wall, holding him there while snarling in his face.

"I've had enough of your *tricks* and your *deceptions*, you *disgusting* little worm!" They raged, opening their mouth wide and snapping in his face with their sharp teeth. "I'm going to get some answers even if I have to beat them out of you!"

Double Trouble emphasized this last part by slamming him again into the wall; Borpt let out a gasp from the force of the impact. They were not even bothering to hold back their incredible strength, the rage flowing through Double Trouble's veins was making them unhinged. They did not like being tricked—but even more so—they did not like the fact that they were involved in someone's death. It horrified them.

"So, what, you're going to kill me?" Borpt wheezed. "That won't put you in good standing with Janus."

Double Trouble sneered. "Enough of this *Janus* nonsense—I knew only one Janus in my life, and they would not be involved in something like this. You're a lying little sneaky coward, and I bet you made up Janus so you could hide behind him. Am I getting close—*darling?*"

Borpt sagged in their hands, his chin touching his chest. Double Trouble was starting to worry that he fainted until his body started heaving.

Is he faking a seizure? They wondered—but then they heard it—laughter. Borpt cackled as he raised his head, scrutinizing Double Trouble with an expression that chilled them to the core.

"Think you got it all figured out, huh?" He said menacingly. Suddenly, his whole body became a black nothing—little red motes of light dancing within. Double Trouble shrieked as they dropped him—Borpt began to morph—becoming bigger and taller. When he was finished transforming, a bald-headed, blue-skinned humanoid wearing a black body glove stood before them. They were genderless, staring at Double Trouble with glittering gem-like eyes.

"Aithex?" Double Trouble breathed. "How? You are… like me? Janus gave you the power of entropy too?"

"Cloooossse!" Aithex teased. "Oh, you're sooo close! Let me give you another hint… *Atreyen*…"

If Double Trouble was reeling before, they were now ready feint at hearing their true name spoken aloud by this stranger. They backed away from Aithex open-mouthed.

"*How*… how do you know me? Who are you really? If you have the power of entropy, you could be anyone! You're not Aithex! Show yourself!" Double Trouble said with terror in their voice. They feared the answer.

Aithex nodded and smiled. "So be it." They declared, becoming the transitional form so similar to Double Trouble's—except for the dancing lights—red instead of green. Their outline became taller and slighter, more feminine. A long thick tail appeared as hair flowed down from the crown of the head, reaching to the middle of their back. The morphing figure tossed their hair playfully as the form solidified, and once again, Double Trouble found themselves gasping.

A green-skinned female stood before them dressed in an oily black skinsuit, the front opened to reveal a hint of cleavage. Bright red hair framed a beautiful elfin face—two long, thin ears poked out through the red strands. She peered at Double Trouble with green and yellow slitted eyes as she smiled, showing rows of sharp teeth.

This woman was older than they remembered, but her face was unmistakable.

"Yikka!?" Double Trouble cried in disbelief.

"Hey, Atreyen. Miss me?" Yikka replied.


HENARTORINOS'23

Chapter End Notes

Illustration done by Henar, A.K.A. ilikeyoucatradora on Instagram and Tumblr.

Though Lovers Be Lost, Love Shall Not

Chapter Summary

> Double Trouble's painful past abruptly inserts itself into their life with the arrival of Yikka.
>
> Panga makes a disturbing discovery, revealing Sable's horrifying nature.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Yikka! Is it really you?” Double Trouble cried, both overjoyed and dumbstruck by the current turn of events.

The last time they had laid eyes upon their first love—perhaps their one and only true love—she had turned her back on them when they had needed her the most. Right when the entire world had seemed against them, Yikka was the refuge Double Trouble had so desperately sought—only to have her cast them away callously, into the cold sea of disregard.

But that was so long ago and far away, and somehow, across space, time, and reality, Yikka had found them. Double Trouble felt pure happiness at seeing her once more, quickly dismissing the single rebuff made by the one person who had ever truly known them.

With hands held out and smiling warmly, the newly returned Yikka approached Double Trouble.

“Yes, Atreyen, it's me, your Yikka,” She said, wrapping her arms around them. It was a tender and openhearted hug—full of real love. It was not an expression that felt mimicked or faked—even with the strongest magic. Double Trouble returned the embrace, tentatively at first—then fully.

ONE

Suddenly laughing with joy, Double Trouble placed their hands gently on Yikka's checks. She gazed into their eyes; there was an expectant need there as Yikka parted her lips, leaning towards Double Trouble's mouth. As the reunited lovers kissed, their bodies pressed into one another, much like that night in the auditorium—now lost to time. Double Trouble could feel Yikka's heart beating against them, becoming in sync with theirs, and once again, it was like the two were one.

One heart, one mind, one love.

Double Trouble and Yikka parted from each other's embrace, still grasping each other's arms—as if they were afraid to lose each other again. Yikka ran her fingers down between Double Trouble's parted jacket, upon their bare green skin. She stared at their chest in amazement before peering up into their eyes, grinning.

"You did it, Atreyen. You became who you were meant to be. You're so wondrous and beautiful to behold!" She said, lovingly stroking their cheek. "You changed so much, yet you're still the same."

"Oh, darling, you really don't know the half of it," they responded with a laugh, placing their own hand over the one gently caressing their face.

The two were still smiling at each other like fools when Double Trouble glanced behind Yikka, their eyes alighting upon what lay on the floor.

The body.

The body of the woman, Olistene, whom Yikka had just killed, by what means Double Trouble could not fathom. Nor the reason—betrayal. Confusion once again clouded their mind.

"Yikka, what is all this? You killed a person? Why?" They whispered before more questions forced their way into Double

Trouble's head. "The organization—*The Vibrissa*… and the… *Sable*. What is going on?"

Yikka placed her hands on Double Trouble's shoulders in comfort. "Easy, Atreyen, easy. There is so much going on, so many wondrous things I have to tell you about—but I can't right now. It's not the right time. Do you still trust me?" Yikka asked earnestly.

A moment of doubt crossed Double Trouble's face as they stared at the still corpse on the floor.

"I…" They stammered as Yikka placed her hands on the sides of Double Trouble's face, gently shifting their gaze back into her eyes.

"Do you still trust that I love you?" She whispered.

There it was—that word unspoken from before. The one they had known Yikka would have proclaimed if only a cruel situation had not torn them apart. It was like a balm upon a wound they did not recognize they had—one carried for years upon their heart.

Double Trouble placed their hands over hers. "Yes… yes… I do. I do believe it. I felt it, just now,"

Yikka laughed brightly. "Yes! Like when we first kissed—that night in the auditorium, our hearts beating in unison. It was like we were one!"

Double Trouble's face lit up. "You felt it too!"

Yikka nodded; tears were falling from her eyes, and Double Trouble could feel their own, warm and tickling, running down to her hands.

"Can you tell me how you got here, at least? How did you become like me? Did Janus give you the power of Entropy? The last time I saw you was at school, when…" Double Trouble said, trailing off at the last part.

When you walked away from me.

Yikka's face fell as shame filled her eyes. She turned from Double Trouble, wrapping her arms and tail around herself in comfort before turning back to them—the tears flowing more openly now down her beautiful green face.

"I'm sooo *sorry* about that, Atreyen, I truly am. With all my heart. I…" She started, then grimaced as she forced herself to continue. "I was confused… and scared. You remember how that place was, that world we lived in. It was like one oppressive weight upon every moment of our lives; it was like we couldn't breathe. I was not as strong as you were. I was… I was a *coward*, Atreyen." She said sadly.

Double Trouble rushed to her, wrapping their arms and tail around her in reassurance.

"*Oh, honey, no*… you were not a coward. You are right. That place was horrible for such strange and beautiful people like us. I was angry at the time. I felt alone and betrayed, but now I see… now I see…" They said, stroking Yikka's long red hair.

Yikka nuzzled her face into Double Trouble's neck, holding them tight as she continued her story.

"When I came home from school that day, my parents acted as if nothing had changed—but I knew. I could see it in their body language and the subtle way they treated me that they knew about us." She said, the fear of the memory plain in her voice.

"What happened to you? Tell me," Double Trouble asked gently, lifting Yikka's face so she gazed into their eyes.

"When I woke the next morning, they were waiting for me, the men who had come to take me to the Conversion Center. I couldn't believe it at first; I was in shock. I could not believe my parents would do this to me. I didn't say a word as they took me away to be *fixed*. It was only the beginning for me, and I had no idea…"

“At the Conversion Center they started slow with the newcomers, the idea being to ‘gently’ bring you into their program. I was immersed in literature, radio, and imaging programs that were deemed ‘proper’ and ‘normal.’ This could be tolerated—for is that not what we went through every day? The group therapy was next, where we would take turns role-playing.”

“This was not so bad in the beginning, for the others sent to the Conversion Center were kindred spirits, and we made light of the role-playing, we turned it into a kind of fun game. However, the Guides—these were the people in charge of us—did not like this and changed the type of role-playing we would perform. It became… hard to have fun with it.”

“Now, some were ‘lucky’ enough to have seen their way to ‘redemption’ by now and could be graduated and sent back into the world as a normal and proper member of society. The rest of us were elevated to the next level of torment. Shock-therapy, hypnotherapy, drug therapy, and other therapies—it became a blur for me at this point.”

“They also… went into my head, Atreyen,” Yikka continued, reaching towards her head with bent fingers, making small gentle motions as if she was trying to itch an impossible scratch. “They hurt me… they hurt my mind…”

Double Trouble reached out and clasped her hands in theirs, drawing them down and pressing them into their chest, where their heart was.

“Oh, precious, you don’t have to go on if you don’t want to,” they said kindly.

Yikka shook her head emphatically. “No, we got through the bad stuff, now comes the good part!” She said with a broad grin.

“It was late at night, and I was in my room, held down with straps so as to not mess with the bandages on my body. I was also heavily sedated, for my resistance to them was too great. The

Guides were becoming frustrated, for they thought they could not break me. Little did they know I was on the verge of giving in. That was when *they* came,"

"At first, I thought I was hearing things, hearing voices. Hearing someone calling my name—I was on a lot of medications, after all. Then they appeared out of the shadows, a person in a strange robe with a strange face—neither man nor woman. They had a staff with a ball on the top that glowed with the same energy I saw in their eyes."

"They introduced themselves as Janus, as I'm sure they introduced themselves to you Atreyen. They said they were 'in the neighborhood' and that they were there to help me, help a friend of Atreyen's. They said they could give me the power to set me free. All I had to do was accept it. Accept it and touch the strange ball on the end of their staff they called the Orb of Entropy."

"I thought I was mad… and maybe I was… but I figured I had nothing to lose. Absolutely nothing at all. I reached for the Orb and… well, I'm sure you know the rest." She said, finishing her tale.

Double Trouble looked thoughtful. "When I was in that place, the one where I received my magic, I had a kind of choice. I chose to come to this reality out of countless trillions. How did you end up here too, Yikka?"

Yikka placed her hands on her chest and smiled brightly back. "Because I knew you were here, Atreyen, I felt you through my love for you. It was a very easy choice, for I would follow you across time and countless realities to find you. I love you!"

Yikka reached out with her hands, and Double Trouble grasped them, pulling her into another embrace. Their lips met for a more passionate kiss as their bodies made contact.

It felt so good to have her back, so close after being away for so long, and after hearing what poor Yikka went through, it made

Double Trouble ashamed for ever having been angry with her. They held Yikka tight—as if to protect her from ever coming to harm again, and they felt her doing the same. Their tails wrapped around each other and became entwined; it was as if every single part of the two lovers wanted to make as much contact with the other as possible.

For a brief moment, Double Trouble felt that it was truly possible for the two of them to become *one*…

* * *

It was early morning as a set of yellow eyes surveyed the crowd below. Panga was high up on a nearby building, clinging to a perch with her hand and foot claws, looking for someone—or, more accurately—someones.

The feline warrior felt utterly energized and refreshed today, having spent the evening playing silly games with Flit and getting a full night's rest. The extra sleep had done wonders for Panga, and when she woke, it was with a purpose in mind—find whoever had involved Flit and all those other children in evil and completely and *utterly crush them*.

Panga had a lot of experience with stamping out evil—the warrior woman having developed a process for dealing with it. The first step was to witness the evidence of the evil in the world—see the pain and suffering it was causing firsthand. That was what she was doing now, hunting for that first loose thread to follow.

Suddenly, Panga spotted it—a person who was acting peculiarly. It was an individual of diminutive stature, standing on a street corner as they tried to act inconspicuously. Once in a while, someone would approach the small figure, and an exchange would take place.

Must be one of the children selling this evil to a customer, Panga thought to herself. *Flit said it was called Sable.*

This was what she had been searching for. This was the thread.

Panga's tail started to wag in interest and she leaped into the air, landing on a lower rooftop, closer to her target. Picking one of the customers, the silent hunter zeroed in, leaping from rooftop to rooftop to follow them, always keeping the mark in sight.

The person moved quickly through the streets, furtively casting about as they clutched their prize possessively. It was as if they were desperate to get out of sight and use the Sable as soon as possible—Panga knew what they were feeling; the urgent need to feel good again, to experience the best times of your life all in an instant. But it was not real—it was a lie—and behind it all was an evil purpose, one the feline warrior had yet to figure out.

Panga watched as her quarry entered a small apartment complex, one of the cheap additions added as an annex to another building. She scrambled down a nearby wall to leap after them on all fours, running up the stairs to halt the entry door before it closed.

Once inside, the feline warrior caught the scent of the person who had just opened the door; it was a 'he,' and his aroma permeated the air he just passed through. It was sweet and pungent-smelling—mixed with anxiety and fear. But, there was something else, something not right. A sour taste sat amongst the fug—like a sickness—that of someone who was close to death. Panga followed the scent up the stairs, moving quietly on velvet feet until she reached the right floor.

She was immediately struck by how silent the apartment complex was. Panga had been on Thenlor for quite some time now and was familiar with this cramped way of living—so different than the way her people lived on Elysia. There was the constant sound of life in the background; people talking, yelling, or smells of food cooking.

Instead, she sensed nothing in this apartment complex; it was like it was dead.

Following her quarry's scent down the hallway, Panga was led to a door left open in haste or just ignored—like the safety or privacy

was no longer a concern. She moved into the apartment, searching for the man and quickly finding him sitting at a table, photographs spread out before him. He was staring off into the distance, glassy-eyed and clutching what she could only assume was Sable in his hand. Panga inspected the pictures, running her orange hands over them to gently spread them out. They were all variations of the same four people; the man with two small children and a woman.

His family, she thought with a pang of sadness. *I don't see them here. They must be… gone.*

"They're dead," the man said suddenly, now focusing on the intruder in his home. "All dead—taken by those monsters,"

Panga crouched next to him, peering up at him with compassionate yellow eyes. She reached out a hand and laid it over his, the one holding the Sable.

"I'm so sorry. I know the pain of loss, *believe me*, I feel for you. But this is not the right way. Sable is evil, and I feel it is killing you." She said, imploring.

"I don't care," He said with a smile, tears streaming down his face. "As long as I can feel *good* again. Soon, I will be with them!"

With tears brimming her own eyes, Panga gently pried the man's hands open. He tried to resist but was so weak; it was like taking a stone from a small child.

"No! Please!" He pleaded as Panga threw the Sable at the nearest wall with all her considerable strength. It shattered with the sound of breaking glass, the fragments raining down onto the floor in smaller pieces.

The man lunged onto his hands and knees, sweeping the fragments with his hands into a pile to gather them all in one hand. Selecting the largest piece from his small collection, he held it up to the light, sighing in satisfaction—once again under the influence of the Sable.

Panga hissed in irritation. *I should have known it would not be easy to stamp out evil,* she thought. *I can do nothing for this poor soul.*

Panga left the man to his dark, sweet dreams, quickly walking out into the hallway. She then stopped, noticing something else now that she was not fixated on following the man; most of the other apartment doors were open or ajar. Panga stood completely still, straining her ears and listening for the sounds of life—but hearing nothing. Walking over to one of the doors that had been left ajar, she sniffed at the crack in the door—immediately, a familiar and sharp smell assailed her nostrils, knocking her back.

The smell of death.

Panga's eyes widened as her long ears lowered in horror; she realized what she would see behind that door and all the others.

This is way worse than I feared, Panga thought, trying to push down on the dread welling up in her heart. She replaced that feeling with another, one which would be more helpful to her current situation—fury.

Panga once told Catra that their people were filled with great compassion and empathy. This was true, but they were also capable of great anger. Anger towards those who cause evil and pain.

This Double Trouble better have answers for me, Panga thought as she turned and leaped down the halls on all fours. *Or today may be the last time they breathe the air of Thenlor, this I swear upon the Great Chailendra Tree.*

* * *

Dancing through their storefront, Double Trouble spun and hummed, all the while fussing about as they organized the candy. In their distraction, the Imp had forgone their storefront red and white outfit for what was now their usual appearance; glossy black jacket and pants, hair of pure silver. They pirouetted and

twirled, their tail forming a spiral around their body before ending their little ballet in an arabesque, placing the last bonbon on a pyramid of bonbons.

Double Trouble could not help their exuberance, for they had not been this happy in a long time. The feeling was all-encompassing; it was in their head, their heart, and their soul.

They were in love.

"The last time I had saw you we had just split in two, she was looking at me, I was looking at you," they sang; it was another melody from their rich life in the theater. *"We wrapped our arms around each other, tried to shove ourselves back together,"*

They continued their song, moving about the room as if they were drunk, completely carefree.

"*The story, the origin of love*—" They sang, cutting off the last part as something on the shelf caught their attention. It was a candy person, laying on its side amongst a group of standing candy people. It was like it was asleep.

Or dead.

Double Trouble stared at it fixedly, the sudden concentration yanking them out of their dreamlike state. The Imp found themselves disturbed in a manner in which they could not quite put a green finger on.

Double Trouble had parted from Yikka last night in absolute joy, promising her that they would continue their work, selling the Sable. They trusted her, trusted her love in them that her plan was a good one. But they could not shake a feeling of unease, hanging on to their happiness like a great weight.

The body. The Sable.

The Imp shook their head, trying to shake the thoughts out and forcing a smile on their face.

Yikka has her reasons; I told her I trusted her, they thought.

Once again, Double Trouble considered Yikka's reasons for killing Olistene—betrayal.

What could have been so bad for Yikka to have killed Olistene? Hadn't Yikka betrayed them once? They did not need to feel the need to kill her for it.

Murder.

Double Trouble shook their head furiously. *No!* They thought. *Yikka did not betray me. She loved me! She still does! It's not the same!*

Borpt. Aithex.

Yikka had been both Borpt and Aithex the whole time, two individuals whom Double Trouble did not like. Both these individuals made Double Trouble uneasy with their casual cruelty.

No, it was Yikka playing a part, they thought, pleading with themselves, but they could not help the questions that kept on appearing.

Why did Yikka keep herself hidden from you for so long if she loved you?

Double Trouble was so caught up in the moment that they had not ask Yikka such an obvious question. They were too happy.

Too blind.

Double Trouble turned and leaned down against the glass counter, considering their reflection.

The body. The Sable. The murder. Borpt. Aithex.

Something else was bothering Double Trouble; it was the way Yikka's transitional form had red dancing motes instead of green—

like Janus and Double Trouble had. It just didn't sit right.

That's silly, Atreyen. It's probably because you and Janus have no gender, and Yikka is female. That's the reason, they thought lamely to themselves. But they doubted the power of entropy made such gender distinctions.

There is something terribly wrong with this. There is something terribly wrong with Yikka.

"NOOO!!!" Double Trouble cried in abject misery, putting their head in their hands. *No, you have to give Yikka a chance to explain herself. She has been through so much. You love her, and she loves you. You have to give her a chance,* they thought with finality on the subject.

Double Trouble forced their mind to remember a time they had grown to have feelings for another woman—a woman who had a troubled past and did bad things. A woman who, in the end, turned out to have good in them. The Imp fled into the memory, seeking solace.

Atreyen pilots the Horde Skiff out of the Whispering Woods and through the field of flowers, heading in the direction of the Fright Zone. They take a moment to consider their companion, preoccupied in her own reveries as she stares off into space, tail twitching.

Catra.


HENARTORINOS'23

They remember the joy in her heterochromatic eyes when Atreyen had come to rescue her from the disaster that was her secret hideout—all burning around Catra as she lay trapped under a fallen walkway. If they had not shown up and interceded, lifting the heavy weight of her prison off her with their incredible strength, Catra would have burned to death—or been captured by the rebels.

For a brief moment, Atreyen had thought the look she had given them was an indication of her feelings for them—romantic feelings—for since the first moment they laid eyes on Catra at the Princess Prom, Atreyen felt an attraction to the feline woman. It is not just for her beauty—which was in abundance—but also her anger, her pain. Catra is hurt, like them. She had been betrayed by the one she loved—as Atreyen had been.

Catra is also so tender, so fragile, all the while being so strong on the outside; she wears a disguise like they sometimes do. As Atreyen watches Catra stare off into the distance, they feel an overwhelming need to reach out, to touch her, to hold her. But they know that would not go very well for them.

No, Catra does not have any romantic feelings for them. She is just glad someone had cared enough to save her, for she is so very alone now. Atreyen does not need their magical powers of insight to tell she is still in love with someone else—this Adora. Catra's anger and feeling of betrayal have sent her careening into this cycle of violence and evil, and she is set on this path.

The injustice of Catra's situation makes Atreyen consider something: is her fate really set? Why does she have to stay on this path?

Atreyen frowns to themself. But is that their way? To help people? Sure they care about Catra, and she pays them well for their services. But to go out of their way to put Catra back onto the right path? Is that the way of chaos? Of entropy?

They remember being in the place of entropy. It is full of limitless possibilities—neither good nor evil. Entropy and chaos are what you make of it. Steering Catra off her path of evil and onto a neutral or good path, IS chaos. They are still following their nature by helping Catra.

Atreyen nods to themself; the choice has been made, and it will not be a pleasant one for Catra, but it will be for her own good.

The door behind them slammed closed, snapping Double Trouble out of their revelries. They turned to identify the person responsible for the disruption.

Standing in front of the shop entry was a robed figure. They stared at Double Trouble from under a hood, glaring at them with two yellow eyes and flashing white fangs. From behind them, a cream-colored, brown-striped tail whipped back and forth behind them in evident irritation. If that was not enough indication this person was angry, then the low, menacing growling was.

“Uh... hello, are you here to buy some candy?” Double Trouble asked lamely.

Chapter End Notes

Illustration by Henar, a.k.a, ilikeyoucatradora on Tumblr and Instagram.

Fury of a Madgēcot

Chapter Summary

> Panga and Double Trouble finally meet in an explosion of bonbons, chocolate truffles, and lollipops.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Waking with a start, Flit immediately felt around the bed, searching for Panga—only to find cold sheets.

“Panga?” Flit asked tentatively—then louder, “Panga!”

There was no response; total silence met the little girl’s entreaty, indicating that the hideout was empty. If her friend had been there, she would have answered.

Flit suddenly felt uneasy, not because she was alone, for she was alone in the hideout a lot—mostly at night. No, it was the way Panga was acting the night before.

Flit had lots of fun with her friend, playing the simple games Panga had taught her, games from the feline woman’s home world of Elysia. Panga had laughed and teased Flit, seeming to be having a good time—but the little girl had sensed something behind her friend's smiling face; fear and anger. Flit knew that Panga was very upset about finding the Sable—but why—she did not know.

They are just pretty and shiny rocks, kind of cold when I hold them, but nothing horrible, right? Flit thought to herself, already knowing this was a lie.

If I believed the Sable was harmless, why did I feel the need to hide it from my friend?

Ever since she had gotten involved with selling the Vibrissa's product, Flit had felt an underlying sense of dread whenever she had the onyx stones in her possession, feeling fortunate that Double Trouble had kept her from using it. The little girl sensed it was because they had been looking out for her.

Despite their apparent aloofness, Flit knew Double Trouble secretly cared about her and the other children. They were always so generous, giving out extra candy on top of the payment for their work. When any of the children asked to sleep in the main back room, Double Trouble always laughed.

"Oh, you little rascals," they would say, trying to hide a smile. "Always trying to get more out of me, aren't you?"

But Double Trouble would always set up bedding for them to sleep on. In the beginning, it was old packaging material, but since then they had purchased sleeping pads, pillows, and blankets. More recently, they could be heard muttering to themselves—something about needing to get bunk beds for their "little mice."

Double Trouble would even stay up with the children until they fell asleep, telling the most outlandish stories or singing. Flit knew there was great kindness in her employer and even felt like they were her friend.

Flit suddenly felt very scared. She had promised Panga that she would stay away from Double Trouble, but the way Panga had acted last night made Flit believe that the fierce woman would not stay away from *them*.

Panga was a warrior, one that had single-handedly taken out those thugs chasing Flit the first time the two met. With the exception of the night before, Panga went out every night to dispense justice to criminals—and as far as the feline woman was concerned—Double Trouble was a criminal. Panga's absence suddenly made sense.

Flit scampered to the small hole in the wall, her own exit from the hideout, knowing she had little time. Hopefully, she could get to the candy shop before Panga tore Double Trouble into little green shreds.

* * *

"Can I help you with something?" Double Trouble asked the angry stranger apprehensively.

The newcomer continued to growl as they reached up with orange hands, white claws at the tips of each finger, and lowered their hood. Double Trouble was startled by the face that blazed back at them.

It was a *she*, and she was beautiful, obviously of the same feline species as Catra. Two yellow-slitted eyes peered out of a light orange face with a cream-colored oval patch around the left socket. On each side of her head, long, cream-colored ears poked out from between strands of wild brown hair—white tufts protruding down from behind each ear. Her eyes narrowed at Double Trouble's appraisal of her appearance.

"Looks like you've seen a Madgēcot Star Hunter before," she said in a lyrical voice. Double Trouble had never heard an accent like it before.

"Huh?" They responded, dumbfounded. "Whats a Magicat Star Hunter?"

The woman hissed in irritation. "Madge-eee-cot," she said, baring her fangs as she pronounced slowly, "Not Magi-cat. Do not play games or insult me, *criminal*, for you already have much to answer for,"

"Criminal!" Double Trouble practically shrieked, acting incensed. "Madame, how dare you enter my establishment and hurl insults in my face!"

The feline woman smirked in response to this. “That won’t be the only thing I hurl into your face, *criminal.* It all depends on how you cooperate. Tell me, where do you get this evil from? This Sable, you call it. Why, of all things, are you having innocent children—like Flit—sell it?”

Double Trouble nodded to her. “Ah, you must be the Panga my little mouse always talks about. What is Flit to you? You are obviously not her parent, for I don’t see the resemblance, *honey*.”

Panga tilted her head in a curious manner. “*Honey?* What is this *honey* you call me? Is it an insult? As for Flit, she is under my care and none of your business. You will not be seeing her again, for I will not allow her to be involved in your evil.”

Double Trouble was genuinely angered at this. *Who is this crazy cat lady to take away my best earner? And what is this evil she keeps prattling on about?* They think.

“Listen, *darling*,” Double Trouble started, receiving the same curious tilt of the head from Panga, “First, your little Flit is my best worker; I can’t have you keeping her from selling for me. I just won't stand for it,” Double Trouble said, receiving an outraged expression from Panga, “Second, I’m involved in a completely legal business venture here. You have absolutely no right to stop me,” Double Trouble continued as Panga’s eyes widened, her tail whipping back and forth furiously. “Third, and this is the last and most important one; I’d like to see you stop me, *Kitten*.” Double Trouble finished, putting the maximum insouciance possible in their voice.

The reaction was immediate.

Panga flung her robe off, revealing a skin-tight bodysuit made of strange green and black strips of materials, and lunged at Double Trouble.

“KITTEN?!” She screamed, slashing down at Double Trouble’s face, “You're going to find out why I’m called *White Claw*!”

PANGA'S TEMPER


IRIA ABELLA

Double Trouble stopped the downward strike with the forearms of their jacket, the sharp claws incapable of penetrating the magical material. But the force of the blow still hurt, making the Imp wince in pain.

"Yes, my dear, you have such pretty white nails. *Very nice*," they jeered.

They received a knee to the stomach in response, doubling them over in a wheeze and putting their face in a perfect position for a roundhouse kick. The Imp flew sideways into a rack of candy; it exploded outward with their impact, scattering treats across the floor. They stood back up, wiping some stickier pieces of candy off their body.

Panga came at them again in a cartwheel. She was fast and agile, using a fighting technique Double Trouble had never encountered. They decided to use their favorite maneuver.

Pivoting on their heel, the Imp attempted to slap the tornado of claws and fury out of the air with their long tail. They screamed as Panga raked her claws over the soft green skin of their precious rear appendage, drawing blood.

"OW! YOU BIT—" they started to shriek, but a clawed foot cut off their retort, sending them flipping into and through the glass counter—shattering it.

Double Trouble stood slowly and menacingly from the ruins of their display case, covered in fudge and hissing with rage.

This crazy woman is too small, too fast, and I left that blasted laser sword in my room, they thought frantically to themselves. P*erhaps I need to fight fire with fire.*

Double Trouble took on their transitional form, their outline becoming smaller and slighter, their tail becoming thinner. When they had completed their transformation, a feline woman of equal

size and stature as Panga stood before her. The warrior woman halted in her attack; surprise written on her face.

"Cat-Tra?" Panga said incredulously, drawing equal surprise from Double Trouble. They had taken the form that they had last seen Catra in—when she had freed them from the dry storage locker.

Panga squinted at the Catra imposter before her and sniffed suspiciously. Then shook her head.

"No, you are not Cat-Tra, shapeshifter. You can't fool me." Panga said, crouching to spring. "I don't know how you stole my sister's form, but you will pay for that, too."

Double Trouble ignored the questions as to how this Panga knew Catra; it wasn't important. Panga didn't appear to be in the mood to answer questions anyway, and the Imp gathered their strength for the upcoming fight.

Catra was the best form Double Trouble could take for fighting. After all, it was as Catra that Double Trouble went toe-to-toe with She-Ra. The exchange ended up with the Imp in a cage, but they still put up a good fight. Besides, now they had an extra advantage—Shen's jacket.

Double Trouble stretched their consciousness out to access the extra magic of the jacket—suddenly feeling stronger and faster, their claws sharper. They leered at Panga.

They went on the offensive this time, leaping at their nemesis to deliver kicks and downward slashes. Panga was quick, but the jacket gave Double Trouble the extra advantage they needed, putting Panga on the defensive. The fighting form the feline woman practiced was efficient and precise, but compared to the pure fury of Catra's fighting style, it was not enough.

Panga blocked a kick to the face just as she received a slash to her side—yowling in pain—Panga backed up, holding her side.

“Had enough, crazy woman?” Double Trouble said in a perfect imitation of Catra’s voice.

Panga panted and removed her hand, revealing four rips in her strange black and green outfit, blood welling from the cuts. Double Trouble watched in amazement as the outfit’s material shifted over the tears, sealing them to stem the blood flow. Panga gazed up at them and grinned.

“Hand-to-hand fighting isn’t the only weapon at a Madgēcot’s disposal,” Panga said, reaching down to her torso.

Between two fingers, she pinched one of the black strips comprising her outfit and somehow pulled it off—the outfit sealing as she balled the removed section in her hand. Then, with a flick of her wrist, the material flew at Double Trouble—who ducked. Once it was over their head, it exploded in a shower of rainbow-colored sparks that rained down—absorbing into their body.

Double Trouble gasped as they felt their connection to entropy suddenly vanish. They transformed—not back into the shape they had grown accustomed to—but their original form, the form they suffered in before they accepted the power of entropy. Even worse, the Imp was naked, wearing only Shen’s jacket.

Double Trouble was utterly horrified. They wrapped their arms around their chest, drawing their knees up and encircling their tail around their whole body.

“NO!” They screamed in a feminine voice. “NO! GIVE MY POWERS BACK! PLEASE!”

Panga studied them with pity in her eyes. “The Chakra Block is only temporary. Your powers will return in time,” she said, walking over to them. “Unfortunately, I’m not going to wait for that,” She said, raising a clawed hand to strike at Double Trouble. They cringed, closing their eyes and readying themselves for oblivion.

‘PANGA, NO!” A voice shrieked.

Double Trouble opened their eyes to see Flit standing at the entrance, a horrified expression on her little face. Panga abruptly snapped out of her fury, retracting her white claws and dropping her hand down to her side.

“Flit!” She said incredulously. “You promised to stay away from Double Trouble! What are you doing here?”

The Imp gasped as they felt their powers of entropy returning, quickly transforming back into their true form. Sitting back up, they ran desperate hands over their chest and hips, trying to reassure themselves everything was back to normal.

Flit ran past Panga to Double Trouble, placing her small body between the two combatants.

“I won't let you hurt them, Panga! Please stop!” Flit pleaded to her friend.

Panga stared at Flit, her eyes wide and ears lowered in shock. “Flit! You have no idea what they are involved in. The Sable is killing people! Innocent people!”

Flit shook her head. “No, that’s not true! It can’t be. Double Trouble is my friend! They wouldn't be involved in something that hurts people!” She stated emphatically.

Panga walked over to Flit and kneeled in front of her, placing a clawed hand on the little girl’s shoulder.

“Flit, I saw it with my own eyes. I followed a man who bought Sable from one of the other children back to where he lived. It was killing him, and I’m certain it was killing all the people around him. It's evil, Flit. Don’t you trust me?”

Flit glanced back at the Imp, uncertain. “Yes, of course, Panga. But please, don’t hurt them. Don’t hurt Double Trouble.” She pleaded, turning to her friend.

Panga studied Double Trouble, skepticism and scorn written on her orange face. They felt a sudden surge of fear as they remembered their powers being stripped from them, reverting from their true form and back into their original one. The Imp cowered in fear from Panga's gaze.

Panga hissed in annoyance. "Okay, Flit, I won't hurt them." She said, leaning down to speak directly into the Double Trouble's face. "But you're done selling Sable. I'm going to be watching you," she snarled, baring her fangs menacingly. "Let's get out of here, Flit."

Flit nodded before turning back to Double Trouble. "I'm sorry, but I can't work for you anymore," she said apologetically, following Panga out the front door.

Double Trouble watched them leave, feeling despondent and confused. Many questions were swirling around their head—even more than before Panga's little visit.

You have no idea what they are involved in. The Sable is killing people! Innocent people!

Panga's words burned in their mind like a curse. They had no reason to believe her; she was a complete stranger—one who attacked and violated them, stripping them of their powers of entropy. But for reasons they could not define, Double Trouble felt Panga was telling the truth. Or at least, she believed she was telling the truth.

The Imp groaned, picking themselves up to limp through the back door. They made their way slowly to the stairs, climbing up to their private apartment to make their way to where they kept their medical kit. Sitting on their luxurious bed, the Imp tentatively stroked their tail, examining the scratch marks Panga had left. It was quite the vicious slash the fierce woman gave them.

I didn't even know her and she wanted to hurt me, Double Trouble thought, dabbing some medicated ointment into their

hand and gently applying it to their wound. *Whatever she had seen had made her angry enough to come here and try to kill me.*

They remembered the Sable, the way it gave them such pleasure in exchange for a part of their life essence. If you used the Sable too much, it could potentially be harmful—*but death?* Double Trouble was selling the Sable for Yikka, and there was no way she would intentionally do something harmful to others. The Yikka they remembered cried when she accidentally hurt a classmate on the playground; it took Double Trouble the rest of the day to calm her down enough to forgive herself. But that was a long time ago…

Double Trouble sighed to themselves, leaning back into the softness of the bed, letting it cradle their bruised body as they snuggled into the pillows. They let their mind drift back to when they helped Catra do something horrible, all the while knowing it was for a greater purpose.

Atreyen is in the room adjoining Catra's bedroom, the one where she, Scorpia, and Entrapta—before the technical Princess was betrayed and sent to Beast Island—would gather to plan their strategies. It is right after their rescue of Catra—who is currently cleaning herself up and patching up the injuries she sustained during her battle with Glimmer. Catra mentioned an idea she wants to share with Atreyen, a plan to strike a grievous blow against the rebellion, something she needs them for.

Atreyen takes in the room; in one corner, they notice the old computer terminal Entrapta had once used, now covered in dust. There is also a couch nearby, just big enough for three people to sit on, positioned in front of another viewscreen, much larger than the one on the computer terminal.

Atreyen suddenly jumps as they step on something that squeaks. They bend over at the waist and inspect it; it appears to be some sort of toy mouse.

“Sorry about that,” a voice says behind them. “Scorpia’s always getting those stupid things for me.”

Atreyen turns to see Catra exiting her bedroom—she kicks the toy mouse under the couch. Out of her usual maroon, red and black bodysuit, Catra wears only undergarments; a pair of gray and white tight shorts, and a top with the Horde symbol emblazoned on the front. She seems completely unconcerned about the fact that they are basically seeing her in her underwear.

It is also the first time Atreyen has seen her without her headpiece, and they are struck by how different she looks. Catra is still lovely—but without the hard and cruel lines of her facemask. She absently runs clawed fingers through stone gray hair, sweeping it back from her face—then turns to notice Atreyen watching her.

“What?” She asks, hands on her hips and tail twitching.

Atreyen jolts out of their stare, laughing it off. “Oh, nothing, darling. It's just that this outfit isn't as fashionable as your other one.”

Catra snorts at this. “Well, I don’t need to wear that outfit for what we need to talk about—besides, it's just you and me here. Scorpia’s off on a mission for Hordak. I feel like I can be more… casual with you.” Catra says with a small smile.

It is a good thing Atreyen has complete control over their outward appearance, or else they would blush uncontrollably. They don’t say a thing, only giving Catra a small bow and a smile in return.

“Okay, down to business,” Catra says as she hops over the couch and plops down on the cushions.

She picks up a controller and activates the viewscreen as Atreyen takes a seat next to her. The proximity to a semi-clad Catra makes Atreyen feel as if bugs are crawling over their body, and they force themselves to focus on what she is showing them.

After pressing a few buttons, a map of Etheria appears—red dots indicating the position of the Horde forces along with the assumed location of the rebels. Catra zooms in on one of the rebel kingdoms—Salineas—where five Horde naval flotillas are stationed just outside of the visual range of the kingdom.

"We have a chance to strike a blow against the rebels by taking out Salineas, but we need the Princesses distracted—especially Mermista and She-Ra—so we can move in quickly and overwhelm the forces there," Catra says. She presses another button, bringing up images of Mermista and She-Ra. Atreyen notices a tightening around Catra's eyes and lips as she considers the image of She-Ra.

"That's where you come in. I need you to take the form of that ridiculous Flutterina and keep the Princesses tied up somewhere, preferably at Bright Moon. I don't care how you do it, just as long as they are distracted for a day and a night. Can you do that for me, Double Trouble?" Catra says to them, hope in her beautiful heterochromatic eyes.

Atreyen gives her their most toothy grin. "Of course, darling, anything for my Kitten," they reply coyly, twirling their hair.

Catra grins at this, taking their playful banter as a silly tease, not knowing their true feelings for her. This plan will also give them the perfect opportunity to make contact with the rebels, enacting their overall plan to help save Catra from her current path.

Atreyen suddenly feels uneasy as they realize this plan means a kingdom will fall. Usually, this is not something they worry about; falling kingdoms serve the cause of entropy. But this kingdom will be taken by force, meaning people might get hurt—or killed. Atreyen is not comfortable with that.

"So, Kitten," they say, continuing to stare at the map while twirling their hair, "How are you going to take Salineas? Break down the gates and just wipe everyone out? Or just use your ships to just blow the place up, annihilating everyone?"

For a brief moment, Catra's eyes widen as her ears lower. She glances down before retaining control over her emotions. This is one of the many reasons Atreyen wants to save Catra—she does not belong where she is; she is too tender-hearted.

"Uh, no," Catra begins, stammering a little, "Nothing like that. Hordak has some kind of hand cannon he built using First One's technology. He will use that to break down the magic barrier while our ground forces will storm the place. Every Horde soldier is armed with a stun staff that doubles as an energy projector. We can normally subdue a rebel population without many casualties. What is the point in ruling Etheria if you kill everyone?" Catra says, forcing a chuckle.

Atreyen makes a bored sound while inwardly, they feel some relief. This plan will be messy—but knowing that people would not die made them feel a little better. They could work with that. Even better, they might be able to live with that.

Double Trouble sighed out loud. Those times on Etheria were so much more straightforward than life now—now, their emotions felt like a tornado—reuniting with Yikka and the mystery surrounding her. The feline warrior Panga accusing the Imp of evil, that the Sable they were distributing for Yikka was killing people.

This Panga, who somehow knew Catra—*how is that possible?* She made it seem like they were friends, and if Panga was friends with Catra, what did that say about her accusations of Double Trouble?

The Imp sat up, rubbing their confused head. *There is only one way to get to the bottom of this*, they thought, getting to their feet and walking to the stairs.

I need to speak to Yikka. I need her to tell me the truth, and there is no better time than the present.

* * *

Panga shrugged back into her cloak as she left the candy shop, feeling the slashes the Catra imposter gave her mending under

the Jaadoo suit. Flit walked quickly past her, not saying a word as she scurried down the street. Panga did not need her experience as a mother to know the little girl was angry with her.

"Flit! Wait! I want to talk to you!" Panga called, using her long legs to catch up with the child. She leaned down and gently put her hand on Flit's shoulder—the little girl whirled—the vim in her expression startling the warrior woman.

"I can't believe you, Panga! They are my friend!" She screamed, tears in her eyes. "If I hadn't shown up, what were you going to do? *Kill them?"*

Panga stood back up, peering down at the little girl with sorrow. "I'm sorry, Flit, but you didn't see what I saw. The Sable is evil. It's hurting people. Don't you believe me?"

"Yes, I believe *you,* Panga; why do you think I agreed to stop selling it? Why don't you believe *me* when I say that Double Trouble is not bad? Maybe they didn't know like I didn't. Did you think of that?" Flit said, waving her little arms at Panga in exasperation.

Panga considered that. She was so angry when she witnessed the effect Sable had on that poor man and all the people around him —it drove her into a fury—and the fury of a Madgēcot can be terrible.

Panga let out a soft growl that ended in a sigh, rubbing at the sides of her temples to help release some of the bad energy. Flit was observing her expectantly, lowering her little arms back down to her sides.

Panga remembered stripping Double Trouble of their magic by using the Chakra Block. How they changed to the form of a woman—a rather beautiful woman—but they were horrified by it. It was like she had done the most terrible thing imaginable to them—Panga could not help feeling a pang of regret that she had done that to another living being.

Also, this Double Trouble somehow knew Catra—had transformed into her and fought with the fury of a Madgēcot. In order to have done that, this Double Trouble would have had to have known Catra, perhaps even been friends with her.

Maybe you were a little too quick to take action, Panga, she thought, kneeling once more in front of Flit.

"I do believe you, Flit, and I'm sorry I attacked your friend. I'm glad you were there to stop me, for I believe I would have regretted what I was about to do. Thank you." Panga apologized, holding out her arms. "Do you forgive me?"

Flit, who was trying her best to maintain an angry face, suddenly broke into a big smile and leaped into Panga's arms, squeezing the feline woman's sides with her little arms. Panga winced as she felt Flit pressing on the exact spot her healing slashes were, but did not protest, laying her cheek on the top of the little girl's head.

Panga felt the rest of her anger and fury completely melt away in the face of the child's unconditional love and started to purr.

Chapter End Notes

Illustration by Iria, a.k.a, ilikeyoucatradora on Tumblr and Instagram.

The Church

Chapter Summary

> Seeking answers, Double Trouble pays Yikka a visit, discovering her in the last place they would ever expect to find their first love.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The rain pattered gently against the tinted windows of the taxi speeder, creating beads of moisture that immediately steaked backward with the vehicle's forward momentum. Through these blurry lines, Double Trouble watched the tall building pass by, feelings of excitement and dread mingling into a soup of numbness within their chest.

RUN

Excitement for in no time they would be with Yikka—so soon after their reunion the night before. The brief meeting had been full of so much future promise, awakening old feelings within the Imp; emotions, and sensations they had not felt since they were young—when the initial forays into romance still had its mysterious and stimulating appeal.

But then there was the dread.

Double Trouble had so many questions for Yikka, so many things didn't seem right or out of place. They did not like having to take the role of inquisitor so soon into what felt like a second chance with their first love, but it had to be done. Double Trouble had to know the truth of what was going on—but they were so very, very afraid of the answers.

With a sigh, the Imp tried to get comfortable in the cushions of the taxi speeder; their bumps and bruises from their encounter

with Panga were still grieving them. Then there was the vicious slash, still evident on their tail, so close to their bottom.

On top of everything, I have that Madgēcot Star Hunter breathing down my neck, they thought with annoyance. *What even is that? More like a Mangy-Cat Star Hunter.*

Double Trouble chuckled to themselves, imagining calling Panga that to her face the next they saw her. But then they remembered how she took their powers away and the smile dried upon their face.

I have to figure out what to do about her if I want to continue selling Sable. Maybe Yikka has an idea. After all, she is the great and almighty Janus—Crime Lord.

The taxi started rising higher as it approached its destination, the rain seeming to fall harder as they got closer, tapping heavily on the metal exterior of the Taxi, sounding as if skeletal hands were rapping on the outside, knocking to be let in. The beads of collecting rain were no longer forming parallel lines upon the exterior of the glass—now they veered chaotically—forming imaging that, to Double Trouble's mind, appeared like leering skulls.

The Imp shook those grim thoughts from their mind as they tried to make out the mega-structure through the rain-blurred window. It appeared like a dark blob—but then suddenly, as if by magic—it could be made out clearly in the mid-afternoon gloom. Double Trouble's earlier feelings of unease intensified at the sight of their destination.

Like the other mega-structures, it was enormous, but that was the limit to the similarities. Where the other massive buildings were constructed of straight lines and functional, this building was more fluid and ornamental, shaped like an immense octagonal column. Looking closely, the Imp could discern that it was comprised of millions of stone spires and buttresses, all heaped upon one another in a complicated, confusing jumble. In addition, there

were large expanses of multicolored glass of varying shapes and sizes, placed haphazardly amongst all that complexity, seeming without any thought to reason or practicality.

At the very top of the gigantic Gothic building was what seemed like another structure—all black and shaped like a pyramid. As the taxi speeder circled the mega-structure, Double Trouble noticed a long, vertical rectangular window on one of the four triangular sides.

A lot of effort and work had obviously gone into constructing this monolith. It was like a piece of art, and like all art, it evoked a certain sentiment. For Double Trouble, it made them feel small and insignificant—as if they were in the presence of something greater than them, a higher power.

It reminded the Imp of something they had never seen on Etheria, but it was everywhere on the planet they and Yikka had come from. They strained their memory for the word when it popped suddenly into their head.

A church. It was like the whole building was a church—a great big church with another church sitting on the top.

What is Yikka doing in a place that looks like a church? Double Trouble thought as the speeder decelerated to land on a large landing platform near the apex of the building. They watched as two large doors opened outward towards the landing platform, and a small figure strode out swiftly. It was a well-dressed woman—like Olistene but older—smiling warmly as she came to greet the Imp.

As the taxi came to a complete rest, the side doors opened, sliding up and out like wings. The well-dressed woman leaned down smoothly, holding out a well-manicured hand to Double Trouble. They clasped it; it was warm and soft, and she politely guided them out of the speeder.

“Welcome, welcome!” She said in a richly accented voice, marking her as part of the upper class of Thenlor. “Welcome to the Numen, Double Trouble! I am Mrs. Saliare—but you may call me Carmen."

Double Trouble started at this; something about the building’s name troubled them.

"*The Numen?* What a strange name, my dear Carmen. What is this building? Is it a church or something?”

Carmen gave a high-pitched laugh. “Oh, good heavens, no! That is just what Janus called it when he took over the place. The name kind of… stuck.” She said with a shrug and a chuckle. “The Numen is simply the headquarters for the Vibrissa—nothing more. There is no worship taking place here, I can assure you!”

Double Trouble was put a little more at ease by Carmen's friendly demeanor and followed the woman across the landing pad and towards the open doors. As the Imp and Carmen passed through the entrance, the double doors closed smoothly and gently, making a soft sound much like a gentle sigh.

The Numen's inside was much different from the outside. Double Trouble found themselves following Carmen along a beautiful broad hall; the walls and floor composed of opalescent marble that gleamed like the Moonstone in Bright Moon. Peering up, the Imp could make out gold geometric frescoes on the ceiling, shining down upon them like the most beautiful sunrise.

Complementing the aesthetics was a fragrance wafting through the air—rich and woody with a floral hint—it was subtle yet calming. Double Trouble’s long green ears pricked up as they heard a sweet song, like soft chimes in the background, almost imperceptible.

The earlier sense of feeling small and in the presence of power was still there, but now the Imp felt peace and calm instead of unease. The dread vanished, leaving them with a sense of

happiness—happiness that they would soon be reunited with Yikka.

Tucked in an alcove along the hall was a pair of smooth metallic doors with a control panel to one side. As Carmen pressed a button on the panel, the gold doors whisked open, revealing a luxurious elevator paneled in rich woods. The well-manicured woman then indicated that Double Trouble should enter, a broad smile adorned on her face.

"This will take you straight to The Temple; there, Janus awaits you," Carmen said.

"The Temple?" The Imp responded, a curious expression on their face. "You are not coming with me, honey?"

Carmen shook her head vigorously. "No, no, I am not allowed in The Temple. Only guests of Janus are."

"Hmm," Double Trouble shrugged, striding into the elevator. They were actually glad not to have Carmen around when they meet Yikka; they would rather be alone with her.

The doors closed, and Double Trouble felt the elevator begin its smooth ascent. They rested against the cool wood paneling of the elevator interior, enjoying the feeling of calm. The past day had been absolute chaos for them, and even though the Imp enjoyed sowing chaos, they did not like being on the receiving end of it. It seemed so worth it now, worth all the doubt and uncertainty—like everything was going to be okay.

Double Trouble let their mind drift to another time, a time when their gambit to help someone they cared about succeeded and everything turned out for the best in the end.

Stroking the wooden counter with a damp cloth, Atreyen makes an attempt to clean away last night's grime. They really hate clean-up duty, but at this stage of ownership, Atreyen really can't afford to hire anyone to do it for them.

As they scrub at a particularly nasty smudge, the rag slips out of their grasp and onto the floor, causing them to kneel to retrieve it. Glancing up, Atreyen is given a view of the underside of the counter—they gasp. There is a wad of filth left behind by the thuggish bartender they had fired when they took over the establishment—it is still fresh and gooey, clinging to the bottom of the countertop in a gelatinous wad.

"Ewww!" Atreyen exclaims, standing up quickly to clutch at their tail. "Oh, why? Why me? What have I gotten myself into?" They cry to no one in particular.

A chuckle from behind Atreyen makes them freeze in place.

"You really are good at getting yourself into trouble, aren't you, Double Trouble?"

Atreyen recognizes that voice immediately—they rise and turn, still clutching their tail and feeling uneasy.

Catra.

Grinning, she strides out of the glass elevator and into the Enchanted Grotto, looking completely different than the last time Atreyen had seen her—still wearing a variation of the skin-tight maroon and black leotard, Catra's facemask is now gone, and her hair is much shorter. Their old employer almost seems like a completely different person, yet Atreyen can still recognize the gleam of mischief in her heterochromatic eyes.

She is also still absolutely beautiful.

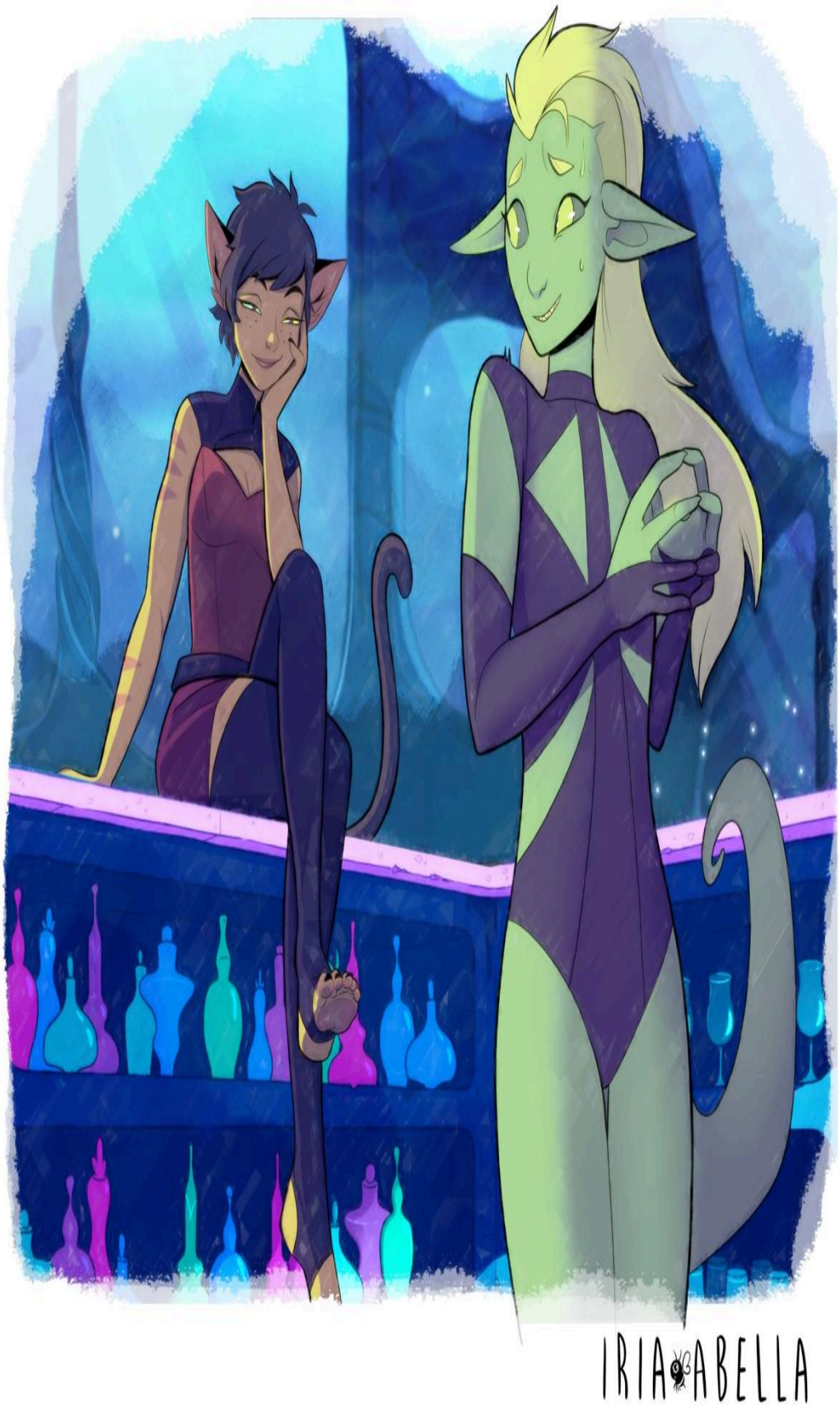
The last time Atreyen had seen Catra, they had just horribly betrayed her—double-crossing her by helping the rebels stage a surprise attack on the Horde, all the while pretending to be working for her. Atreyen had also pretended to be a friend to Catra, for they knew that she saw them as her one and only friend—Scorpia had left, and Catra betrayed and exiled Entrapta. Atreyen had even manipulated Hordak into turning against Catra, forcing her into a battle with the Horde ruler and defeating him.

She had been alone and vulnerable when Atreyen delivered their coup de grâce, informing Catra of their betrayal of her while simultaneously forcing her to face the reality of her situation: that Catra is not where she was supposed to be, that she is fighting for the wrong reasons. That Catra did not really want power for power's sake—she was using it as a misguided means to make people stay with her—not abandon her like she felt Adora did. That up until that point, Catra's life is an absolute lie.

Atreyen had delivered that news to a broken Catra seemingly with relish, but on the inside, they felt like dying. Injuring Catra that way, even though it was for the best, hurt them equally, for they cared so deeply for her. It took a lot of effort to walk away from her, to abandon her while she watched them leave forlorn eyes.

Now Catra is here—in Atreyen's recently purchased establishment. She is much changed but no worse for wear. Is she here for revenge? To get back at them for betraying her? They remember seeing what she had done to Hordak, and he had been armed with a hand cannon. Atreyen is just holding a wet rag.

Still grinning, Catra strides over and hops up on the bar; she sits back to lean on one arm, gazing at them.


IRIA ABELLA

"So you really bought this dump, huh? From what Scorpia told me, they had some kind of fight here, breaking the glass and sinking the whole place." Catra stated nonchalantly, tapping her black claws on the countertop. Her extremely sharp black claws.

Atreyen gulps. "Uh, yeah. It took the last owner a month to patch the glass dome, pump out the water and dry the place out. They tried to re-open, but were in so much debt with all the repairs they had to sell the joint. I was able to sweep in and purchase the place at a bargain."

Catra laughs at this. "Yeah, you are pretty good at being at the right place at the right time when someone is at their most vulnerable." She said without any rancor.

Atreyen sighs heavily. "Kitten, if you're here to—"

Catra waves them silent. "I'm not here to hurt you, Double Trouble. I'm not like that anymore—at least I'm trying not to be. I want to thank you."

They gape at her incredulously. "Thank me?"

Catra gives them a kind smile and Atreyen feels their heart beat faster.

*"Yeah, your betrayal of me, even though it was **pretty horrible**," she says, emphasizing the last two words, "Was the first step on my new path. A path that led off the path of darkness and may allow me some form of redemption. A path that led me to love, to happiness—to Adora." She said, beaming now. "What you did was probably the best thing anyone did for me."*

Atreyen feels a warmth infuse their core; Catra's words mean more to them than she could possibly know, but they don't allow even a fraction of it to show. They give her their most winning smile—full of charm mixed with a hint of guile.

"Oh, honey, I'm so glad you and Adora finally got together. Wow! I mean, the two of you fighting all that time... it was so obvious to

everyone you two should just hook up."

Catra laughs at this, shaking her head. "You're really something else, Double Trouble. I guess I can always count on you being a rogue, huh? Tell me, did you betray me just for the money the rebels paid you? I remember you saying they had a super-weapon, but was there something else in it for you?"

Atreyen shrugs at this. "Naw, I did it all for the cheddar, hon. Sweet, sweet money."

Catra tilts her head and squints at them. "I don't know. Part of me feels like you were doing it to help me. That you were orchestrating that whole thing to make me realize the error of my ways."

Atreyen suddenly feels a jolt as Catra eyes them suspiciously, but then she lets out of bark of laughter and relaxes.

"Nawwww…" Both Catra and Atreyen say to each other simultaneously, ending in laughter.

With a loud *ding*, the elevator came to a halt, yanking Double Trouble from their memories. The glossy doors then slid smoothly apart, revealing their destination.

It was a vast space, the dimensions of which matched the black pyramid at the top of the mega-structure—three of the four walls slanting inwards until finally meeting together in a pinnacle, high above. The walls were composed of glossy black material, reminding Double Trouble of the dreaded Sable, but the floor was of the same opalescent marble as the lower building—the Imp's feet making a clipped tapping as they proceeded out into the chamber.

Scanning behind them, they noticed that the wall that housed the elevator had sealed off what was one-third of the rest of the pyramid. Two black double doors stood to the left of the elevator door, appearing to give entry to what lay behind the wall. Facing forward once more, they recognized the huge rectangular window

they spotted on their taxi ride sitting on the opposite side of the room. It was even larger in person, giving a fantastic view of the dark and rainy cityscape.

Sitting in front of this window was a large desk, and behind this desk was a figure with their back turned to them, gazing out the window. Yikka turned as Double Trouble neared, her face beaming with absolute happiness.

"Atreyen!" She cried, rising quickly from around the desk, hands held out to greet them.

Double Trouble found that they could not maintain their outward appearance as their face broke out into a wide grin. They could not help it; they were smiling like a lovesick fool as they grasped Yikka's hands. She pulled them in for an embrace followed by a kiss—passionate and sweet.

The two parted and gazed at one another, their wide toothy grins a reflection of one another. Yikka then cocked her head as she appraised Double Trouble, her expression turning to one of concern.

"I'm really glad to see you, Atreyen, but I feel like you're here because something is wrong—it's written all over you, my love." She said, stroking Double Trouble's cheek with the tips of her clawed fingers.

Double Trouble felt a jolt that someone had read them so well, especially with the control they had over their own body language. The Imp suddenly realized that when Yikka was in the form of Borpt, she had been able to discern their feelings while keeping her own hidden. It was disconcerting to be at such a disadvantage, especially when Double Trouble had been a master of disguise for so long.

"Yes, my love, yes. I'm sorry…" They started, then stopped, not knowing how to continue. Examining the desk, the Imp noticed odd trinkets and things they were unable to identify. On the front

of the desk was a long pole or staff; it was mounted horizontally on a stand—like it was a trophy. Double Trouble thought it was a strange thing to keep on a desk, and for a brief moment, they thought they recognized the staff… but then Yikka gently guided their face so they were once again gazing into her eyes.

"I know why you are here. Don't worry, it's fine." She said kindly. "There are so many questions you need answers to, so many holes in my story. I will tell you everything. Just ask me."

Double Trouble thought on this, trying to collect their mass of jumbled confusion into logical questions. They started at the beginning, where Yikka had ended her story the night before.

"Yikka, you said that you came to this universe because you followed me here, right? Because you love me," they began.

Yikka nodded her head emphatically. "Yes! Yes, my love! That is an easy question! I would follow you anywhere!"

Double Trouble held up a finger to stop her from continuing. "Please, Yikka, don't lie to me—*please*. You said you would tell me the truth, right? Yikka, this universe was not the first place I came to when I gained my powers. I ended up on a planet called Etheria in a dimension called Despondos. If you were following me, why did you not end up there?"

Yikka's face fell before she turned from them, gazing out the window.

"You're right, Atreyen; I did not end up on Etheria." She replied quietly.

"Yikka, where did you go? Did you end up on Thenlor? Or some other planet in this Universe?" Double Trouble asked tentatively.

Yikka wrapped her arms around her body and shook her head. "No, I didn't." She said, letting out a long sigh. "Oh, Atreyen, I was telling you the truth when I said I followed you here, that I could sense you through my love for you. If that was the only

thing determining my course, then I would have found you in the beginning."

"When I gained my powers, I was in a different place than I am now—mentally, that is. Those monsters in the Conversion Center basically tortured me—cut my body and my mind. I was furious, and I wanted to seek revenge on all those people that hurt us, that drove us apart. As I was making my way to you, I was steered off course and taken to another place through my anger and lust for vengeance." Yikka said, reaching up as if to grasp something.

"Where, Yikka? Tell me." Double Trouble said.

She turned to them, a fearful, far-off look in her eyes as she spoke to them in a strange whispery language. Double Trouble felt their blood turn to ice in their veins as they recognized that speech, for they had heard Shen speak it in his dreams… or his nightmares.

"It means the Place of Night, and it is a good name," Yikka continued. "An entire universe composed of darkness and demons, and at the center, a dark goddess standing sentinel over a dark planet. The planet where I ended up is called Shen'Dar-oom. That is what my rage and anger got me."

Double Trouble rushed forward and embraced Yikka as she suddenly started to weep. From what Shen had told them of Shen'Dar-oom, it was much, much worse than the planet they and Yikka had come from.

"Ohhh, my poor Yikka," they soothed, stroking her hair. "Why didn't you tell me? Someone who is close to me is from that place. I know how hard it must have been for you."

Yikka regarded Double Trouble, sorrow in her eyes. "I know, Atreyen, I know. But I was worried what you would think of me," she said, trying to keep the tears from coming back.

“Nonsense,” Double Trouble responded, but Yikka withdrew from their embrace.

“Well, Atreyen,” she said, getting a hold of her emotions and running a hand through her hair. “Let me finish my story before you come to that conclusion.”

“I arrived on Shen’Dar-oom completely disoriented. I’m sure your friend told you how dark the planet always is, even during the day. I arrived at night, and it was horrible; the stars were the red eyes of demons peering down from a black sky, always watching you.”

“My arrival quickly brought the attention of the sorcerers of the planet, and they sent out a pack of their horrible undead Szi'th to hunt me down. They cornered me in a cave in one of the haunted forests and captured me, bringing me back to their castle. There, I was brought before their ruler, the Shen’Aan-war.”

“He deemed that I was to be put to good use and given to his sorcerers—the Death Binders—who magically bound me and brought me to their chambers below the castle. They placed me in a horrible pool and cast incantations upon me. I was corrupted by them, corrupted by their magic to serve them—which I did unwillingly for many years. I don’t remember much of that time… it’s really just a blur…”

Yikka rubbed her head and shivered, and Double Trouble once again reached out to hold her, but she stopped them, holding up her arms and shaking her head.

“No, no comfort, not yet; let me finish.” She said.

“Somehow, the Shen’Aan-war and his minions were able to come to this galaxy, bringing all their weapons and forces with them—including me. The host of Death Binders I accompanied took me to this planet, to Thenlor, using me to enforce their will. Then, one day, their power over me seemed to weaken and I was able to gain some of the control I had over myself once again. I did not

let them know this, for I feared they would reinforce their hold upon me. I used this opportunity to watch my tormentors and learn their ways—so eventually I could escape."

"But it was not necessary, for abruptly they all left. I overheard one say that their lord— the Shen'Aan-war—had the means to gain entry to this universe through a place on Etheria, which is where they went. Not too long after their departure, I was totally free; their bindings on me unraveled into nothingness."

Yikka illustrated this by interlocking her fingers, then separating her hands with a small smile on her face.

"But it was not over for me, Atreyen. The corruption still existed. I don't know what they did to me, but the power Janus gave to me —the power of entropy—was tainted by their Death magic. I can still feel it inside me, like oil or slime, sliding through my veins and running down my bones."

Yikka hugged herself again, shivering. Double Trouble had to force themselves not to go to her and place her within their arms.

"I was not left totally bereft of a solution, though, for the Death Binders had left behind the means to my salvation. I had learned much from them, and through the grimoires and scrolls they left, I found a way to free myself of their corruption. That codex I had you retrieve from Xayide was the last piece of the puzzle." She said, letting out a sigh of relief.

"What about the Sable? Is that part of your plan to free yourself?" Double Trouble asked tentatively.

Yikka nodded. "Yes, it is the key. The Death Binders had just finished constructing this temple before they left. I have no idea what purpose it was to be used for, but it is constructed of a material not found anywhere in this universe. They summoned the stuff straight from their world through an inter-dimensional portal and assembled this place, piece by piece."

Yikka guided Double Trouble over to one of the corners of the vast room. There, they noted that huge gouges had been cut in the shiny black walls.

"I discovered this material is a kind of psionic property, giving people intense positive experiences. I decided to call this material Sable. When someone uses Sable, their heightened emotions take the form of energy, and if you have the right method to transport and store that energy, you can use it for a powerful rite or spell. Like the spell of cleansing, the spell I need to cast in order to free myself of this curse."

Yikka turned to Double Trouble, holding out her hands and placing them on their shoulders. "That is what I'm doing, Atreyen. I'm selling the Sable in order to be free of a horrible taint forced upon me. That is what you are helping me to do, my love."

Double Trouble suddenly felt unsure, Panga's words running through their head.

"Yikka, I felt the effects of Sable. It felt like it was taking something from me while it was giving me happy memories." They said, apprehension in their voice. "Also, someone recently said the Sable was evil and it was killing innocent people."

Yikka's eyes narrowed, and her fingers pressed firmly on their shoulders. "Who? Who said the Sable is killing people?" She asked angrily.

"This person, a woman. She is a friend—or parent—or whatever of one of the children who sells my Sable. She came to my shop and assaulted me. She was furious, Yikka! She said I was evil and that I was selling evil, that I was *killing* people!" Double Trouble blurted out, barely keeping the hysteria out of their voice.

Yikka released Double Trouble, placing a finger to her hips. "Let me guess... is this person covered in orange fur, has a tail and white claws?"

Double Trouble was shocked. “Yes! Her name is Panga. She also called herself White Claw. She said she was a Star Hunter or whatever. Nasty piece of work she is, Yikka. Do you know her?”

Yikka laughed. “Yeah, we’ve had run-ins with White Claw. Though, I didn’t know her real name was Panga. Huh, cute name.” Yikka said, nodding to herself. “She is a pest, sticking her furry nose into other people’s business. It's what those *Mangy-cat* Star Hunters are best at!”

Double Trouble laughed at Yikka’s same humorous twisting of the word Madgēcot that they had come up with.

Yikka placed her hands back on Double Trouble’s shoulders, gently massaging them. “Don’t worry about her, Atreyen. She is like those hard-nosed people back on our home planet, those religious fanatics who only viewed the world in black and white, too blind to see that it is composed of so many beautiful colors.” Yikka laughed, then suddenly concern appeared in her beautiful yellow and green eyes. “Are you okay, Atreyen? Did she hurt you?”

Double Trouble’s face fell at the memory. “I don’t know how she did it, Yikka, but she somehow took away my powers. I was stripped of them, and I transformed… back into… the way I was. She was about to kill me if someone hadn’t stopped her.”

Pure rage appeared on Yikka’s face, and Double Trouble was taken aback by the vehemence within it.

“She is going to pay for that!” Yikka hissed, clenching her fist. “It's time I take care of that *rabid cat* once and for all!”

Double Trouble placed their hands over her clenched fist, trying to calm her. “No, Yikka honey, please don’t,” Double Trouble pleaded as Yikka regarded them with incredulity. “She is taking care of this little girl, Flit. Flit loves Panga; I can't have anything happen to her friend. It will break the little dear’s heart.”

Yikka’s anger bled away into a gentle smile. “Ohhh… I’m sorry, Atreyen, the thought of someone hurting you, someone so like

those *monsters* who hurt me… it brings out the *monster* in me. I'm sorry, I promise, I won't do anything rash."

Double Trouble sighed as Yikka pulled them into an embrace, feeling all of the earlier doubts and insecurities bleed away. Why were they so mistrustful of her? Why did they let the words of Panga—someone who had hurt them horribly—affect them so much? Why couldn't they just accept that their true love was back in their life? Yikka obviously loved them, and they loved her dearly in return.

Yikka pulled away from them, smiling, then with a thoughtful aspect, she placed her finger to her lips to turn towards the large window.

"Atreyen," she said, turning back to them, "I want to try something,"

Yikka held out her hand, and from the tips of her fingers to her elbow, her arm took on a transitional form.

"I want you to take my hand—and using your entropic powers—focus on your love for me. I will do the same." She asked, smiling shyly, like the young Yikka they remembered.

Double Trouble inspected her hand—all black with red dancing lights. They now realized why her transitional form was different from theirs—it was the corruption. Double Trouble became hesitant.

Yikka continued to smile at them. "Atreyen, remember that time in the park with the kite? Remember how I was trying to get you to fly higher? What did you say to me?"

Double Trouble smiled, a mirror of hers. "*I feel like I need someone to give me a push every once in a while*," they replied softly back to her.

Yikka nodded emphatically. "Yes! Come, Atreyen. Take my hand. Come and fly higher with me!"

Tentatively, Double Trouble walked forward, holding out their hand and allowing the power of entropy to flow through it, taking on the transitional form. Clasping her hand in theirs, Double Trouble focused on their love for Yikka.

AFTER DARK


@miledibuja

Instantly, the outline of two separate hands disappeared as the dancing green and red motes flowed into each other. The lights moved about as if on their own random paths, then veered as the two different colors were drawn to one other. Red and green lightly brushed against one another, initiating a physical reaction between the two lovers.

Double Trouble gasped; the sensual feelings they were experiencing were intense and wonderful. In their long life, the power of entropy had enabled them to take on various genders, letting them experience physical pleasure in all its capacities. But this was on another level entirely, for it transcended the physical into the magical.

The Imp could tell that Yikka was experiencing the same exact thing—her eyes were hooded in pleasure, lips parted in expectation, revealing rows of dangerous teeth. She seemed so incredibly beautiful and alive at that moment—Double Trouble's feelings for Yikka were so ardent that they clasped her other hand, doubling the flow of entropy.

Yikka suddenly gasped, drawing back and breaking their connection, leaving Double Trouble with yearning. They focused on her with questioning eyes.

"What is wrong? Was I pushing you too hard?" They asked sorrowfully.

Yikka gave a small laugh. "I'm sorry, Atreyen. That was incredible! But can we take it slow, please? It's not you, believe me. It's the corruption. I'm afraid of going too far with you. I'm afraid of corrupting you as well."

They nodded at Yikka, reaching out and taking her into their arms.

"Honey, we can take all the time we need—we have waited this long. I am going to help you beat this and will do anything to drive this darkness out of you. I promise."

Yikka nuzzled her face into Double Trouble's neck. "Thank you, Atreyen. Thank you for believing in me." She said, drawing back away from them once again. "Now, please, I have much to do, and I would like to be alone right now. I do want to see you again, and I like the idea of you visiting me. Who knows? Maybe we can keep experimenting with how far we can take this… *thing of ours."* Yikka said with a coy tilt to her head.

Double Trouble laughed as they kissed Yikka on the forehead. "I will take you up on that, my heart. I will be back soon, I promise." They said as they turned and walked back towards the elevator, their tail caressing the air around them.

* * *

I WANNA KILL YOU

Yikka watched Double Trouble as they turned a final time, waving to her before entering the elevator and blowing a kiss. Yikka laughed, returning the affection in kind as the elevator doors closed. Her beautiful face still lingered on the smile—before slowly fading into uncertainty.

Walking briskly around the desk, Yikka pressed a button on the intercom. It beeped before a tinny voice emitted from the speaker.

"Yes, Janus?" Carmen asked.

"Contact the bounty hunter—Gmork. I have a task for him." Yikka said in a deep masculine voice. "I need him to take care of White Claw once and for all."

Chapter End Notes

Illustration of Catra and Double Trouble by Iria, a.k.a ilikeyoucatradora on Tumblr and Instagram.

Illustration of Yikka and Double Trouble by Miledibuja on Tumblr, Instagram, and Twitter.

Magic Dance

Chapter Summary

> Just as Double Trouble starts to think everything is well with Yikka, new doubts arrive, casting aspersions on their love for her.
>
> Meanwhile, Panga is starting to change her opinion of a certain rogue, making herself vulnerable to them.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Sitting amongst the chaos of wood posts, planks, metal joiners, and packing material, Double Trouble inspected the instruction pamphlet in their hand, head tilted curiously. The directions were poorly written, and along with a series of vague diagrams, attempted to describe the assembly of a particular piece of furniture in a series of steps. The Imp absentmindedly stuck their tongue out and squinted, comparing the illustration of the next step to what they had recently assembled.

Oh, honey, this is all wrong, Double Trouble thought. *You didn't inherit any of your father's engineering skills, did you?*

"Dubble Twubble?" A small voice said next to them, "I think it's supposed to go like this,"

The child—Cora was her name—held up one of the wooden posts as she placed a small metal joiner in the circular slot. Then, picking up another post, Cora inserted the other end of the same joiner in its slot, connecting the two posts. The child held the construction up to Double Trouble, beaming with happiness.

Double Trouble laughed. "Oh, you are quite the little wonder, my dear Cora!" They exclaimed merrily, patting her on the head.

The Imp cast about around their main work area, noticing the other children tearing open packages and beginning to assemble their contents in little clusters. It appeared as if one group was making serious headway and were putting the finishing touches on their assembly—a bunk bed. Well, the frame at least; the mattresses were still on their way.

"Oh, marvelous, my Little Mice! Marvelous!" Double Trouble said, jumping up and clapping with happiness.

Just then, they spotted one of the children—Rory—climbing the framework of the bunk bed. The little boy had reached the top and was poised to traverse the narrow beam running the length of the assembly. Holding out little arms, he balanced himself as he began to tightrope across.

"Look at me!" Rory cried as the other children watched in awe. Suddenly fear blossomed on his face as he missed a step—the little boy cartwheeled his arms—trying to regain his balance.

Quick as a thought, Double Trouble was there to stop his fall, catching him deftly with their long arms. Rory stared up at them with amazement as they cradled him, safe and sound.

"Again!" He cried. But the Imp only shook their head in disapproval, placing him back on the ground.

"Off you go, Rory. You always seem to be getting into mischief; I think I will start calling you *Little Trouble*." Double Trouble chuckled, aiming a playful swat at the child. They missed, and the boy squealed as he ran off to join his friends.

There was a time I would have let you fall to get a good laugh, they thought to themselves. *Whatever happened to that version of me?*

The children continued their work as the Imp let their mind drift. They settled on one memory, a situation similar to the one Rory had gotten himself into—a recollection of when someone was in

danger of hurting themselves, and Double Trouble went out of their way to stop it from happening.

The Seaworthy bar reeks of sea salt mixed with dirty bodies and stale ale; Atreyen wonders why they were there.

That is right; they heard this place had some new entertainment, and as the owner of the Enchanted Grotto, it was always good to see that the competition was up to.

Following the sound of cheering, Atreyen makes their way down the stairs to the establishment's basement—as they go deeper—the stench increases its assault on their delicate nostrils, making them wince. The space below is dark, with only one dingy ceiling lamp illuminating a crowd of people shouting out wagers. It is a rough group; they form a ring around two figures circling each other—both armed with swords.

With a start, Atreyen realizes they are looking at some form of gladiator combat, people fighting for the entertainment of others. From what they remembered, it was outlawed on their home planet for thousands of years. How is this taking place on Etheria, of all places?

Atreyen wiggles their way to the front of the crowd, trying to get a closer glimpse of the fight taking place. Both combatants are shirtless but completely mismatched.

One is a huge brute, probably from somewhere in Crimson Waste. His physical appearance is much like their old comrade, Alix; pink scaly skin, sharp teeth and claws, slitted yellow eyes. He hisses in challenge to his opponent, licking the blunt edge of his blade with his long prehensile tongue.

The other is smaller in stature, a young human man not too far out of his teens. He is lean and muscular, with a faded vertical scar over his chest—where his heart is. Atreyen quickly notices that this specimen of a man is quite handsome; his long black hair

frames a noble, patrician face. But his eyes are what really draw Atreyen—dark, inquisitive, with just a hint of sadness.

Using their powers, they gaze deeper into the young man, discerning his bright soul—a good soul. But there is a shadow around this soul, hanging about it like a weight. Atreyen knows that he must have been hurt very badly in his life to be carrying a burden like this. They should know. They carry one too.

A woman enters the center of the ring, giving the odds as she takes bets from the crowd. Once this is done, she holds up her hand for silence.

"Okay, same deal as before. Whoever draws first blood wins. There are no rules, and first blood could mean anything from a scratch to a missing head!" She screams to a cheering crowd. "Are you two ready?" She asks the two combatants.

The young man nods solemnly while the brute hisses loudly in assent.

"Okay! Ready? FIGHT!" She screams, backing out from between the two gladiators as they start circling.

The brute is the first to go on the attack, screaming as he makes broad slashes with the sword—clearly not concerned with the damage he will inflict. The young man deftly hunches under these clumsy swipes, blocking the few chops that come close with economical parries of his sword.

Ducking and rolling, the young man maneuvers around his foe—but the brute spins on his heel—trying to catch the other with a decapitating chop. The young man wisely stays in a kneeling position, holding out the tip of his sword just enough for the brute to brush his arm over the razor edge in his clumsy strike, cutting himself.

"First Blood!" The female announcer calls to jeers.

The brute shakes his head in disgust as he exits the ring, leaving the crowd booing—obviously, the mob wants to see something more bloody.

The young man stays in the ring, waiting for the next challenger; Atreyen knows how this situation will end. He will keep fighting until whatever self-destructive darkness within him plays out—or someone ends him. With Atreyen's experience with their own inner demons, they understand the latter is the likelier of the two. They make a swift decision.

"Okay, who is next?" The announcer calls.

Atreyen holds up a slight arm and wiggles their fingers. "Me! I'm next!" They call jauntily.

The crowd laughs as the announcer gives them an incredulous scowl.

"Really?" She says to Atreyen, who nods back. She then turns to the young man. "You okay with this?"

He shrugs. "Why not?" He asks simply.

Atreyen holds up a finger before the announcer could go on. "One thing though, honey. I want a wager between me and handsome here. Is that allowed?"

The announcer shrugs and nods, and Atreyen addresses the young man.

"So if you beat me, I will let you have this," they say, drawing out a small bag from their pocket. They toss it to the announcer who catches it. She whistles after inspecting the contents, peering over at the young man with raised eyebrows.

"It's a lot. This is an easy win, buddy, and good reason to retire from this nasty business." She says to him.

He gives her another shrug. "I will be done when I'm done," he says tiredly. Then to Atreyen, "So what do you get if I lose? All my winnings?"

They smile and shake their head. "Nope. You leave this place and come with me, promising never to do this again."

He cocks his head. "So... what? I'd be your slave or something?"

Atreyen laughs at this. "Only if you want to be," they say coyly, enjoying the blush they receive in reply.

"Okay, enough flirting. You two are here to fight!" The announcer yells. "Get ready green and blonde, pick that sword up!"

Atreyen crosses their arms and shakes their head. "Naw, I don't need it."

"How are you going to get first blood then?" The young man asks, confusion plain on his face.

"Simple, I'm going to take that pretty sword from you—pin you—and give you a pretty little cut with it. Don't worry. I'm known to be very gentle." They respond with a grin.

The crowd jeers at this, and the young man only laughs, shaking his head.

"Okay, you two ready? When I say 'go,' you two better not do anything other than fight, you hear me?" The announcer says sternly. Both Atreyen and the young man nod as she stares back, clearly unsure what their nods are in agreement to.

"Whatever, just FIGHT!" She says, annoyance in her voice as she steps back and out of the ring.

The young man immediately crouches, sword held up in guard position as he starts to circle his opponent. But Atreyen doesn't move; they stand there, watching him coolly with arms crossed and tail swaying languidly. The young man stops his movement

and gazes at Atreyen questioningly—as if asking them what he should do next.

“Well, I’m waiting, lover-boy. Come and get me!” They say mockingly, putting their hands on their hips.

Shaking his head, the young man suddenly rushes them, sword held out to deliver a small slash. In a flash of green, Atreyen sidesteps away from the sword strike—but the young man is good—attempting to compensate with a spin much like the brute used on him, only keeping his slashing arc tighter, minimizing the damage.

With a hand chop, Atreyen lashes out and strikes the young man’s wrist, numbing his hand and causing him to drop the sword. Spinning on their heel, they sweep his feet out from under him with their tail—he falls prone onto his back. Atreyen is on him in an instant, pinning him with the weight of their body and holding his arms over his head in their firm grip.

He fights against them fiercely, struggling and growling. They admire his spirit, but ultimately it is futile; Atreyen has him. Realizing this, the young man sags in their grip, eyes wide in disbelief.

“Wow! You are a lot stronger than you look!” He exclaims.

Not pleased with this outcome, the crowd starts to boo and jeer.

“BLOOD! BLOOD! BLOOD!” The mob screams.

With the tip of their long tail, Atreyen grasps the hilt of the young man’s sword, bringing it up and around to his right cheek. There, using just the tip of the blade, they give him the smallest of cuts, drawing just the bare hint of blood. Atreyen gives him a wide grin, showing the young man rows of sharp teeth.

“I think you’re mine now, handsome.” They say lasciviously. “By the way, the name’s Double Trouble. What's the name of my newest acquisition?”

He grins back at them, his eyes full of mirth. "Shen. You can call me Shen. Nice to meet you, Double Trouble,"


HENAR TORINOS '23

“Always getting others to do your dirty work, huh, Fancy Pants Lizard?” A voice called from the entrance to the candy shop, snapping Double Trouble out of their fond memory.

The Imp turned, placing their hands on their hips. “Ah, my dear Canens! I was wondering when you were going to come by with a nasty comment, and here you are—splendid!”

The muscular woman grinned as she entered the back room, examining all the hard work taking place. Double Trouble had not laid eyes upon Canens since the night at the old docks when they had been reunited with Yikka.

“What brings you here, my dear? Another mission from Janus?” They asked, trying to maintain the façade that there was nothing amiss, that they didn’t know the truth of Janus—and therefore—the truth of the Sable.

Canens scowled, shaking her head. “Nope, Janus can keep his missions. I’m here because I wanted to tell you that I’m done. Done with working for Janus, selling his product. I wanted you to hear it from me first.”

Double Trouble hid their shock at this proclamation. “Oh? And why did you feel the need and come and tell me, my dear? You could have written a letter or something,” They replied nonchalantly.

Canens gave them a long, meaningful look. “Because, even though I tease you by calling you ‘Fancy Pants Lizard,’ I respect you. You’ve come through for us countless times, and you’re one of us, D.T.” She said, giving Double Trouble a friendly pat on the arm. “I also wanted to warn you; there’s something not right with this whole Janus business,”

Feeling a jolt through their insides, Double Trouble outwardly winced a little. Quickly getting a hold of themselves, the Imp planted a smile on their face, trying to hide the insidious dread starting to creep through their veins.

"Oh really? What's the matter? Janus late on his payments or shortchanged you, honey? I can always give you a loan," they said.

Canes pursed her lips, shaking her head again. "No, nothing that quite simple. Tibernus and Fontus were getting cold feet and didn't want to sell Sable anymore. They said it was hurting people. They went to that weird building to ask Janus directly about it."

"Oh, did Janus fire them or something?" Double Trouble asked, trying to keep calm.

Canens stared at Double Trouble, fear in her eyes. "No, D.T., they disappeared. I haven't heard from them since," she said.

Double Trouble whirled away from Canens, gritting their teeth with eyes closed.

That means nothing. It doesn't mean anything bad happened to Tibernus and Fontus. They probably just told Yikka they quit and ran off somewhere, they thought, pivoting back to Canens to plaster a weak smile on their face.

"Well, honey, thanks for the warning! But me and my Little Mice are doing fine here. We've had no problems selling that Sable!" They exclaimed.

Canens smirked at them, shaking her head. "Well, don't say I didn't warn you. Hey, if you ever need me, I'll be around. I'm using my earnings to open up a gambling salon nearby called *Nobody's Bizness*. Don't be a stranger, D.T." She said with a smile before walking out.

Double Trouble gave a smile of their own and limply waved goodbye, but once Canens was gone, they wrapped their tail around themselves in comfort. Gazing forlornly at the entrance to their candy shop, the Imp felt a little hand tug at the bottom of their black jacket. Peering down, they saw Cora gazing up at them with wide, compassionate eyes.

“Don’t be sad, Dubble Twubble. Look! We’re done!” The little girl said happily, pointing behind them

Scanning where she indicated, Double Trouble noted that all six bunk beds were completed, the children surrounding their accomplishments with joyous faces.

Double Trouble stifled a laugh and wiped at their eyes, unable to control a few tears from escaping.

Cora regarded Double Trouble with concern. “Did we do it wrong?” She asked sadly.

Double Trouble shook their head. “No, my little lamb—no. You did it perfectly. You are such wonderful little darlings.” They replied gently, laying a green hand on the little girl’s head.

The children cheered, further buoying the Imp’s mood. Double Trouble clapped their hands together, getting the children’s attention.

“For all your hard work, my Little Mice, I will reward you with a *performance!”* Double Trouble cried, full of drama. “It is from one of my best works—a masterpiece!”

The children cheered again as Double Trouble began dancing around them, singing joyously.

* * *

From the shadows of a nearby alley, Panga watched as a muscular female exited the candy shop. Squinting in the rain, the unfamiliar woman scanned up and down the street, searching for signs of danger. Seemingly satisfied that no apparent threat existed, she drew her hood up over her head before striding away.

Panga waited for a few heartbeats after losing sight of the muscular woman, just in case she doubled back. The feline warrior was only there to talk some sense into this Double Trouble, not wanting any violent altercations. If what Flit had told

her was true, then Double Trouble was a good person and could recognize that what they were doing was evil. Panga just had to keep her cool this time—without resorting to violence.

As long as they don't call me Kitten, she thought, exiting her hiding place to leap on all fours to the candy shop.

Kneeling down, Panga peeked over the bottom of one of the windows, scanning the interior of the candy shop for any other potential entanglements. Spotting only colorful confections, Panga rose to two legs and proceeded to the front door, tentatively opening it to poke her head inside. The feline warrior strained her long ears for signs of life, cocking her head when she caught the most curious sound.

Is that singing? She thought, fully entering the store. *It's coming from the back. Better check it out.*

Tip-toeing the back of the shop, Panga slowly opened the door there, revealing an even more curious scene.

It was Double Trouble, frolicking around a group of cheering children while singing the strangest song.

"*Dance magic, dance,"* Double Trouble sang, grabbing a laughing girl up into their arms. *"Put that baby's spell on me!"*

MAGIC DANCE

Double Trouble tossed the child straight up into the air and caught her, twirling around before placing the now-dizzy child back down on the ground. The rest of the children all jumped around Double Trouble, reaching up with their little arms to be next.

"*Jump magic, jump,"* Double Trouble continued, joy written on their face. "*Put that magic jump on me!"*

Panga gaped at them, her mouth wide open and long ears lowered. She had never witnessed someone so carefree—so vibrant, so full of life and fun. She instantly saw what Flit was

talking about; Double Trouble *was* a kind and generous soul. Panga found herself feeling another emotion—warm and good—deep within her core. With a start, the feline warrior realized that she was blushing—clearing her throat loudly, Panga tried in vain to stifle those unwanted feelings.

The room fell into a dead silence as everyone stopped what they were doing, heading swiveling towards the intruder.

"Uh, hello," Panga said lamely. "It seems like you guys are having lots of fun."

Upon spotting her, the expression on Double Trouble's face transformed from joy to fear. Panga was surprised to find this hurt her more than the scratch she received from the Catra imposter, the shame of it welling up inside her.

"Well, we *were* having fun—that was until you showed up, *my dear*," Double Trouble said coldly. They then addressed the children, placing a big smile on their face. "My Little Mice, why don't you go into the front and eat some candy? Does that sound good? I need to speak with our visitor here. Hopefully, she plays nice."

Eager to get their hands on the sweets, the children scurried past Panga as Double Trouble stared daggers at the feline woman. Panga awkwardly pawed the floor with a clawed foot as she looked away, too ashamed to meet the Imp's eye

Once alone, Double Trouble crossed their arms. "So, you here to beat up and violate me again, *Star Hunter*?" They said, fury plain in their voice.

Panga held her hands up in placation. "I just want to talk to you, Double Trouble. Flit said that you are a good person, and I want to believe her. I'm here to get your side of the story, that's all."

Double Trouble looked fixedly at her, not seeming to be moved by her words.

“Listen, about what I did to you... I’m sorry. When I use the Chakra Block, it’s to take magic away from an enemy—to block them from using it temporarily. When I used it on you, I had *no idea* that it would do that to you—hurt you so badly in that way. I swear on the Great Chailendra Tree that I didn’t mean to harm you like that.” Panga said imploringly.

Double Trouble continued to stare at her as their tail gave a small twitch.

“What’s a Great Chailendra Tree, darling?” They asked evenly.

Panga was taken aback by the question. “Uh… well, it’s the most sacred thing on my planet. The most special force to the Madgēcots. Swearing upon the Great Chailendra Tree is the ultimate oath a Madgēcot can make.” Panga explained.

Double Trouble pursed their lips and then let out a long sigh. “Okay, honey. I accept your apology,” they relented.

Panga cocked her head in response. “What is this ‘honey’ you keep calling me? Is it an insult? I guess I deserve it if it is...”

Double Trouble cracked a smile and shook their head. “No, it's not an insult. It's just one of my little quirks to call people ‘honey’ and ‘dear.’ Honey is something sweet and nice,” Double Trouble said before appearing thoughtful. “Maybe I should stop calling you that then,” they teased with a grin.

Panga laughed at this, finding herself charmed by this rogue. She considered Double Trouble’s smile—the dangerous rows of exposed sharp teeth while the face around the smile was open and inviting; it was strangely appealing to her.

Then Double Trouble’s expression subtly changed. The grin was still on their lips but not in their eyes; it was as if they were concentrating on something. Panga suddenly felt the fur on her shoulders stand up on end—it was like Double Trouble could peer right through her.

“Are you using magic on me?” She asked uncertainly.

Double Trouble jolted, a hint of embarrassment crossing their features before being quickly suppressed.

“In a way, yes, I was my dear. I was trying to see if I could trust you.” They replied evenly.

“So, do you now?” Panga asked.

Double Trouble shrugged their shoulders. “Meh.” They said, holding their hands out to either side of themselves.

Panga squinted her eyes while trying to stifle a smile, her tail twitching back and forth rapidly behind her. “You like to tease a lot, don’t you?” She said.

Double Trouble grinned at this. “Oh, honey, it's like you’ve known me for years,” They said mischievously.

Double Trouble gestured to the table in the center of the room, pulling out a chair for Panga while sitting across from her. Panga spotted black bags on the table and assumed they contained the evil Sable. With uncertainty, she sat in the proffered chair.

“*So.* What would you like to talk to me about, Madgēcot?” They asked as soon as she took a seat.

What's with all the different names they keep calling me? Can’t they just call me Panga? She thought, shaking her head. It made her think of something.

“Well, Double Trouble—wait, is that really your name? Is there something else I can call you?” Panga asked with a tilt of her head.

Double Trouble pursed their lips as if thinking. “No, it's not the name I was born with.” They say with a shake of their head, no humor in their voice.

“Okay, so what is the name I should call you? I don’t really like calling you Double Trouble.” Panga said.

Double Trouble broke eye contact and gazed past her, an unfocused aspect to their eyes.

“There was someone else who didn’t like using my second name, someone who also knew my first name. But he was very close to me, and you are not—my dear. Sorry,” They said will a sad shake of their head. “We just aren’t there yet, Panga.”

Panga felt disappointed at this but also hopeful. *Double Trouble cares about trust. That is a good sign,* she thought to herself.

“Okay, fair enough,” she said, holding her hands up. “Let me start at the beginning then, Double Trouble. Why do you want to sell Sable?”

The mischievous smile returned to Double Trouble’s face. “To make money, of course,” they said simply.

Panga was incredulous. “Is that all? Is that all that motivates you? I don’t believe that.” She said, shaking her head and crossing her arms.

Double Trouble rocked their head back and forth. “Well, *honey*, it was in the beginning,”

“Okay, it started off as a way to make money—but now it isn’t?” Panga asked, eyebrows raised.

Double Trouble stared at her for a long moment without making a move. Panga was starting to get uncomfortable when they finally spoke.

“No, I’m doing it to help someone—someone I thought I lost a long time ago. She was hurt very badly, and needs the Sable distributed to help heal herself.” They said in a quiet voice.

Panga tilted her head. “How? How was she hurt? Also, I do not see the connection to the Sable and being healed.” Panga stated.

Double Trouble closed their mouth and crossed their arms, clearly agitated. “I don’t know why I should go on. I’m not even sure why I told you this much. You wouldn’t understand,” they said sullenly.

Don’t shut down on me now, Panga thought to herself. *I think I need to gain a little more of their trust.*

The feline woman reached her hand out across the table to Double Trouble. “You must love this person very much, am I right? You don’t want them to suffer; you don’t want to lose them. I know what it's like to lose the ones you love.” Panga said, drawing her hand back and hugging herself with her arms. Double Trouble immediately regarded her with interest.

“I had a child once; Chhaya was her name. She was so dear to me, so very dear to me and Maira—my mate. It was when Maira and I were off-world, on a mission for the Star Hunters, that it happened. Chhaya was staying with family—watching her while we were away. They had these Ghoda—they are an animal you can ride—and Chhaya fell while riding one. She was hurt very badly.” Panga said, her voice now becoming strained with emotion.

“Maira and I rushed back to our world as fast as we could, but we did not make it in time; Chhaya slipped away before we even made orbit. Maira and I were absolutely devastated; we were beside ourselves with grief. At first, we had each other to console one another, but Maira was too angry. She blamed herself for not being there—she blamed the Star Hunters for always sending us off on missions, and in the end, she blamed me.” Panga continued, tears trickling down her cheeks.

“She blamed me because she fell in love with me and for having a child together—having someone that we cherished so much. Blamed me for giving her so much to lose. She left me not long

after, and we were both alone. Then the mission to Thenlor came up, and I volunteered, grateful to have something to do besides wallow in my sorrow." Panga said, finishing her story while wiping the tears from her eyes.

"So you see, Double Trouble, I understand better than you think." She said with a sad smile.

Double Trouble stared at her for a moment and then sighed, long and deep. "I'm so very sorry, my dear, that is horrible," they said sadly. "I've never had children, so I cannot imagine how you feel. But losing a lover is something I know quite a lot about." Double Trouble said simply before starting their own tale.

Panga listened as Double Trouble began their tale with how they were born on a planet from a completely different reality than hers. How they were born as a female but identified as neither male nor female, something Panga was familiar with.

"My name was Atreya, which is the female version of the name. I renamed myself Atreyen, the neutral version of my name." Double Trouble said.

"So that is your first name?" Panga asked.

Double Trouble nodded. "But please, my dear, don't call me that."

Double Trouble continued, how their planet was not like anywhere in this universe, that it was strict and oppressive, not recognizing any other gender distinction other than male and female. They also noted that their people absolutely forbade any relationship other than one that was between a man and a woman—Panga could not fathom that such a place could exist.

"I had this friend, Yikka. She was my best and most special friend, and I loved her, and she loved me. Over the years, we became very close, and we developed feelings for each other. Romantic feelings. We were terrified of what would happen to us if anyone found out and tried to hide it. But one day, we could not hide it

any longer, and everyone found out. That was the beginning of the end for us," Double Trouble said sadly.

Their story turned tragic, Yikka's refusal to acknowledge them, coming home to angry parents, and finally, the realization they would be sent to the Conversion Center the next day.

Panga was horrified by the notion of the Conversion Center and felt her tail bristling; she knew she sensed evil.

Then, Double Trouble's story veered from the tragic and to the fantastic. The arrival of the magical Janus and receiving the power of entropy—being transported to Etheria.

"This Janus must be one of the holders of the Ultimate Powers, the Guardians of the Magical Staves," Panga said with wonder. "The Madgēcot have records of them, but they are incomplete."

Double Trouble nodded, then continued with how they came to Thenlor to reinvent themselves, to escape their past—much like Panga did. How they then became involved with Borpt—agreeing to sell the Sable after proving themselves to Janus. Meeting Flit and creating the network needed to sell the Sable and their success with it. Then finally, to the night on the starship, their discovery of Borpt's true identity as Janus, and then as Yikka.

"I had not seen Yikka since that horrible day, so long ago. But I was not angry with her for betraying me; I was just so happy to see her again!" Double Trouble said with a wide toothy grin on their face. "And the best thing was, she didn't betray me!"

Panga listened to Double Trouble recount Yikka's horrible tale at the Conversion Center and then her salvation from torment by the mysterious Janus, giving her the same power as Double Trouble.

"Yikka tried to reach me on Etheria but became trapped in a horrible nightmare dimension called the Place of Night. I know someone else who came from there, and from what he described, it is horrible." Double Trouble said.

Panga nodded. “Yes, the Madgēcots know of the place. It is one of the many Dread Realms,” she stated simply.

“Then you know how terrible it must have been for her, for she was captured and tortured by those horrible sorcerers there,” Double Trouble said, pain in their voice.

Panga felt dread well up inside her and closed her eyes. “Yes, Death Binders they are called,”

“Yes. They did something to Yikka, something bad. They corrupted her somehow with their magic and made her their slave. When they invaded this universe, they brought her with them. And when their Set'Heth-un'dar was destroyed, and She-Ra defeated the Shen’Aan-war, Yikka was freed of their bindings. The problem was, she was not freed of their corruption.” Double Trouble explained.

“While she was their slave, Yikka learned a lot from the Death Binders—spells, and incantations. They also left this stuff behind, magic stuff that she calls Sable. She is using the Sable to collect energy to use for a spell of cleansing; supposedly, it takes a great deal of energy to cast. That is what I am doing, Panga. I’m selling Sable to help free my true love of torment. Do you understand now? Wouldn’t you do the same if you could get Chhaya back?” They said, finishing their long tale and regarding her expectantly.

Panga was quiet as her mind raced. It was a long story, and there was a lot to process. It was a confusing jumble of details, but there was one aspect of the story that Panga could not get past; Yikka’s tale just did not add up. There were too many holes, too many loose threads that could be pulled, possibly unraveling the whole story.

She regarded Double Trouble, wondering how they could be so blind. From what she knew of them, they had spent most of their life hiding their true nature. In fact, their magical powers were based on hiding their identity. Surely they were also adept at spotting falsehoods?

Panga decided she had to be careful. She felt like she was making headway with Double Trouble and did not want to ruin it after gaining some ounce of their trust.

“Yes, Double Trouble; if there was a way to get Chhaya back, I would try it. As long as this way did not involve following the path of evil,” she said, holding up a hand to forestall Double Trouble’s protest. “I’m not saying that what Yikka is doing is evil. I just don’t know. You asked, and that is what I have to say about it.”

She continued. “There is one that confuses me, though, and please forgive my ignorance. As a Star Hunter, I have traveled far and experienced much in this galaxy. I have encountered lots of magic and have witnessed magical corruption. From my experience, spells of cleansing do not take that much energy. In fact, they are done all the time on my home planet of Elysia. It is a magical place, much like your Etheria. Why don’t you ask Yikka to come with me there? You can come too. We will welcome all of you and help heal Yikka. What do you think?” Panga asked hopefully. “This way, we don’t have to use the Sable.”

Double Trouble seemed apprehensive as they considered it. “I don’t know, Panga... Yikka doesn't trust the Madgēcots or the Star Hunters. I’m not sure she would want to go with you,” they said uncertainly.

“Would it hurt to ask if it means an easier and quicker way to help her?” Panga implored.

Double Trouble sighed. “No… It wouldn’t hurt to try—you’re right,” they threw up their hands in exasperation. “I will try to talk to her.”

“Also, I know you don’t owe me, but I must ask a favor; can you please stop selling Sable until we know if Yikka will come to Elysia? *Please?*” Panga pleaded.

Double Trouble closed their eyes and nodded their assent. “Yes, I can do that,”

Panga beamed as she stood up. “Great! Now I should be going and check on Flit. Without the job to distract her, she finds other ways to get into trouble. But I will come by tomorrow to check on you.”

Double Trouble suddenly brightened at the mention of the little girl.

“Tell the little dear that Double Trouble says hi,” they said.

“I will. I’m bringing Flit to Elysia with me even if we don’t end up taking Yikka there. But you will have a chance to see her again,” she said, suddenly squinting at them and cocking her head. “You know, you are very good with them—the children, I mean. You have this way with them.”

Doubled Trouble laughed brightly at this. “Yes, my dear, I have been told that before,” they said. “See you tomorrow,”

Panga nodded as she exited out the back room and into the candy shop, immediately chuckling when discovering that the children had made a mess of the store. Candy had been spilled everywhere as the small ones gobbled it up, and two rascals were in the process of climbing the shelves to reach the higher goodies.

Panga absentmindedly waved goodbye to the youngsters, still processing Double Trouble’s story and the implications of Yikka’s mistruths. She was dubious that Yikka would agree to go to Elysia and was concerned for the end result.

Placing the hood of her robe over her head, she passed through the front door of the candy shop. Panga really hoped Yikka would go with her—the feline woman didn’t want to go up against Double Trouble again. The thought made Panga feel stressed—but not because she was afraid of them. Sure Double Trouble was a formidable fighter, and even without using the Chakra Block against them, they would still be a tough opponent to beat. No, it was because Panga was really starting to like them.

Panga was so distracted by these thoughts that she didn't spot the shock maul swinging towards her until it was too late. It hit the feline warrior full force in the side, sending her yowling across the street and into a pile of garbage. Spitting and hissing with fury, Panga leaped up out of the trash to land in a crouch. She groaned, clutching at the spot where the shock maul connected; it felt like she had multiple broken ribs.

Across the street and next to the entrance of the candy store, she spotted a figure holding a large, double-handed shock maul. Panga growled as she recognized him.

He was a hulking figure covered in a rain cowl; Panga knew from experience that he was covered in cybernetic enhancements and armor under this garment. A sharp-toothed grin split along a canine muzzle as one red eye blazed out from under a hood. He chuckled low.

"Gmork," Panga hissed. "That was a cheap shot,"

"Hello, White Claw," he growled, "Long time, no kill."

Chapter End Notes

Illustration by Henar, a.k.a., ilikeyoucatradora on Instagram and Tumblr.

The Wolf and the Cat

Chapter Summary

Caught off-guard and trapped, Panga fights for her life against the brutal bounty hunter Gmork.

Double Trouble falls into a trap different from Panga's - one even more dangerous.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Panga gave a nod of affirmation before turning to depart; Double Trouble's eyes lingered on the feline woman in an almost desperate need, her long tail giving one last twitch as it disappeared into the candy shop. There was hope blooming within the Imp's green chest, but it clashed with strong feelings of trepidation—both emotions stemming from the same source: the Star Hunter's proposition to take Yikka to her home world.

It was a kind and generous offer, and after using their powers of perception on Panga, Double Trouble found it to be genuine. The plan seemed so simple, and the notion of taking Yikka away from this dreary planet was so right. Elysia sounded beautiful—a magical world just like Etheria where they could start over there with Yikka—plus—save her without having to use that horrible Sable.

But an insidious feeling kept pulling the Imp's thoughts away from Panga's plan, covering their hopes like a dark cloud, making them feel like they were only dreaming—that going to Elysia was just a fantasy, not real. That the only real solution was the hard one: the Sable. Wasn't that what their father would say to them whenever he bothered to interact with them?

Atreya, narrow is the gate, and difficult is the way which leads to life, and there are few who find it.

Double Trouble shook their head, trying to dislodge the memory of their cold father from their brain.

Honey, why on earth are you thinking of that man? They thought, confused.

The Imp forced their mind back to Panga and her beautiful feline face, so much like Catra's. The Star Hunter was fierce and compassionate, but unlike Catra, Panga wore her heart on her sleeve—the Imp did not need their magical abilities to see this. Double Trouble found this to be the most appealing thing about Panga; after living a life based on obfuscation and hiding their true intentions, open honesty in someone was refreshing. The Imp had to admit that, in spite of the violent first meeting, they were starting to like this noble Madgēcot.

When Double Trouble had peered beneath the surface to Panga's vital spirit, they saw pain and anguish lying there; she was hurt—but not yet broken. The Star Hunter was constantly striving to put good into the universe as a means to heal her wounded soul—but it was slowly beating her down. Double Trouble found themselves grinning ruefully as a thought occurred to them.

Darling, what is it about you that seems to draw all these poor, hurt souls to you? They thought with a chuckle. *And why on earth did you spill your entire life out to Panga? You even told her your real name!*

Panga's story, the story of her lost child, matched the pain that Double Trouble had perceived inside her. She had opened herself up to the Imp, making herself vulnerable, which made them want to be vulnerable in kind. Before they made the decision to tell Panga everything, they remembered hearing a voice in their head, a memory from Etheria.

Open your heart to me, Atreyen.

Double Trouble sighed loudly to themselves. "Ohhhh… Shen, my dear boy," they said out loud, focusing on the recollection.

Atreyen wakes slowly out of a beautiful sleep to a curious sensation—there is someone in their arms.

Ah yes,** they think to themselves. **The lost lamb I rescued from himself—Shen.

It is not the first time they have woken this way, but it is the first time they are wrapped so tenderly around another person. Their arms and tail encircle Shen, pressing him tightly into their lithe body as their face nuzzles into the crook of his neck, his long black hair tickling their nose.

Atreyen becomes self-conscious and releases their hold on Shen, slowly moving away from his sleeping form. Sitting up, they remain in the bed to watch him sleep; Shen is so still and quiet, his breathing peaceful. Not like the other night when he woke from a nightmare, yelling in that strange whispery language of his. Atreyen had held Shen then, singing softly while caressing his forehead until he fell back asleep.

Atreyen likes watching him sleep. Actually, they like watching him anytime—especially when he thinks no one is looking. Atreyen adores the moments when they catch a glimpse of the sadness and fragility Shen keeps hidden behind a mask of conviviality. The veil he holds in place—too afraid to let others see his pain, believing it will drive them away.

Atreyen enjoys sitting there with Shen, being near him while he sleeps. With a sudden realization, they realize they just plain like being with him. Shen is empathetic and kind. He has a fantastic sense of humor—laughing at their wit and always quick to trade quips with them. Not least of all, Shen is darkly handsome and very passionate; Atreyen feels a smile creep on their lips as they remember their times together.

With a long weary sigh, they realize what this all means: it's time for the two of them to part ways. Atreyen is getting too close to Shen, and he is getting too close to them; they just can't have that.

With a thought, Atreyen uses their powers to clothe their naked form, getting out of bed slowly so as not to wake their bedmate. The two of them are staying in a guest room behind an opera house in Salineas—it would be easy to slip out before Shen wakes. Atreyen doesn't want to have to tell him to his face that their brief relationship is over; Shen will figure it out when he discovers they are gone. Atreyen begins to tiptoe towards the door when a groggy voice calls out to them.

"Leaving without saying goodbye?" Shen calls from the bed.

Atreyen winces as they turn to him, placing a smile on their face. "Well, darling, I just couldn't wait all morning for you to decide to get up. I was just slipping out to get us something to eat!"

Shen sits up and looks at them dubiously. "Don't lie, Atreyen. You're leaving, and you couldn't tell me to my face. Am I right?"

They sigh and grin sheepishly—they were caught. "Sorry, darling, but my relationships usually don't last this long—it's time we part company. It's just my way, honey." Atreyen says sorrowfully.

Shen gives them a sad smile. "I'm sorry to hear it, I really am. I'm going to miss you," he says. "But I understand."

Atreyen smiles weakly at this; this is just as hard as they thought it would be. "Thanks, darling. We had a great time together, didn't we?"

He nods. "Yes, we did." He says as a more serious look appears on his face. "You know, Atreyen, even if you couldn't open your heart to me, it doesn't mean you shouldn't try with someone else, you know? You deserve to be loved too,"

Shen's words strike them like a hammer, and it takes every ounce of their will not to go to him and wrap their arms around him. But Atreyen maintains their façade.

"OH, STOOOOP! You're too much, darling! You really are!" They say, bent over laughing, slapping their knees. "Can I use that line

in one of my plays?"

Shen only shakes his head as he waves them off. Atreyen recognizes real sadness in his eyes and knows they have really hurt him.

"Hey, you're going to be okay, right? I'm not going to have to come to find you in some seedy basement and drag you out again, am I?" They ask, trying to hide their concern as best as they can.

He laughs. "Yeah, don't worry about me. Hopefully, we will run into each other someday, huh?"

Atreyen gives him their most winning smile. "You can count on it, darling," they say before walking out the door.

"Dubble Twubble!!" a child's voice screamed, pulling the Imp out of their daydream. They shook their head, recognizing the girl Cora at the doorway to the shop.

"What's the matter, Little Mouse? Did you eat all the candy alread —" Double Trouble started to say before the stress on the little girl's face made them come up short.

Cora shook her head vigorously. "No! Someone is attacking the cat lady! You need to help her. Hurry!" She shouted.

* * *

The monstrous figure of Gmork strode towards Panga, swinging a massive shock maul in slow arcs like a pendulum. Clutching her side, the feline warrior watched the bounty hunter, knowing there was not nearly enough time for her Jaadoo suit to begin its magical healing before he reached her. Panga could probably escape—Gmork was nowhere near as fast as her—but she couldn't leave. Panga had no idea if he was here for her or Double Trouble—and if he attacked them—Gmork could hurt the children.

The bounty hunter was close now—and with one hand—reached up to draw back his hood, revealing a hideous lupine face. Gmork leered with sharp fangs, one yellow eye pinning his victim with malevolence while the other glowed with a dull red light—it was a bionic optic, recently installed after their last encounter.

“I see you got your eye fixed,” Panga stated, hoping to distract him with conversation.

It didn’t work, and Gmork snarled. “Yes, no thanks TO YOU!” He screamed, swinging the mighty weapon down in a crushing blow.

Panga was barely in time to leap out of the way, wincing in pain as her movement jostled the injury to her side. She wasn't moving as fast as she should be—the pain taxing her energy, making the feline warrior sluggish. Frantically thinking of a solution, Panga reached down to her Jaadoo suit, selecting the needed cantrip.

“I didn't want to take your eye out, Gmork. I’m sorry for that, but you gave me no choice. I couldn't let you hurt those people.” Panga said, pinching a green strip from her hip and pulling it away.

Gmork laughed cruelly. “That’s okay, White Claw. I just had to hurt some more people to help pay for my new eye,” he taunted.

Panga snarled as she balled the material in her hand, flinging it at her opponent. The cantrip burst into jade sparks before landing on Gmork, green flames springing up wherever it landed on his rain cowl in spite of the rain. Dropping his weapon, the bounty hunter howled in fear as he attempted to beat the flames out. Having no luck with this strategy, Gmork bent forward to tear the burning cowl off, flinging it away—he now stood before Panga in all of his armored and cybernetic majesty.

“Nice trick, *magic kitty*,” Gmork said, reaching down to his belt and removing a cylindrical metallic ball from a leather satchel. “But technology beats magic any day!”

Gmork threw the metallic sphere right as Panga attempted to leap away. As the ball sped towards the feline warrior, it popped open, ejecting a wad of silver webbing which spread out and opened like a flower. The net wrapped around Panga, causing the Star Hunter to fumble the landing, adding further harm to her injuries. Panga was in a fury now and she ignored her pain, fighting viciously to escape her trap.

Gmork grinned as he held up a wrist gauntlet, smoothly pressing a control button with his opposite hand. The metallic net instantly lit up with crackling blue energy—Panga howled as she was electrocuted. After what Gmork believed was a sufficient amount of time, he pressed the control again, ceasing the electrical current to Panga's trap. The feline warrior sagged in the restraints —now utterly spent and defeated; she lay on her back, breathing heavily.

Gmork picked up his shock maul, laying the handle over his shoulder to casually stride over to his vulnerable enemy, cockiness in his gait. He gazed down at Panga with supreme conceit—the feline warrior returning his stare with hatred as she hissed.

"I like to use that little toy on some of my more troublesome opponents, the ones I actually need to bring in alive," he explained "Unfortunately for you, that is not the case here."

Gmork lifted the shock maul high over his head, the falling rain sizzling on the power field surrounding the heavy head. Panga closed her eyes as she awaited her fate, whispering words in praise of the Great Chailendra Tree.

"Oh, excuuuuuse meeeee," a voice rang out. The salutation elicited a growl from Gmork—he turned to identify the person who dared interrupt his kill.

Opening her eyes, Panga was shocked to recognize none other than Double Trouble standing behind Gmork, waving a slender arm to get the thug's attention.

“WHAT!?” The bounty hunter screamed as Panga attempted to wave them away; she did not want the Imp to get hurt, especially on her behalf.

Double Trouble put their finger to their lips, looking innocent. “I was wondering if you know where *Nobody’s Bizness* is? I’m supposed to meet a friend there and I’m terribly late,” they said sorrowfully.

Turning to stride towards the smaller figure, Gmork growled—full of threat and menace. Panga renewed her struggles against the net, fearful of what a killer like Gmork would do to Double Trouble.

I refuse to let them die for me! Panga thought, using her claws against the net. But it was no use; her old nemesis had paid well for this device and it was strong. She was left to watch helplessly as Double Trouble faced certain death.

As the bounty hunter neared them, Gmork raised his weapon, ready to smite the Imp.

“I think you're going to be late anyway—especially after I turn you into green paste!” He snarled.

Double Trouble gasped mockingly, placing both of their hands over their open mouth.

“Oh no!” They cried. “Big bad wolfy is gonna hit me with his wittle hammer; what shall I do?” They mocked.

Panga winced as Gmork roared, arching the maul down with all his might. But before it hit Double Trouble, an implacable force seized it in midair. With a look of utter disbelief, Gmork beheld a large red pincer clutching the shaft of his weapon—just under the head. Following the large muscular arm attached to the claw, he noted that where once there had been a skinny green lizard, a large woman stood now before him.

She was white-haired and grinning; red armored chitin covered her shoulders as a long armored stinger-tipped tail swayed menacingly behind her.

“Its not nice to hit strangers,” the white-haired woman scolded. “I’m just going to have to take your toy away.”

The claw closed tighter around the shock maul handle with a sharp *click*—the diamond-hard pincers cutting the metal material cleanly. Immediately, the weapon’s power field deactivated with a muffled buzzing sound as the heavy head fell to the ground. Gmork looked at the headless shaft of his shock maul incredulously.

“That was a pure star-forged Galvorn, woman!” He yelled piteously.

The large white-haired woman grinned, opening and closing her claws.

“*Snip snip, darling!”* She sang, whipping her tail around to impale Gmork’s stomach with the stinger. With a loud exhalation of air, Gmork doubled over, clutching the appendage which stabbed him.

“You just go to sleep now!” The large woman said hopefully.

Gmork looked down, snatching at the stinger his bionic hand and tossing it away scornfully. Chuckling to himself, the bounty hunter shook his head, indicating his body from the chin down with his metallic hand.

“Everything from the neck down is custom made and very expensive. If that was a toxin you injected me with, it wouldn't work; there is nothing down there to poison.” He said.

The large woman suddenly became all black with dancing jade lights—the outline shrinking. When the transition was complete, Double Trouble stood before them again, finger to their lips, expression thoughtful.

“That’s excellent information to have, honey.” The Imp said before holding their finger up in exclamation. “Oh! I have just the thing for you!”

Double Trouble reached into their velvety black jacket, extracting a metallic cylinder from within its folds. With a flick of their thumb, a black beam sprung forth, forming a long blade with a sharp tip. It hummed with power as a white energy haze surrounded the dark energy.

Panga recognized the sword immediately, gaping open-mouthed at its sudden appearance.

A Night Sabre! Where in the name of Elysia did Double Trouble get that? Panga thought in wonder.

Gmork looked at the weapon in Double Trouble’s hand hungrily; he recognized it too.

“I’m impressed, but somehow I doubt a shrimp like you defeated a Kalevalian Basilisk Rider.” He said dubiously. “I will enjoy taking that toy from you and adding it to my collection.

“Come get me, ugly!” Double Trouble taunted, waving the Night Sabre at Gmork.

He lunged at them, heaving his huge metallic fist at Double Trouble’s mocking face. They deftly dodged the clumsy strike, swinging the laser sword upwards through his bicep, completely severing the arm. Gmork screamed in fury, spinning around with his other arm to slam his elbow into his foe—but the Imp spun away in a pirouette—delivering an almost lazy chop through the shoulder of Gmork’s other arm. The bounty hunter stood before Double Trouble, peering down at two sparking sockets where his arms used to be.

“*Surrender!*” Double Trouble said dramatically, pointing the Night Sabre’s tip at Gmork. “*You’ve been disarmed!*”

The Imp suddenly broke character and grinned sheepishly. “Oh, darling, that was a real stinker of a joke!” they said with a chuckle.

Despite the pain she was in, Panga found herself smiling at Double Trouble’s antics.

They really are amazing, she thought. *I guess I’m not surprised they pulled a Night Sabre out of nowhere; they seem to be capable of anything!*

Gmork stared at Double Trouble as if they had lost their mind—then suddenly—he spun and started to run away.

“Oh no, you don’t!” Double Trouble yelled, throwing the sabre at the fleeing Gmork.

Like a humming black disc, it spun through the air and through the bounty hunter’s pumping legs with a flash of sparks. The limbless torso of Gmork fell to the ground with a metallic clank, the head howling in fury as it faced the ground. The Imp walked calmly over to their fallen enemy, flipping the torso over casually. Gmork lashed out, snapping and biting at their feet—but missed.

“Bad dog,” Double Trouble scolded before quickly striding over to where Panga lay.

“Oh, honey, you’re a mess,” they said, not unkindly, helping the Star Hunter out of the net.

Double Trouble stopped Panga’s attempt to stand with a gentle hand, and she flopped back down on her rump with a hiss.

“Just let me up. I can walk,” she protested.

Double Trouble leaned down, scooping the feline warrior up in their arms. Expecting pain, Panga was surprised at how infinitely tender they were with her, not even remotely jostling her injuries. She was amazed by how strong yet gentle they were—and more importantly—how secure it felt to be held by them.

“Nonsense, you silly thing,” Double Trouble scolded, cradling her against them.

The Imp gave the feline warrior a roguish grin, exposing rows of dangerous serrated teeth. But behind the smile, Panga discerned great kindness and empathy—hidden behind a façade of indifference. Before she knew it, the feeling of warmness was spreading through her core one more. Also—and even more startling—Panga realized she was blushing again.


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“Just relax, Kitten,” they cooed, beginning to carry Panga toward the candy shop and eliciting a growl from her.

“Don’t call me Kitt—” she started to say but stopped herself, a thoughtful expression blossoming on her orange face.

“You know, I will allow you to call me Kitten, only if I can do something in return,”

“Oh?” Double Trouble prompted with raised eyebrows. “You’re not really in the position to make demands, darling.”

Panga ignored this jibe and continued. “I will let you call me Kitten if I can call you Atreyen,” she said with raised eyebrows of her own.

Double Trouble abruptly stopped walking to stare at her, their expression strange. Beginning to get uncomfortable with the gaze, Panga was regretting her request when a small smile appeared on their green face.

“Okay,” Double Trouble said softly to her. *“Kitten.”*

* * *

With the children's help, Double Trouble dragged the metallic torso of Gmork into the main workspace behind the shop. The head attached to the torso was not pleased with being handled in this manner and cursed the Imp loudly, causing the little children to gasp and cover their ears. When his profanities would not cease, Double Trouble stuffed a gag in his muzzle and slapped him on the cheek.

Once they had situated the torso in an upright position, Double Trouble and the children surrounded their captive, pondering what to do as Panga sat in a nearby chair. Wrapped in dry towels, the feline woman held a cup of hot cocoa in her hand while staring daggers at the remains of Gmork between sips of the hot drink.

“Hmmm…” Double Trouble thought loudly. “He is kind of a heavy paperweight, so that is out of the question,”

“How about we sit him in the corner and just throw things at him? That would be lots of fun!” The boy, Rory, said hopefully.

“No, I want to use him to play dress-up,” Cora said with a pout. “Put pretty makeup on his face. He could be my dolly!”

“Ewww, Cora, I can get you a nicer doll than this thing, my sweet,” Double Trouble said, upper lip curled.

Gmork glared back at his captors with murderous intent, all the while growling through the gag.

Panga laughed despite herself. “Can we just stop this nonsense and get to asking him questions?” She asked, putting her cup down and standing up stiffly.

Double Trouble went to keep her from rising but stopped when Panga bared her fangs at them.

“I’m fine,” she said, waving the Imp away and limping over to Gmork. Panga held her hand before the bounty hunter’s face and flexed her fingers; five sharp white claws extended meaningfully.

“If I take that gag out, do you promise to be good?” The Star Hunter asked, not bothering with the ‘or else.’

Gmork glared at Panga but nodded, and she roughly yanked the rag stuffed in his mouth. He ran his tongue around his dry mouth, glaring at his captor.

“I will be good, but I’m not telling you a thing—*White Claw*,” he said sullenly.

“I know you won’t,” Panga nodded, reaching up the shoulder of her Jaadoo-suit and pinching off a green section of it. “That’s why I’m going to use this,”

Instead of balling up the cantrip, she licked one side and slapped it on Gmork's forehead. The bounty hunter winced, peering cross-eyed up at the material stuck above his brow with a disgusted grimace. Placing the tip of one clawed finger against the strip on the bounty hunter's forehead, Panga closed her eyes.

"You will tell me everything I ask and speak no untruths," the feline warrior said calmly.

The strip flashed a bright green before it began sinking into Gmork's forehead, disappearing completely. The bounty hunter's mouth opened wide as his tongue lolled, the one remaining eye becoming cloudy and distant. Grinning, Panga opened her eyes and nodded to herself.

"Now, I only have one question: Who sent you?" She asked the pacified Gmork. Double Trouble walked over to stand next to Panga, wrapping their arms around themselves—it was almost as if they were anxious.

The bounty hunter smacked his lips absentmindedly. "Someone named Carmen sent for me—said I had to kill White Claw."

"No," Double Trouble whispered, backing away.

Panga turned and looked at them in concern. "Who is Carmen?"

Double Trouble shook their head fiercely. "He is lying, Panga. Whatever you did is not working," they said angrily.

Panga reached out and tentatively clasped Double Trouble's hand. "Atre—" She started before thinking better of using their true name in front of the children. "The Truth Speak does not fail. I have used it many times, Double Trouble. Who is this Carmen?"

Double Trouble grimaced before they spoke.

"Someone who works for Janus," they whispered. "Janus sent Gmork to kill you."

* * *

Double Trouble arrived at the Numen via taxi speeder that very same evening. Just as the vehicle had made its landing, the Imp leaped out, hurriedly rushing to the double doors of the building's entrance. For once in their chaotic life, Double Trouble was utterly bent on only one objective and would not stop until they had seen it through to its completion.

The large double doors burst open as Double Trouble rushed in, almost manic now. There to greet them once again was the smiling Carmen—they bounded towards the woman with such intensity that she flinched as the Imp grasped her by the arms.

"Did you send Gmork to kill White Claw?" They snarled. "DID YOU?"

Carmen nodded, and Double Trouble let out a sigh of relief—but then Carmen opened her mouth to speak.

"Janus commanded me to do it," she said, pointing to the ceiling. "You should speak to him,"

Double Trouble was stunned at this pronunciation—it was just as they feared. Releasing their grip on the woman, they made their way to the elevator, numbly walking in to press the button for the uppermost floor. Leaning up against the wood paneling as the doors closed, the Imp closed their eyes.

This has to be a mistake! This has to be a mistake! They thought furiously. *Yikka promised me to my face she wouldn't hurt Panga! She lied to me!*

Before their thoughts could take them any further, they once again sensed the strange insidious feeling as before, wrapping their consciousness in darkness. They felt their mind being pulled away from their train of logic to their father's voice, once again educating them in the ways of the world.

Atreya, you will know the truth, and the truth will set you free.

Double Trouble shook their head. *What was that?* They thought, confused. *That didn't even make sense.*

Atreya, trust in a higher power, not people.

Double Trouble cocked their head.

Atreya, trust in her with all your heart and lean not on your own understanding.

Double Trouble gritted their teeth.

Atreya, in all your ways submit to her, and she will make your paths straight.

Double Trouble shook their head so furiously that their long ears flapped against their head and face.

"Stop!" They shouted. "Stop talking to me, father!"

The elevator door opened with a *ding,* and Double Trouble found themselves at their destination: the Temple.

The spacious interior of the Temple was much the same as when the Imp first came here—black glossy walls. Bright shiny floor. Desk in front of a large rectangular window. And behind the desk, standing and beaming at them, was Yikka.

"Atreyen!" She called joyously, holding her hands out. "I'm so glad you're here! Come to me!"

Double Trouble found their doubt melted away at the sight of her —grinning foolishly—they rushed to join her. She embraced them, wrapping her arms around them lovingly.

"I'm so glad you're here Atreyen," she said. "But I wasn't expecting you. Is something the matter?"

With a start, Double Trouble realized they had completely forgotten why they had come here and gently pulled back from Yikka's embrace.

How did I forget about Yikka hiring someone to kill Panga? What is the matter with me? They thought, confused.

"Yes, Yikka. Someone tried to kill Panga outside my place, someone named Gmork," they said as Yikka cocked her head curiously. "It turns out Gmork was hired by your assistant, Carmen. Did you tell her to do it, Yikka?"

Yikka looked horrified. "No, Atreyen, I didn't hire Gmork to kill Panga!1 I only wanted him to keep an eye on her. I mean, she *did* attack you, didn't she?" Yikka said, placing her hand on the Imps's cheek.

Double Trouble felt relief. "So you didn't lie to me?"

Yikka smiled sweetly. "Never love. I will always tell you the truth," she said, gazing deeply into their eyes. Her large green and yellow eyes were like two deep pools—in them, Double Trouble could perceive dancing red lights, beckoning the Imp to join them.

Feeling dizzy as the dark haze returned, the Imp placed a hand on their forehead—trying hard to find something to focus on—their eyes seized upon an object on Yikka's desk. The long pole they had noticed when they first came here—mounted horizontally on a stand.

"Yikka? What is this… *stick* on your desk. Is it a trophy?" Double Trouble asked before finally realizing where they had seen it before.

Yikka walked over to the desk and snatched the mounted pole up in her hand, spinning it deftly around before slamming one end down on the marble floor. She stood before the Imp, holding the pole upright like a staff, much like Double Trouble had witnessed someone else do.

“Not really a trophy, Atreyen, more like a piece of memorabilia,” Yikka said, appraising the staff. “You see, it used to hold the Orb of Entropy, here at the end.” She said, pointing to the top of the staff.

Double Trouble’s head spun at this revelation. “What?! But that is Janus’ staff! What are you doing with it, Yikka?!”

She laughed brightly at this question. “Why, they gave it to me, of course, silly!” Yikka said, shaking her head at Double Trouble as if that was the most obvious answer. “I am the bearer of the Orb of Entropy!”

Double Trouble forced themselves to focus, the fog in their mind intensifying.

“Where… where is it?” They asked, having a hard time getting the words out.

Yikka smiled kindly to them, lightly tapping the center of her chest with both hands.

“In me, Atreyen. The Orb of Entropy and I are one, as you and I soon will be,” she said, the vision of pure benevolence.

“Whaaaa…” The Imp started to say before Yikka placed a finger on their lips, stifling their words.

“Shhhhh…” she said kindly. “Enough questions, my love.”

Yikka held her other hand up as it transformed, taking on the corrupted transitional appearance. Double Trouble was instantly transfixed; the swirling red lights in all that infinite darkness beckoned to them. The Imp took her hand in theirs, allowing the power of entropy to flow through their fingers—they gasped as the pleasure came quicker this time, and much, much more intense.

So overwhelmed by the sensual feelings Double Trouble swooned, beginning to fall backward in a feint. But a hand gently slid

around to their back, guiding them to spin around—Double Trouble felt Yikka's arms wrap around their midsection as she pressed her body into their back. Yikka held Double Trouble against her, still clutching their hand in hers, green and red fireflies dancing together in the night of their union. Her face nuzzled in the crook of their neck as she whispered to them.

"Yessss… Atreyen, can you feel my love for you?" She said, her breath tickling their ears.

WRAP YOUR ARMS AROUND ME

The sensation was so intense that the Imp could not speak, only nodding in agreement. Double Trouble could feel her love. It was real, and they could feel themselves slipping into it.

"Hmmm… Yes…" Yikka beckoned. "Now focus on that feeling—of my love—**and submit to it,**" Yikka said as her entire front became her transitional form—a galaxy of infinite darkness, red lights, like demon eyes, dancing within.

Double Trouble nodded slowly, and except for the dancing green lights of their entropic magic, the Imp's entire back matched Yikka's front, and the two outlines merged.

Double Trouble felt themselves truly sink into Yikka and her into them—but not all the way. It was incredible. It was more than incredible; it felt like being slowly lowered into a pool composed purely of erotic climax, and Double Trouble gave themselves fully to it.

As their eyelids started to droop, Double Trouble witnessed an amazing sight outside the large window. In the distance was a rare occurrence—the clouds had lifted just enough for the sun to blaze through as it dipped behind the horizon. It was beautiful, and the contrast between the dark clouds above and the grim city below made it appear as if they were looking up from the bottom of a long tunnel. A long tunnel that they were slowly sinking into, away from the light.

The sun then set, and Double Trouble faded away—into darkness.

Chapter End Notes

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Chapter Summary

> After their visit with Yikka, Panga finds Double Trouble completely changed. Where once the Imp had been the model of perception, they were now oblivious to all reason.
>
> Concerned by her friend's behavior, Panga decides to get her own answers from Yikka.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It was in the midst of the morning surge as Panga walked up the wet stairs out of the train tube and onto the rainy streets— Thenlorians bustling around the feline warrior, pushing and jostling to get to their workplaces.

Panga hated using public transportation, having rather used her preferred method of leaping from building to building if not for the fact she had little Flit in tow. Panga wanted to bring the little girl when she visited Double Trouble, hoping that perhaps seeing the little girl could cheer them up.

The revelation that Yikka had sent Gmork to kill Panga had rocked Double Trouble— Panga had felt the stress pouring off them, even through their attempts to hide the emotion. The Imp had assured her it was all a mistake, that they just needed to speak to Yikka and to please not rescind the offer to take her to Elysia.

Panga agreed only to placate Double Trouble, for the feline woman did not want to upset them further, feeling that to do so would lead to disaster. Panga was dubious about this Yikka—but would still help despite the fact that the other woman attempted to have her killed. It was the way of the Madgēcot to give aid to those in need.

“Are we almost there, Panga?” Flit whined up at her.

Panga cast her gaze down the street, noticing that Double Trouble's place was not far away. She peered down at Flit, noting that the little girl had drooped over with her arms down, a forced haggard aspect to her face, and laughed at Flit’s dramatics.

“Yes, Flit, we are almost there. Maybe you can have some candy when we get there. Perhaps that will be the solution to your energy issues.” Panga suggested. Flit immediately perked up.

“Candy!” She cried, running down the street as fast as her little legs could take her.

Panga lengthened her stride, keeping pace with the eager child—a good night’s sleep in a Jaadoo-suit had done wonders for her; where once there had been broken ribs, now only bruises remained. There was something also to be said for having Flit snuggled up with her all night, the child’s love seeming to magnify the healing magic of the Jaadoo-suit.

Panga laughed as she caught up with the scampering Flit—leaning down to scoop the child up in her arms. Fully retracting her claws, the feline woman reached down to tickle the little girl’s tender sides—Flit squealed and giggled, trying to push away Panga’s hand.

“I see you suddenly have more energy, little one. All you needed was some motivation,” Panga teased with mock sternness, all the while delivering more tickles.

“Okay, okay!” Flit cried, still laughing. “No more—*Mommy!*”

Panga’s yellow eyes instantly widened as her long cream-colored ears lowered—it had been a long time since someone had called her that. The mixture of sadness and joy it elicited was bittersweet, making her throat tighten at the emotion’s sudden arrival.

Panga stopped tickling Flit, gaping at the little girl incredulously as the little girl stared back with wide eyes of her own—but then a tiny smile appeared on her lips.

“Is it okay if I call you that?” Flit asked apprehensively.

Her gaze now blurry with unshed tears, Panga’s eyes softened as she smiled at Flit.

“Yes, Flit, it's okay,” she whispered, leaning forward to press her nose to Flit’s. It was a tender expression of love, one given from a Madgēcot parent to their child for generations; the feline woman thought she would never express herself this way again. But before emotions could overcome her, Panga lowered the little girl to the ground.

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“Off you go, the candy is waiting,” she said, prompting the youngster with a pat on the behind.

Flit giggled and ran ahead to the candy shop as Panga stood back up, wiping at the moisture fogging her sight.

My child, she thought with wonder. *Just like that.*

Panga hurried to catch up as Flit excitedly burst through the shop's entrance—passing through the front door—the feline woman found no sign of Double Trouble or Flit. She continued through the establishment's back door and into the large work area, finding no one there either.

“Hello?” She called.

Inspecting the large space, Panga was happy to notice that the bunk beds now had little mattresses on them, complete with blankets and pillows. She was also glad to discover that Gmork was gone.

When Panga originally asked Double Trouble what they would do with the violent bounty hunter, they suggested throwing him down the nearest garbage chute. She had initially laughed at the suggestion, but after recognizing the seriousness on their face, made Double Trouble promise to hand him over to the authorities.

The feline woman stifled a growl when she noticed the black bags full of Sable, still sitting on the table in the middle of the space.

Well, at least it's here and not being sold, Panga reasoned.

“Hello? Flit? Double Trouble?” She called again, starting to feel uneasy.

“Here we are, darling!” A voice cried.

Panga looked up and smiled, feeling strangely relieved when she saw Double Trouble sauntering down the stairs leading from their apartment, holding Flit in their arms. The little girl seemed so

happy to be reunited with the Imp, her arms wrapped around their neck.

“It's so wonderful that the two of you came to see me!” Double Trouble exclaimed happily as they put Flit back down on the ground. “My darling, darling Flit! I missed you, honey!” They smiled, clutching their hands together next to their face.

“Me too!” Flit exclaimed as she beamed up at them.

Panga grinned at Double Trouble. “My, you're in a good mood today,”

“Oh yes, darling! The most wonderful mood!” They said, beginning to glide about the room, their poise and movements that of a ballroom dancer; one hand was positioned as if on an imaginary shoulder, the other holding an imaginary hand as they dipped and twirled their ghost partner.

Panga watched them with a bemused grin on her face, her lips slowly forming a frown of concern as she remembered the day before. She went to Flit, crouching beside the little girl.

“Flit, I need to speak with Double Trouble. Can you go into the front for a bit? Maybe have that candy you wanted so badly?” She said before turning to the Imp. “Is that okay with you?”

Double Trouble waved a hand airily. “Oh, yes, she can have *all* the candy! Sweets for my little sweet!” They exclaimed, still dancing around the room.

Flit gasped with excitement but then spotted Panga’s shaking head.

“Only five candies, Flit,” the feline woman said sternly. “Now off you go.”

The little girl nodded, hurriedly making her way to the candy store. Panga was so distracted with watching Flit that she didn’t

notice Double Trouble coming up behind her, giving a small shriek when they grabbed her.

"Dance with me, Kitten! I'm so *very* happy, and I need someone to dance with!" The Imp declared.

Twirling Panga around, Double Trouble took her hand in theirs, their other on her waist as they gently led her in a waltz. The feline woman gazed curiously at her light orange hand clasped in the other's green one—then tentatively placed her other on her dance partner's slender waist, under their black jacket. Their green skin was smooth and soft against her hand, and Panga felt her face flush at how pleasant it felt.

"Uh, Atreyen, I've never danced this way before. I'm going to be a clumsy partner," she admitted, unsure of herself.

"Nonsense, Kitten," they scolded, using their nickname for her a second time.

It's funny how quickly I got used to being called that, Panga thought ruefully. *And how quickly I call them by their true name.*

Panga allowed herself to be led in Double Trouble's strange dance for a moment, disentangling herself after they led her into a spin.

"Okay, okay," she said with a laugh, holding her hands up. "This is making me dizzy. Can you stop dancing and talk to me for a moment?"

Double Trouble ceased dancing and sighed heavily. "Okaaayyy…" they said dramatically. "Spoilsport. What do you need to speak to me about so badly, honey?"

Panga shook her head, confused. "Uh, how about what happened last night? With Yikka?" She asked, slightly exasperated. "The fact she hired Gmork to kill me?"

Double Trouble nodded as if this hadn't occurred to them. "Oh, yes—*that*. It turns out the whole thing was a big

misunderstanding. She just hired Gmork to keep an eye on you, and the big dummy took it too far," they waved a hand nonchalantly. "Yikka says sorry, by the way."

Panga gaped at this. *Sorry? Sorry for trying to kill me?* She thought but did not say aloud.

"Well, okay then, what about my offer to take her to Elysia? To heal her?" Panga asked.

Double Trouble placed their hand on their chin and squinted. "Oh, yeah. We didn't really get to that. I'm sure everything will be fine, though. Yikka has the Orb of Entropy now. I'm sure she has the power to heal herself." They said dismissively.

"WHAT!?" Panga shouted. "Yikka is a bearer of the Orb of Entropy? How did that happen, and why am I only just hearing about this?"

Double Trouble viewed Panga as if she was a rude guest.

"Yeah, Janus gave it to her. What's the big deal?" They said before appearing thoughtful once again. "Although she did kind of ruin the staff when she removed the Orb and absorbed it into her body,"

Panga felt her head spin and fur crawl at these revelations. The feline woman went to Double Trouble, clasping their hand in hers as she gazed into their eyes meaningfully.

"Atreyen, a bearer of one of the Ultimate Powers does not simply cast away their responsibility. They don't just *give* one of the Magical Staves away as if it were a simple gift... They do so only after their death. Janus is dead, Atreyen. They are dead, and somehow Yikka has their power."

Double Trouble shook their head. "No. No, you're wrong. Yikka wouldn't lie to me. Janus gave it to her." They said, trying to pull their hand out of Panga's grasp—but she held tight.

“Atreyen, you also simply don’t separate the magical font from its staff. It can only be done with great and terrible magic. Evil magic.”

Double Trouble looked distressed as they kept trying to pull out of Panga’s grasp.

“It's not true!” They shrieked. “You’re lying to me!”

Panga hissed in anger, feeling her fury rise at their obtuseness. “How can you be so *blind*, Atreyen? What is *wrong* with you?” She said, baring her fangs at them.

When Panga noticed Double Trouble scrutinizing something past her, she released them instantly. Turning her head, the feline woman caught sight of her tail sweeping in long arcs, now twice its normal size.

Evil! But it can’t be Atreyen. I know them to be good, she thought, confused. Then it came to her. *Corruption. They have a magical taint on them.*

As she studied Double Trouble’s confused face, it suddenly became clear to her.

They are somehow enchanted. No wonder they are acting so strange.

Double Trouble's countenance became stern then. “I don’t like how you are behaving, *Panga*. I think it's time you left, dear,” they said, sticking their nose in the air almost comically. “I think I need a day or two to forgive you.”

Panga held her hands out in placation, backing away from Double Trouble.

“Okay, Atreyen. I am sorry, I will be leaving now.”

Double Trouble nodded to her dismissively, and Panga whirled, striding towards the exit. Before she passed through the door, the

feline warrior stopped to regard them, noticing that the Imp had resumed their strange dance.

“I promise I am going to help you, Atreyen,” she whispered. “I swear it by the Great Chailendra Tree.”

Panga turned, crossing the door’s threshold and into the shop, spotting a chocolate-covered Flit behind the glass counter eating huge gobs of fudge. The little girl grinned sheepishly at Panga.

“Sorry, guess I got a little carried away,” she said apologetically.

Panga smiled, motioning the little girl to approach as she kneeled. Placing her hands on Flit’s shoulders, Panga gazed into her child’s eyes.

“Flit, this is really important. I need you to be able to get back home by yourself. Can you do that?” She asked.

Flit cocked her head, now confused. “We are leaving Double Trouble so soon? Shouldn’t I at least say goodbye?” She said, downcast.

Panga shook her head. “No, little one. Double Trouble is… sick. They are very sick, and I need to go somewhere to find out how to make them well.”

“Okay,” Flit said in a small voice. “Will it be dangerous? When will you be home?”

“No, little one, it is not dangerous,” Panga replied, running the tips of her white claws through Flit's hair and forcing a smile on her face. “I will be home tonight, I promise. Now off you go!”

Flit beamed back at her, bright as a sunrise. “Okay, mommy!” She said before exiting the shop.

Panga watched her leave, the smile on her face slowly fading—turning into a grimace. She had lied to Flit when she said it wouldn’t be dangerous. Panga knew exactly where she had to go

—the huge and ancient Ecclesiastical Monolith—or Numen—as she had heard Double Trouble call it. The place the Death Binders had turned into their base of operations when they had held Thenlor in their evil grasp.

Panga recalled that the Death Binders were in the process of building some form of a monstrous temple at the crown of the holy building before they departed, never to return. She had no clue as to what its purpose was but was sure it would be the place to find the source of the corruption.

The place to find Yikka.

* * *

Nighttime had fallen as Panga piloted the stolen speeder above the city, high in the glowing clouds, lit by the lights below. The feline warrior did not like resorting to thievery, having 'borrowed' the speeder from an unwitting Thenlorian who had the misfortune of parking it near Double Trouble's establishment—but what were material possessions when someone's life was in danger?

Besides, taking a taxi speeder straight to the Numen's entrance would defeat the point of being secretive, and scaling the immense building would leave the feline warrior drained and unfit to face any threats she may find within.

Arriving above her destination, Panga parked the speeder; it sat humming on its antigravity suspensors as the feline warrior prepared herself. Opening the side door, Panga peered down through the falling rain at the massive building below her. Unlike the smaller structures around it, the Numen did not have any exterior lighting, and nothing shone through its broad windows. The effect of this gloom made the Numen appear as if it were a dark and grim giant standing on light, trampling it.

That's poetic, Panga, she thought, turning her body towards the open door, her feet dangling over nothingness. *You are about to*

jump out of this speeder and try and land on that giant. How about you be positive?

With a flick of her ears, Panga pushed herself off the seat and into the air, immediately directing her face downwards. With arms pressed to her sides and legs together, the feline warrior became a speeding missile with a tail—closing her eyes—Panga whispering a mantra under her breath. When she re-opened them, Panga spread her arms and legs out wide—black and green material, the same as her Jaadoo-suit, appeared between her legs and under her arms, attaching to her sides. The summoned wings immediately caught the wind with a snapping crack, slowing the feline warrior's downward trajectory and allowing her to descend in a glide. Panga was able to steer herself by positioning her arms and legs at the correct angles, directing her flight towards the landing pad, the only discernible entrance near the apex of the Numen.

Just before hitting the platform, Panga performed a gentle upward swoop, landing lightly on her feet. Closing her eyes, Panga whispered a negating mantra, retracting and reabsorbing the material that allowed flight back into her Jaadoo-suit. Taking a deep breath, the feline warrior steeled herself and began walking towards the entrance.

Inspecting the large double doors, Panga momentarily pondered the method to gain entry before reaching for her lower back, selecting the material best suited to this purpose. After pinching it off and giving the cantrip a good lick, the feline warrior slapped it to the seam where the doors met in the middle.

Panga then arched her back, rubbing her clawed hands down the sides of her body as she whispered the mantra of concealment. Starting from the tips of her toe claws and running up her legs, Panga began to disappear, vanishing from sight completely as her hands and head shimmered and faded from sight. Now completely invisible, the feline warrior reached over the material she had placed on the door, pressing a finger against it.

“Open,” she whispered softly.

With a low whine, the doors opened slowly, sweeping out and away from each other, giving Panga a view of the Numen's’ interior. Just like it was outside, the inside of the building was pitch black, utterly devoid of light.

Well, it's a good thing Madgēcots can see in the dark, Panga thought as she crept in on tiptoes.

Straining her sensitive ears, the feline warrior listened for any sign of life—but perceived nothing. The faint music that Double Trouble had previously heard was absent—only quiet stillness met the Numen’s new visitor. The silence of the tomb.

Panga then tried sniffing, sampling the air for any information that could help her. She caught a whiff of an essence that made her wrinkle her orange nose; it was not the pleasant woody and floral scent Double Trouble experienced upon their visits to the Numen. It smelled of stale things, of damp dirt and rot. It smelled like an old grave.

Panga explored up and down the vast, dark corridors on velvet feet, searching for an avenue upwards. The feline warrior sought stairs, ladder, or a vent shaft—but so far—all she could discover was an elevator. Every once in a while, she would stop and strain her ears and nose—but continued to find no sign of life.

When I was fighting the Death Binders, I never made it into this building, she thought as she inspected a random seam with her claws. *But this place lives up to its reputation. It's creepy.*

Giving up on finding another way up, Panga decided to use the elevator, tentatively pressing the button to call it. After what seemed like forever waiting in the dark, the double doors of the elevator opened with a loud *ding*. Panga flinched as the sound echoed up and down the cavernous halls.

The ride up to the temple was long and tedious, but Panga was thankful to have the background noise of the ascending elevator.

At least now she did not have to listen to the numb hush—but she could have sworn she heard a female voice whispering from down below, back in the halls. Whispering her name.

Get a grip Star Hunter, she thought as she gritted her teeth. *It was your imagination. If someone was really saying your name, your ears would have picked it up clearly.*

As the elevator came to a sudden halt, the doors opened with another cheerful ding, making Panga jump. Still invisible and creeping on tiptoes, she made her way into the spacious temple, towards the desk at the other end.

PLAY WITH FIRE

Reflecting back down from the clouds above, the city lights shone through the large rectangular window, creating a long shaft of light through the center of the chamber. Panga made an attempt to avoid this illuminated section, creeping at the edges and staying in the dark. Even though the feline warrior was concealed by magic, she felt unpleasantly exposed in the Yikka's uppermost chamber. She ended up having to suppress her discomfort, entering the light in order to reach the desk.

Deciding to investigate the mounted staff first, Panga lifted it from its stand with the tips of her finger claws, peering closely at it.

I've never seen one of the Staves of Power. No Madgēcot has in a thousand years, she thought to herself, inspecting the ends. *I have no idea if this is one of them.*

Placing the staff carefully back in its stand, Panga continued around to the back of the desk, opening various drawers to poke inside. Finding most empty, she was about to give up the search when she discovered a cylindrical metallic tube inside one of the larger drawers. Picking it up, Panga tentatively sniffed it—smelling nothing.

Noticing one of the ends was a cap, she removed it, upending the tube over her hand. A curled parchment slid out; it was old and

worn, aged with time, and Panga unrolled it carefully. Her yellow eyes scanned the page, following occult diagrams illustrating a ritual written in scarlet ink. Words accompanied the drawings, and even though the language was old and archaic, Panga was still able to read it.

With the fur on her shoulders slowly standing on end, Panga discerned that what she was reading was a rite, describing incantations most vile and whose purpose was to create only evil. Panga's long ears drooped as a name was repeated over and over throughout the spells—one she immediately recognized.

"Zzar," she whispered out loud. "The fallen one."

"Find something interesting?" A sonorous female voice said behind her.

Shrieking in alarm, Panga dropped the parchment before spinning around. She couched behind the desk, scanning the other side of the room for the speaker—there in the darkness, just beyond the reach of the light, Panga spotted two glowing red eyes. As they moved slowly into the light, a beautiful woman was revealed.

She was garbed in a skintight black bodysuit, the neckline dropping into a 'V' to expose a portion of her midriff. With skin as green as Double Trouble's, the woman smiled the same dangerous sharp-toothed smile as them as she sauntered towards Panga's hiding place. Long pointed ears poked out between strands of flowing red hair—and behind her—a thick green tail swayed languidly. As the strange woman got closer, Panga noted her eyes were no longer glowing red, having now reverted to the same green and yellow as Double Trouble's—the pupils a black vertical slit.

Stopping not far away from her desk, the woman crossed her arms, her long tail curling up into a spiral behind her.

"I can see you through that invisibility spell, *Madgēcot."* She said with a laugh in her voice. "Although not as well as I would like.

Why don’t you just drop it so I can get a good look at you?”

Panga stood and whispered, revoking her invisibility cloak. Now fully exposed, the feline warrior walked around the desk to stand before the woman.

“You must be Yikka,” she said evenly—receiving an even broader smile in reply. Panga noticed that unlike Double Trouble’s dangerous smile—which had their appealing face to surround it—Yikka’s face seemed even more dangerous than her smile.

Yikka placed a finger to her lips and cocked her hips. “My, you are a lovely one, aren’t you?” She cooed. “I usually don’t do fur, but that patch around your one eye is adorable! And that striped tail! Is it always that bushy?”

Panga reached behind to clasp her tail, running a hand to the tip and smoothing down the agitated fur.

“No, it's not. It just gets that way when in the presence of evil.” The feline warrior said in a low voice.

Yikka gave an exasperated sigh, much like Double Trouble would do.

“Oh pleeeeeese! Stop with that evil nonsense. You sound like those crusty old priests Atreyen and I had to deal with!” She said before her eyes focused on something. Following Yikka’s gaze, Panga spotted the empty tube and parchment on the ground. Yikka’s whole demeanor seemed to change as a small frown appeared on her green lips.

“There is a saying on the planet I came from,” Yikka began. “It has something to do with curiosity and a cat.”

Panga nodded at this. “Yes, I’ve heard that stupid saying. Are you going to kill me, then? You’ve already tried to have Gmork do it.” She asked, her body tensing.

With sadness and regret, Yikka shook her head.

“I don’t really want to, but I can’t have you running to Atreyen and confusing them with silly tales of evil.” She said holding her hand upwards, fingers together.

As Yikka spread the fingers apart, a black orb formed in her palm, red motes dancing within its midnight form. The summoned ball abruptly burst into corrupted red flames as Yikka’s outward appearance shifted from alluring—to horrifying.

Yikka’s eyes blazed like two rubies in their sockets—the intensity of which illuminated her head from within, the fell light revealing her skull in a ghastly leer. The fear that had been slowly gathering in Panga’s stomach formed into a solid lump of terror as she tensed for the oncoming assault.


HENARTORINOS'23

In a blur, Yikka hurled the cupped flames—the projectile zipped past Panga as she leaped away, hitting the desk—it exploded in a shower of splinters, sending the mounted staff spinning and clattering at the other end of the room. Landing, Panga rolled away from a follow-up attack, ending in a crouch as the flaming missile obliterated a section of the floor. Reaching down, the feline warrior pinched off a section of her Jaadoo suit—the part that was a Chakra Block cantrip—balling it up in her hand.

Panga immediately flung it at Yikka—it exploded into rainbow sparks, raining down on her foe. Closing her eyes, Yikka stood rigid as the magic-severing energy touched her, absorbing into her body. But when Panga's enemy opened her eyes, they still burned with demonic light.

"That was the same nasty little trick you used on Atreyen, wasn't it?" Yikka smiled at Panga, menace in her voice now. "And you say *I'm* evil."

Panga shook her head forcefully. "I didn't know that it would do that to them, and I am beside myself with sorrow that it did," Panga said, pain in her voice. "No matter what, I would never do that to them again."

Yikka suddenly cocked her head as the red fire in her eyes died, revealing her yellow and green ones—immediately, her whole outward appearance reverted back to that of a beautiful woman. Yikka studied Panga intently.

"I believe you," she whispered. "You really care for Atreyen, don't you?"

Panga nodded. "That is why I am here, to free them from whatever dark magic spell you put them under."

Yikka nodded. "I think I will just catch you then. Atreyen would like it if I didn't kill you," she said in a reasonable voice.

Panga hissed and crouched again. “I would like to see you try!” She snarled, tail whipping back and forth in agitation.

Yikka favored Panga with a grin as she motioned about her body, long green fingers forming complex patterns in the air. Panga began to feel a strange hazy sensation settle upon her mind—one she quickly recognized.

She is cursing me! Panga thought, reaching down to her leg to yank off the material she needed. Balling it up, the feline warrior jammed it into her mouth, chewing on it furiously before swallowing it.

The anti-hex cantrip worked; some of the effects of the curse receded, partially lifting the cloud from Panga’s mind. Yikka’s ceased her incantation and placed her hands on her hips, gazing at Panga with amusement mixed with exasperation.

“You know, Panga, if you keep pulling off your outfit like that, soon you’ll have nothing to wear!” Yikka grinned mischievously. “As much as I would like to see that, I think I just need to end this game now.”

Yikka’s eyes blazed into Panga, making the feline warrior feel as if being inspected—just as she did with Double Trouble. Panga rubbed at her shoulders as the fur there began to stand on end, deciding that perhaps now would be a good time to get away.

Suddenly the impression ceased, and Yikka transitioned into a black night of dancing red fireflies; Panga knew she was about to shape-shift. Yikka’s outline became slightly smaller, her tail thinner. When her form solidified again, Panga felt her heart begin to race as she took in Yikka’s new aspect—all thoughts of escaping vanishing from her mind.

A female Madgēcot stood before her—all black fur, black hair, and claws—and Panga instantly recognized her. Wearing only a loincloth, the female Madgēcot smiled, her emerald green eyes sparkling in the exact same way that made Panga’s heart swell in

the past. She looked just as she did on the night of their bonding in front of the Great Chailendra Tree.

“Maira?” Panga breathed out in a whisper.

Maira nodded. “It's me, Panga. I missed you so much!” She said with the same lyrical accent as Panga, holding her arms out for an embrace.

Panga stared at her ex-mate, shaking her head in confusion as some of the haze started to creep back in. The feline warrior sniffed at the air, searching for the familiar scent of her old lover—but not finding it. Panga only discerned the scent that seemed to permeate the place she was in—the smell of death.

“No,” Panga said, shaking her head. “Maira left me. You’re not her. You're not going to trick me, Yikka!”

The Maira imposter put her hands down and nodded. Once again, she became the transitional form, shrinking even smaller than before as she solidified into a new shape. When the transformation was complete, Panga fell to her knees as tears poured from her eyes. She knew this form as well.

It was a Madgēcot child—a little girl—wearing a cloth shift with animal patterns printed on its material. It was with a mother’s instinct that Panga recognized the little girl’s cream-furred body—little brown stripes on thin arms and legs. Her ears and hair were black, slitted eyes green—like her mother’s. The tufts behind her long ears were cream— just like her other mother’s.

“Chhaya!” Panga cried, the tears now falling freely from her eyes.

There was pure sorrow in the little girl's eyes as she began to walk toward Panga, hands held out in need.

“Where were you, mommy?” She asked in a child’s voice.

Panga gaped back, abject horror and sadness warring within her heart as she fought against the creeping fog spreading throughout

her mind. It distorted the feline warrior's perceptions, fooling her into disbelieving her senses and the logic of reality. With a soul-wrenching sob, Panga's will crumbled as she succumbed to Yikka's sorcery.

"I'm so sorry, little one. Mommy is so sorry," she cried, hugging herself. Panga was still on her knees, rocking back and forth as the little girl stepped towards her, holding out a small hand as if to seek a mother's comfort.

"Where were you, mommy?" Chhaya continued to ask. "Where were you when I died?"

"NOOOOO!!!!" Panga shrieked, holding her head between two clawed hands as she fell forward, then onto her side. Panga attempted to roll up into a ball, much as she did when she was a child herself—when the world was too much for her little mind.

Panga looked back up just in time to make out Chhaya standing over her, pity and remorse in her child's eyes.

"Sorry, Panga, this was the only way," Chhaya said, reaching for her face. "Time for you to have peace."

The feline warrior gasped as a small hand touched her cheek—seeing only darkness, Panga knew no more.

Chapter End Notes

Illustration of Panga and Flit by Miledibuja on Tumblr, Instagram, and Twitter.

Illustration of demonic Yikka by Henar, a.k.a., ilikeyoucatradora on Tumblr and Instagram.

Coming to Terms With Themself...

Chapter Summary

As a great and terrible storm takes hold of the planet, Flit awakens to find Panga missing.

Fearing her adoptive mother to be in danger, Flit turns to the person most likely to help her.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Torrents of rain fell upon Thenlor in endless sheets, saturating a metropolis originally built to withstand participation beyond its limits; drains and culverts were overwhelmed as massive flooding broke out amongst the avenues and streets, the water forming into rivers that cascaded down into the lower quadrants like waterfalls. On top of this, lightning streaked across the sky in a continuous chain of searing arcs, creating havoc with electronics and causing whole city sections to go without power. Fear of these searing blasts had forced the majority of the speeder traffic to fly at lower elevations or else be vaporized by a random discharge.

Having suddenly manifested during the day's first light, the ferociousness of this storm was freakish and unforeseen. It was almost as if it had been summoned by some foul magic—called forth to herald a great cataclysmic awakening the likes of which this planet had never seen before.

Flit had awoken to the tempestuous morning to discover that her adoptive mother was nowhere to be found. Panga had promised the little girl to be home by last evening, causing Flit to suspect something had happened to her. After a moment of high anxiety, the little girl forced herself to keep calm, seeking the only person she knew might help her.

“Double Trouble!” Flit called, opening the door to their candy shop.

Hearing no response, she proceeded into the backroom, noting the bunk beds full of sleeping children. Flit approached one of the beds, shaking its occupant awake.

“Wh—what? Flit?” A bleary-eyed Cora asked. “What are you doing here?”

“Where is Double Trouble?” Flit demanded.

Cora simply pointed up to the apartment at the top of the stairs before flopping back down to sleep.

Scurrying up the stairs and into the apartment, Flit spotted Double Trouble supine on their luxurious bed. With hands held up, the Imp waved them in the air, tracing patterns known only to themselves. Flit climbed up on the bed—when her friend made no response to her presence, she glared down at them incredulously. Getting annoyed at their apparent obliviousness, Flit kicked Double Trouble in the side—they immediately shrieked.

“Ow! You nasty little child!” The Imp yelled, confusion on their face. “What did you do that for, Flit?”

The little girl raised her arms and waved them dramatically.

“Panga is missing, Double Trouble! I need your help to find her! She could be in danger!” She cried, fear plain in her voice.

Double Trouble blew through their lips, making a rude noise.

“Whatever. I’m mad at her for being so nasty to me yesterday. You’re probably overreacting, Flit. Why don’t you just be quiet and go eat candy, huh?” They said, dismissing her with a hand gesture.

Flit was furious now. Walking straight up to their face and raising a small hand, she smacked the Imp right in the lips. Double

Trouble gasped, falling back away from their assailant to hold their wounded mouth, staring at Flit with wide eyes.

"Now you listen here, you big green jerk!" Flit said menacingly. "Panga went somewhere because she said *you* were sick. She said she would come home last night, but she didn't. Panga never lies to me, so that means something happened to her—probably something bad. I need your help to find her, and *you owe her*. Do you understand? If you don't get up right now and help me, I swear *I'm gonna bite you!"* Flit screamed, baring her small fangs at Double Trouble.

* * *

Double Trouble's lips still stung as they stared at Flit, their mind in a state of complete confusion.

"Did you just hit me, Flit?" The Imp asked incredulously. They felt so strange—as if they had just awoken from a long dark sleep, only discerning their surroundings through dreams up until now.

Flit gaped at them open-mouthed. "Are you serious?" She asked, raising her hand threateningly. "Do you want another one? What is wrong with you!?"

Double Trouble rubbed at their head. "I don't know, Flit, daring, just please don't hit me again!" They said, holding up their hands to ward her off. "Just tell me what is going on, Little Mouse!"

Flit continued to stare at Double Trouble in disbelief but lowered her raised hand. "Didn't you hear what I said?" She asked. Double Trouble indicated that they hadn't.

"Panga is missing. She went somewhere yesterday after visiting you. She said you were sick and wanted to find a way to help you. Panga promised me to be back before night. But she never came home!" Flit cried as anger disappeared from her voice, replaced by fear.

The little girl started to cry, and Double Trouble pushed away their confusion, reaching for the small child to pull them into an embrace.

"There there, honey. We will figure this out." They said, patting Flit on the back. "Where did Panga say she was going?"

Flit sniffled and wiped at her eyes, looking up at them. "I don't know, and she didn't say, only that it was to help you."

This made no sense to Double Trouble, but they hid that from Flit with a smile.

"Ah, I see, my darling. That helps me a lot. I think I can take it from here. Why don't you go down with the other children, hmm? While I figure this out?" They said kindly to the little girl.

Flit was uncertain. "You promise you will find her?" She asked.

Double Trouble held up their hand as if taking an oath. "On my life," they said seriously.

Flit beamed at Double Trouble and hugged them. "Okay, I believe you." She said before hopping off the bed and exiting out the door.

The Imp watched her leave, confusion still swirling in their mind.

What is going on with me? They thought, rubbing their temples. *It is like a heavy weight has been on my mind—only just now being lifted.*

The last thing they remembered clearly was going to the Numen—wanting to get answers out of Yikka. Then, nothing. It felt like they had been in a hole or a cage; they had felt trapped.

Trapped like in the dry storage locker back on Etheria.

The Imp attempted to dismiss the memory that seemingly popped into their head. Why had they thought of that?

Because it's part of the whole reason you came to Thenlor.

Double Trouble cocked their head, remembering the horrifying feeling of being trapped and forced to face some hard truths about themselves.

Hidden within a concealing robe, Atreyen waits within the stale-smelling dry storage locker, a sense of weighty expectation making their tail twitch. They are there to make an exchange with someone—their illicit technology for cold, hard currency. But that is not where the excitement stems from.

Atreyen's suppresses the need to giggle as their long ears perk, picking up the sound of someone entering the kitchen. They know it's him, for they can sense it—they had been so very close to him once. So close that Atreyen almost…

He is at the entrance of the dry storage locker and has caught sight of them; Atreyen's skin pickles as they feel his eyes upon them.

"Are you serious?" Shen asks.

Atreyen casts off their concealment in the most ostentatious manner possible, enjoying the role of performer.

"T-da!" They cry before taking a bow. "Thank you, thank you."

Shaking his head as he regards them, Atreyen can't help but notice something terribly different in the handsome human. Shen wants to find humor in their antics, but there is a darkness about his aspect—something is weighing heavily on his mind.

Ugh, it must be that whole thing with Catra—the poor silly boy. He really is in love with my Kitten, *they think, crossing their arms and favoring Shen with a grin****.***

"Is there a reason for the drama? I mean, I know this is you we are talking about, but did you really need the robe?" Shen asks.

Ah! That's a good sign! He wants to banter with me! *They think before saying, "Uh, yes, I'm not exactly welcome in Bright Moon these days. I guess botching up a Royal Vow ceremony is quite frowned upon. Oh, and Glimmer was absolutely furious when I sent her the bill for it. I don't understand that woman."*

As Shen shakes his head, Atreyen catches the smile he attempts to suppress—they know he is won over, and whatever bad mood Shen had been in has vanished. They always love having that effect on him.

"So, do you have what I need? I've got your payment here," Shen says, holding out a cloth sack that jangles to a familiar tune.

Atreyen has been so caught up in the interplay that they have forgotten the whole reason Shen wanted to meet them—they put on a show of being excited at the prospect of money, wanting to hide the disappointment brimming in their chest.

"Ah perfect, let's see…" they say, counting the coins. "Hmmm…is this it?"

"Come on, don't I get a preferred customer discount?" Shen asks.

Atreyen places a long green finger to their lips, acting as if they are thinking about money—when instead—their mind is drawn to something more physical and direct.

"Okay, fiiine…but you really have some nerve to ask me for a discount when you already owe me, remember? You said you would do anything for me." They say, hoping to change the direction of the situation. The dry storage locker is not the greatest location for what they desire—but—they have done it in less savory locations…

"You're going to have to put it on my tab, Atreyen," Shen says with his typical ineffectual shrug. "Let's see the goods."

Once again, Atreyen hides their disappointment as a niggling concern starts to creep around the corners of their brain. They

move to the side, allowing Shen to see the knapsack containing the illegal technology they had acquired for him.

Atreyen has gone well out of their way to get this device, having to haggle tirelessly with a black-market dealer in the starport near the old Fright Zone. Atreyen paid this unscrupulous and rather very shrewd merchant twice the amount they demanded from Shen, forcing themselves to admit that having the handsome human reach out had awakened a need to reconnect. This exchange is only an opportunity for Atreyen to make up for their past mistake of pushing Shen away.

Sure, they know the poor boy is in love with Catra—but there is no happy ending down that road. Their Kitten is already in love with her own soul mate—and besides—even if Catra wasn't in love, Shen is not an option for her. Atreyen would use this opportunity to guide Shen away from the 'cliff' that is Catra—and, no matter how long it takes—steer him back to them.

Atreyen will never openly admit this, though—it isn't their style.

"There are instructions on how to use it inside. It's a marvelous device, simple yet effective." Atreyen says as Shen rummages through the knapsack. He removes the instruction pamphlet, briefly flipping through the pages as Atreyen's curiosity gets the best of them.

"So, are you going to keep me guessing? The least you can do is tell me what this is about, mystery man," they ask nonchalantly.

Shen glances back at Atreyen, and they can recognize it in his dark brown eyes—considering the decision to tell them something—something weighing on him heavily. Finally, he accedes.

"Do you know what's going on? How can our enemies send assassins on a whim to attack us?" Shen asks before turning back to the knapsack.

Yes, Atreyen knows all about how the latest bad guy—the Shen'Aan-war—can send magic-enhanced assassins to attack

Shen and his friends on Etheria, all the while hiding in an entirely remote dimension, the Dimension of Night. They are familiar with different dimensions—after all—they are from one separate from the one they currently inhabit.

"Uh-huh. Yeah, I know all the juicy details, especially since this blockade is starting to hurt my business," Atreyen says, pretending to sound annoyed.

Shen nods. "You're in luck, then. I'm going to use this device to access the Crystal Castle and travel to my dimension. I plan on using my Heart Rune to sever the connection and seal off the Place of Night from your Universe. The blockade should lift for you after that, so your business can return to normal." he says, offhandedly.

Atreyen's mind tumbles in an attempt to grasp what Shen has just said. Yes, they can sense its magical potential every time they are near the heart rune Adora has gifted Shen. They also know the story of how Adora and Catra used the original copy to release the magic stored inside Etheria. By the laws of logic, what is used to unlock can also lock, possibly sealing the access to the Dark Dimension. What Shen is talking about doing can work, but there is only one problem, and Atreyen is unable to stop themselves from voicing it.

"Hmm, so you'll be able to return before that connection is severed, right?" they ask, using all their willpower to control the timbre of their voice.

Shen doesn't even hesitate to answer.

"No, Atreyen, I can't come back. That will be it for me since there is no way I'm getting captured again; I will make sure of that. Maybe I'll leave that nice black jacket behind for you? You always liked it."

There is a pounding in Atreyen's ears as something inside them breaks. Just as they realize they are panicking—the anger takes

hold—a feeling they have not felt in a very, very long time. Before they know what they are doing, Atreyen is blocking the exit out of the dry storage locker, preparing themselves for a fight.

Not hearing a response from them, Shen turns—the shock blooming on his face almost makes Atreyen want to weep.

"So, what? You think you're going to tell me you're just going to throw your life away and I'm going to be okay with that?" they ask him, no longer able to mask their emotions.

Shen is now on guard, rising slowly from a crouch to position the knapsack over one shoulder. His brown eyes flick to either side of Atreyen's lithe body, seeking an avenue of escape.

"Atreyen, let me out of here. I have to go," he says firmly to them.

Atreyen shakes their head. "No," they state, just as firmly.

Shen lets out a laugh of exasperation. "So, we're going to just stay here in this food pantry? We've hung out in more exciting places than this, and not nearly as boring," he says with a smile, trying to disarm them.

***Flirting won't work now, honey,** Atreyen thinks as they turn about, considering their options. The answer comes to them suddenly.*

"I'm going to lock you in here—go find Adora or Catra—and tell them everything," they respond.

Before Atreyen realizes how their words can be misconstrued, Shen lunges at them. Quickly pivoting on one heel, Atreyen slaps him down with their thick tail, sending the human careening into the rear of the dry storage locker. Shen slams into a stack of food containers—which tumble down atop his prone form.

Seeing their opportunity, Atreyen turns to flee—only to halt with a yelp as two hands seize their tail. They are yanked back and expertly sent into a spin—through the dizzying spiral of their

trajectory—Atreyen discerns Shen attempting to bolt past them. They reach out with clawed hands to seize the escaping human—but their fingers only find purchase on a chain necklace around his neck.

Shen is momentarily halted as the taught metal links bite into his neck—but as Atreyen's viewpoint revolves in a different direction—they feel him break free, leaving them to crash into the food containers, still holding the necklace.

Atreyen is on their feet in an instant, hissing in rage as they see Shen swing the heavy door to shut them in. Too late, the heavy door slams closed—a slight ***click*** *as the latch slides into place, indicating they are now locked in.*

"SHENNNNN!!!!" Atreyen screams, using all their considerable strength to slam into the door. "WHY ARE YOU DOING THIS! LET ME OUT!"

Their long ears perk as they hear Shen whisper a response, even through the thick door.

"See you next lifetime, Atreyen,"

"NOOOO!!!" They scream, quickly transitioning into a pure entropic state, attempting to slide through the seams around the edges of the door.

But it's no use; the space is too small for them to pass through while maintaining an elasticity suitable for sustaining their life essence. Atreyen can try other forms—but none of them are stronger than what they are naturally capable of. They resume their natural shape and continue their assault on the locked door, hammering away at it with their immense strength.

Why is he doing this? *Atreyen thinks before realizing they are still holding the necklace yanked from Shen's neck. They hold the jewelry up, noticing it is a disc-shaped locket suspended from the silver links. Prying the metallic clam-shell halves open, Atreyen*

discovers a brown tuft ensconced within—holding the fuzz up to a nostril—they sniff, instantly recognizing the smell.

Catra! I knew it! This is all some stupid drama because of Catra—because he could never be with her. What an idiot!

Atreyen bares gritted razor teeth as they hunch over, fists still held against the implacable door as reality hits them.

But he would never even fall for Catra if you were truthful, would he, Atreyen? If you had allowed him to see past your lies to the real you, he would have fallen in love with you—instead of her. And you know you would have fallen for him as well; you were practically there before you kicked him out of your life. Shen would have never been taken with someone so out of his reach.

Atreyen shut their eyes against the pain threatening to brim over the well of their heart—but it is too late—the toll of sorrow has already reached critical mass; it is a landslide now.

Why couldn't you be truthful, Atreyen? Why do you push everyone away with your lies? You thought you were so smart with Catra, throwing all of her dysfunction in her face to turn her from her path. Meanwhile, you are even worse off than her! You're an idiot!

Atreyen sits on the floor, holding their head in their hands as they start to weep. All the while, they remember… Shen explaining the plan to go into the dimension of Night and sever the connection there, thus keeping harm from coming to Etheria. Of how he will be trapped there and will take his own life to keep his father from turning him into a weapon again.

He told Atreyen his plan so nonchalantly—as if he believed that they wouldn't care at all. But that is what ended up hurting the most in the end, for they did care. They cared a lot—but they have no one but themselves to blame for no one seeing it.

Atreyen has weaved such a web of lies and falsehoods as a form of survival—to protect their tender heart from ever becoming damaged again. But their disguise has become a prison—the boundaries of which close in on them and create a sense of intense oppression.

They feel as if they cannot breathe; it is a fervid, all-consuming claustrophobia—which makes no sense—they had been in tighter spaces than this…

Atreyen leaps up to resume their attack on the front door, slamming on it with all their might. They continue this way for minutes—then hours—all the while screaming at the top of their lungs.

"Help! Someone let me out of here!"

Abruptly the door opens, and they fall out and into someone, both of them tumbling onto the floor in a tangle.

It's Catra—and suddenly—they feel hope.

Double Trouble let the memory fade away, not needing to follow that tale to the conclusion. They left Etheria soon after that, thinking they needed to cut the compassion out of themselves, and came to Thenlor. But here they were again, this time with a room full of children in bunk beds and a friend who needed their help.

The Imp chuckled and shook their head.

Atreyen, they thought to themselves. *You have a big tender heart, honey. You need to just accept it.*

I JUST WANT TO BE ME

They forced their mind to their current situation, helping Flit find Panga.

Panga would never abandon the little girl, they reasoned to themselves. *So she must be trapped or held against her will somewhere. Or dead.*

Double Trouble rejected the last thought as they forced their mind back to what Flit said, how she and Panga had visited them yesterday.

I don't remember that at all, they thought. *I just remember talking to Yikka, her telling me—The Orb of Entropy! Yikka has the Orb of Entropy! Which could mean only one thing—she has power over me. My magic stems from the Orb of Entropy, so whoever controls it can control me.*

Confusion and sorrow filled Double Trouble's mind as they considered this betrayal.

Why would Yikka do that? They pondered. But that could be the only conclusion, for she was the last thing they remembered. And if Panga thought something was wrong with Double Trouble, she would try and go to where she thought the problem stemmed from—Yikka.

The Imp sighed deeply, for they knew what they had to do. They had to face Yikka—and this time—get the actual truth from her.

What if she uses her power over me again? They thought. *If that even is what she did.*

A thought occurred to Double Trouble, and they peered down at their black jacket—*their magical jacket.* They ran their fingers over the material on their sleeves, liking how protective it felt. But a strange feeling crept over them, that they were not as fully protected as they could be, making them realize what they needed to do. Reaching down, Double Trouble slowly buttoned the five silver buttons, closing the jacket fully over their torso. The protection felt complete.

It was time to go.

* * *

Panga regained consciousness and moaned, immediately recognizing that she was suffering from the aftereffects of an exceptionally severe curse. Opening her yellow eyes, the feline warrior could only perceive a black wall, strangely lit by an unknown source to her back. The luminescence danced and shimmered on the onyx surface, reminding Panga of light shining up through water. Prone on her side, Panga made an attempt to rise—but couldn't—both hands and feet were bound before her with something that looked like silk ribbons.

The feline warrior yanked at the bindings, but the material held fast—apparently, it was stronger than it appeared. Panga's ears perked as a low pulsation came from behind her—like a vibration—which seemed to accompany the peculiar light behind her. Rolling onto her rear and then her other side, Panga was now able to make out the light source. She gasped at what she discovered, feeling a jolt—like ice—through her torso.

Panga was in a room—not as big as the one she fought Yikka in—but it had the same inky black walls. Instead of the pearlescent marble floor of that room, this one was made of the same stuff as the walls, making it appear as if the feline warrior was in a void of nothingness. In the center of the room was a structure made of the same black materials as the wall. It appeared like a gnarled tree—a black trunk rising from the floor with long, spindly black branches sprouting from the top. The branches bowed outward at the bottom, slowly pointing back in at their ends, giving it the aspect of a great oversized sconce. But when Panga peered at the light source held within the branches, she realized that was exactly what it was.

Nestled protectively within the branches was a large, horrible orb, glowing with a ghostly light—a light Panga had seen many times during her battles with the Death Binders. The evil sorcerers had created these necrotic orbs as a form of magical font, in imitation of their dread god. There was only one way to draw the magic needed for these orbs, one dark way—death.

A Ruin Sphere! She thought with horror. *But how can this be? All the Death Binders are gone, and the Set'Heth-un'dar was destroyed!*

Her question was answered when she spotted the architect of this Ruin Sphere—Yikka—standing before it with her back turned towards Panga, arms and hands held out—as if praising its power. Corposant energy, like lighting, connected the Ruin Sphere to the palms of both of her outstretched hands. Yikka was like a conductor, orchestrating a great and terrible symphony of evil.

DEAD

"Yikka!" Panga cried, horror in her voice. "What have you done?!"

Yikka lowered her hands, severing her link to the Ruin Sphere and turning to Panga with a friendly smile.

"Hey, sleepyhead!" She said with a laugh. "It's about time you woke up!"

* * *

Double Trouble strode purposefully through the Numen's double doors as lighting from the fierce storm backlit their entrance. There to greet them was Carmen, gliding up to Double Trouble with hands behind her back and a tepid smile.

"I'm sorry to have to tell you, but Janus is not ready to receive you today, Double Trouble. Perhaps tomorrow would be a better day to come to the Numen?" She stated cordially.

"Today will be fine, honey," the Imp said, brushing past her forcefully.

Carmen gasped—apparently, she had never been so rudely treated in her life. She caught up with Double Trouble's quick stride and positioned herself between them and further entry, arms held out.

“You will NOT go any further! Janus has commanded it!” She said sternly.

Double Trouble gazed at her coolly, their long green tail twitching in irritation.

“Honey, if you don’t get out of my way*,* I will smack you so hard that even Janus will feel it on the top floor*.*” They stated plainly, giving Carmen their most dangerous smile. “*Now*, get out of my way, *darling,*”

Carmen gulped, gaping up at Double Trouble as they stood menacingly over her. Putting her arms down, Carmin did as they asked, meekly standing to one side as the Imp glided past her and to the elevator. Entering it, they pressed the up button.

Leaning up against the wood-paneled interior of the elevator during the long ride up, Double Trouble impatiently tapped their foot. Once again, they felt a cloud attempt to settle upon their mind—but now recognizing its insidious presence for what it was—they resisted it.

Double Trouble ran their hands over the buttons that held their jacket closed—it gave the Imp the impression that they were in a protective shell. They could almost feel the presence of its last owner, Shen, and they focused on him, using their fond memories of the handsome human as a talisman to strengthen their protection.

Thinking of what they would find in the Temple, Double Trouble’s mind tumbled; there were many different scenarios depicting the upcoming struggle. So many different ways this particular drama could play out. Yikka had taken on the role of villain and caused Panga to be the damsel in distress—by the standard laws of narration—this made Double Trouble the hero of this particular story.

The hero always climbs the tower to slay the villain, thereby rescuing the damsel. But does it have to be that way? In Double

Trouble's mind, Yikka was also the damsel in distress—a victim of the true enemy: the ignorance of their home world.

Couldn't they rescue both women from the web of fate, just like they had with Catra and Shen? The Imp had Chaos on their side—just as they had in those moments past. Double Trouble could do it; they could save Yikka from herself. They just needed the chance.

MIDNIGHT

The elevator came to an abrupt stop as the doors opened with a chime—the cheerful sound at odds with the dark chamber, lit by the flashing lightning from outside the large window. Double Trouble found the expansive chamber disturbing and off, not like the other times they had come here to visit Yikka. At the other end of the chamber, they spotted the wreckage of the desk and the previously mounted staff lying on the floor nearby.

Panga was definitely here. The darling doesn't do introductions very well, they thought, remembering how their candy store was trashed during their first meeting with the Star Hunter.

Double Trouble's ears perked up as they suddenly heard voices. Turning their head to the right, they noted that the voices were coming from the black double doors they had spotted during their first visit. One of the doors was slightly ajar as a strange light peeked between the cracks; it glimmered and danced on the floor in sync with the lighting flashes.

Double Trouble strained their ears as they crept up to the door, recognizing Yikka's voice; it sounded like she was speaking to someone.

Double Trouble stood by the open door and listened.

* * *

Padding slowly over to Panga's lying form, Yikka kneeled and reached out for her orange face, stroking the edge of the cream-

colored patch around the feline woman’s left eye with the tips of her green claws.

“I’m so sorry I had to do that Panga,” Yikka said sorrowfully. “Using your most painful memories against you like that. I’m sorry, but it was the only way to stop you without killing you.”

Panga shook her head as if to dislodge Yikka’s touch. “It's not important, Yikka! What are you doing with a Ruin Sphere? It's dangerous!”


IRIA•ABELLA

Yikka cocked her head. “Oh, that thing?” She said, pointing behind her with her thumb. “It's just a means to an end.”

Panga appeared as if struck. “What end could that possibly be, Yikka?” She asked, afraid of the answer.

Yikka sighed deeply before giving Panga a small smile. “You’re a very curious kitty,” she said, reaching over and poking Panga lightly on the nose. “Very well, I will tell you.”

“I’m assuming Atreyen told you my sad story, for it seems that the two of you have gotten close.” She said, giving Panga a sly smile. “When I told them that I arrived on Shen’Dar-oom and was captured, tortured, and kept as a slave, I wasn’t exactly truthful.” She said with a grin.

Panga gave Yikka a scathing look. “Big surprise there,” she said deadpan.

Yikka laughed and continued. “It wasn’t by accident I ended up in the Place of Night and on Shen’Dar-oom—I chose to go there. I chose to go there over reuniting with Atreyen; I knew I just wasn't ready to find them yet. There were other needs I needed satisfied before reuniting Atreyen and the Place of Night called to me. When I got there, I approached the Death Binders and joined them willingly.” She said, nodding.

Panga was horrified at this admission, but Yikka ignored it, continuing her story.

“They really aren’t that bad, Panga. They were very open and forthcoming with their knowledge and teachings, and they were fascinated by my powers. We learned a lot from each other over the years—or whatever time scale they used in that realm. I don’t really know how long I was in the Place of Night, only that I was there a *really* long time, for I had used my new knowledge and abilities to extend my life.”

“Well, over time, I came to the limits of my power—a kind of barrier, you could call it. I didn’t really like that, so I asked my new friends to help me fix it.”

“Your *friends*? You mean the Death Binders?” Panga interrupted.

Yikka nodded. “Yeah, the Death Binders and their lord, the Shen’Aan-war—great guy, by the way,” Yikka stated cheerily.

“THE DARK HE-MAN WAS NOT A GREAT GUY!!!” Panga screamed, but her words had no effect. Yikka just smiled and shook her head at Panga.

“Stop yelling!” Yikka laughed at her prisoner. “Anyway, they had a great idea. Why not lure Janus to Shen’Dar-oom and get them to give me the Orb of Entropy? Surely its own might would enable me to increase my powers! The Death Binders enacted a ritual doing just that. We brought Janus to Shen’Dar-oom—but they were not exactly happy about the idea of giving their power to me…” Yikka said, sadness appearing on her beautiful face. She shook her head and smiled at Panga again.

“Anyway, I was now the bearer of the Orb of Entropy! I was so happy to continue my journey along the path of knowledge!” Yikka said.

Panga scrutinized Yikka. “I see it now—you're insane.” She said simply.

Yikka groaned dramatically and looked up at the ceiling open-mouthed in exasperation.

“First, I’m evil. Now I’m insane.” She said in sing-song fashion. “You really have a need to apply labels to people Panga. Whats up with that?”

Panga ignored the question. “So you came with the invaders to this galaxy, right, Yikka? You were there when they subjugated whole worlds? When those monsters split up families and killed innocents?”

Yikka waved this off. “That was all lies. I never saw any of that. I came to Thenlor to help with a great project the Death Binders were working on. I got here just as that She-Ra person viciously attacked the Shen’Aan-war and hurt the poor man so badly, he had to go back to Shen’Dar-oom. After that, it was all we could do just to stay alive here, for the populace started turning against us. Plus, that naughty White Claw was always giving us trouble.”

Yikka waved a scolding finger at Panga while the other woman grinned at her smugly.

“I traveled with the Death Binders to Etheria to welcome the Shen’Aan-war back and to greet the Set'Heth-under as it came into this universe. Oh, it was such an exciting time!” Yikka said, clapping her hands together. “But then, once again, She-Ra ruined everything. The Shen’Aan-war was defeated when his *own* son stole his powers, and the rest of the Death Binders were wiped out when the Set'Heth-un'dar was destroyed. Not really sure how that last part happened,” Yikka said, holding her chin as if pondering a great mystery.

Panga interrupted before Yikka could continue. “Yikka, if all this is true, why did you never tell Atreyen? If you think what you are doing is right, why create these falsehoods? Why did you hide from them instead of revealing yourself from the very beginning?”

Yikka appeared confused at Panga’s question, shaking her head as if a bug was pestering her. Panga continued.

“You want to know why? It’s because you know that what you’re doing is *wrong*, Yikka. You know it, and you know Atreyen would never accept it. You know it because deep down inside, you still have good inside you; the person you used to be is still there, the person that Atreyen first fell in love with! Stop this madness before it's too late!”

Yikka regarded her hands, sadness written on her face. “I did not join my friends in their battle with She-Ra—instead choosing to search for arcane knowledge in a place called Mystacor. When I

returned, they were all gone, and I was left with no one. I was alone. Then I saw them. I saw Atreyen." She said with a small smile on her face.

"I had not seen them in such a long, long time, and they looked so different. But I would recognize them no matter what they looked like or the length of time that had passed. I am not sure why I did it, but I kept myself hidden from Atreyen, watching from afar. When I discovered that they were leaving Etheria, I secretly followed them. You can't imagine my surprise and joy when I realized that they were coming here out of all the other planets in the universe. It was like it was meant to be," Yikka said in wonder.

"It was like the cosmos or some higher power had brought us together again, guiding us to this place, in this time. It was then that I realized what I had to do. I created this silly Vibrissa organization to help me realize my ultimate goal and involved Atreyen in it, ensuring that when the time came, they would see the wisdom of my plan when I finally revealed myself."

"My plan for us to come together and be one, becoming a force to be reckoned with. A force that would fight against the kind of tyranny and oppression we had faced on our world. A force for good." Yikka said, pure beneficence on her face.

A sudden realization came to Panga; the Sable, Yikka, the Orb of Entropy, Atreyen, and the dark ritual she read on the hidden parchment written by none other than Zzar.

"You want to become a god, Yikka?" Panga whispered. "You want to join with Atreyen and become a god just like Zzar did?"

Yikka shook her head fervently. "No! Not like Zzar! Zzar only wanted power for power's sake! She betrayed and killed millions in order to ascend to her godhood—paying dearly for it! Instead of a ritual based on mass death, I will fuel my ascension through the small bits of life force collected by my Sable. No one dies! No one is betrayed!" Yikka replied, fervor in her voice.

Panga shook her head, tears forming in her eyes in compassion for the poor lost soul in front of her.

“No, Yikka, you’re wrong. The Sable IS killing people. I’ve seen it! The only difference between your ritual and Zzar’s is the rate at which the death is occurring!”

Yikka shook her head as Panga continued.

“Does Atreyen know of your plan of joining with you? Or are you keeping them in the dark so they won't know what you have planned for them? That’s your betrayal there, Yikka. You are pretending to love Ateyen—just so you can trick and betray them!” Panga accused.

“NOOO!!” Yikka screamed back at her. “You have no idea what you are talking about! I do love Atreyen! Why do you think I’ve been using my power all this time? To help guide them along! To help them see the *light* of my way! I’M DOING IT BECAUSE I LOVE THEM!” Yikka screamed in Panga’s face.

“NO!” A voice said from the door.

Both Panga and Yikka turned to see Double Trouble standing there, horror written all over their face.

“This ends now, Yikka,” they said, voice filled with fury. “I’m here to stop you.”

Chapter End Notes

Illustration by Iria, a.k.a., ilikeyoucatradora on Tumblr and Instagram.

And Death Shall Have No Dominion

Chapter Summary

Double Trouble faces Yikka in a climatic showdown.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Double Trouble stood tall within the entrance to the secret chamber, their lithe body having a newfound strength that Panga had never perceived before. The feline woman could not explain it, but there was a beauty to the Imp now, a vibrancy that poured outward from their skin with a soulful brilliance—it was like she was seeing them for the first time.

"Atreyen! My love! I'm so glad you're here!" Yikka said, striding over to the newly arrived Double Trouble, arms held open in greeting.

Panga used the distraction as an opportunity to test her bonds again, bending her fingers just enough to touch the material with her claws. Moving her nails back and forth as if itching a scratch, she felt the material of her bonds begin to part.

Yikka was within touching distance when Double Trouble reached under their jacket, withdrawing the Night Sabre in one smooth motion. They held it up and ignited its black blade, aiming its tip at Yikka.

"Stay away from me, Yikka," they said coldly. "I heard everything you just told Panga."

Yikka held her hands up in placation but still approached Double Trouble slowly.

"Atreyen, darling, please listen to me. I was just telling our pretty Madgēcot friend that to distract her. Please trust me, Atreyen," she

said smoothly.

Weaving fingers before her, Yikka traced complex patterns that made the air shimmer. Double Trouble squinted at this, appearing unmoved by the attempts to charm them again. Holding their weapon outward as if to ward off a terrible beast, the Imp began to back away from Yikka.

“That’s not going to work again, Yikka, darling.” Double Trouble said, shaking their head sadly. “I believed you. *I believed you loved me.* But this whole time, you were manipulating me.”

“I do love you, Atreyen. That part was always true.” Yikka said while continuing to try and ensnare them with magic.

Double Trouble clenched their teeth, baring them in a grimace. “You were never corrupted by anyone, Yikka. *You corrupted yourself!*” They cried, pain and sorrow bleeding from their voice.

Yikka stopped moving her hands and peered at Double Trouble’s jacket with suspicion.

“I don’t know why I’m just noticing this, but that lovely jacket isn’t a part of you, is it, Atreyen? I sense magic in it. Where did you get it?”

“From someone who *actually* cared about me. It’s protecting me from your power.” Double Trouble answered.

Yikka mock gasped. “Another lover!” She cried, then smiled mischievously.

“I’m not surprised, Atreyen. We have been away from each other for so long. I don’t blame you for wanting company. Although I’m confused as to why you think you're protected from me.” Yikka said, holding her hand out as if grasping something. “After all, I do have the Orb of Entropy.”

Double Trouble suddenly halted, frozen in position by a shimmering red haze surrounding their outline. Yikka continued

her advance, sauntering towards Double Trouble as her tail waved lazily behind her. She reached over to pluck the Night Sabre from their hand, deactivating it before tossing it over her shoulder.

"It really hurts my feelings that you say I don't love you, Atreyen. For I do love you, with all my heart and soul." Yikka said, anger and sadness in her voice. "I didn't want to do it this way—pulling you kicking and screaming to your destiny. But I will do it if I must."

Yikka extended her hand as it transformed—becoming the stygian night of red demon eyes that signified her corruption. She closed her eyes and concentrated—focusing on her target—using her control over the Orb of Entropy to force Double Trouble into their transitional state. As the Imp's body reverted into a twilight of dancing green fireflies, Yikka made contact with their chest, her long digits creating soft ripples as they entered Double Trouble's form, appearing as if Yikka were dipping fingers into the surface of a still pool. There was panic in Double Trouble's eyes as the two began to merge into one.

"NO!!!" She shrieked. "Don't do this, Yikka! This is wrong!"

Yikka continued, fully pushing her arm into Double Trouble's torso —red and green lights dancing together at the focal point of the merging. Panga watched this transpire with stupefied horror, all the while trying furiously to cut her bonds. She was close to cutting through.

The joining of Double Trouble and Yikka continued—Yikka's body was now fully in her transitional form as she stepped fully into Double Trouble—and in a flash of white light—the process was complete.

The entity that had once been two separate personalities screamed in torment, bending over and holding its head as if wracked by some unimaginable pain. It was in a completely transitional form, all black with both red and green lights, heterochromatic eyes glowing green and red.

"NOOOOO!!!!" It screamed in a dissonance, a combination of Yikka and Double Trouble's voices.

"YIKKA, PLEASE, I DON'T WANT THIS!!!"

* * *

After a few moments of swirling confusion, Atreyen finds themselves in a corridor—rows of narrow metallic doors line the walls, interspersed here and there by larger versions composed of wood. Green-skinned youths crowd the hall, chatting amongst themselves in small cliques as their tails twitch excitedly. A creeping sense of familiarity stirs within Atreyen as they notice all of the children seem to be looking in the same direction—directing their focus there—they see a girl standing before one of the numerous small doors.

No! They are lockers! *Thinks Atreyen.* ***This is my school, and I recognize that girl! Its—***

"Yikka!" A feminine and very familiar voice calls.

Atreyen directs their attention to the speaker—there they spot another youngster, this one garbed in clothing distinctly different than the others. Where the other children are dressed according to a distinct gender binary, this child is dressed in clothes that are set in neither a male nor female mien: an old pair of men's work overalls combined with a woman's sweater—modified to be sleeveless. It is a solid first attempt to undermine the social norm and Atreyen knows precisely how proud the child is of their outfit—for this is a younger version of themself they are looking at.

"Yikka? Are you okay?" The younger Atreyen asks.

Realization dawns. ***I know what is happening! This is the day after the kiss in the auditorium! That is why everyone is staring at us—they know!***

Like watching an old video, Ateyen witnesses the drama play out—their younger version attempts to placate Yikka, hoping to

salvage their budding relationship. Yikka—afraid of the consequences—spurns them, turning her back on the younger Atreyen, walking away.

Atreyen is surprised by the spike of pain they feel, almost as if it were fresh—not decades in the past. Their attention is fixed on the retreating form of Yikka as something occurs to them.

The last thing I remember is Yikka merging with me. I must be in some combined version of our memories! *Atreyen thinks as they begin to follow the young version of Yikka.*

Looking down, they see their form as a ghostly outline of their older body, the one currently being absorbed into the twisted, future Yikka. Before them is her younger self—before the life-altering experience in the Conversion Center. Is this the key they had been looking for? Could Atreyen possibly reach this Yikka and turn her future self away from the path of evil? Is there still time?

The young version of Yikka is striding before them now, hugging herself as she turns a corner. As Atreyen catches up, they spot the school's main entrance not far away—the bright afternoon light blazing through the door windows, making them squint.

Yikka accelerates from a quick pace to a jog—her focus entirely set on the double doors as Atreyen attempts to match her pace—yet suddenly—they feel as if they are running through water. Holding out an ethereal hand, Atreyen opens their mouth to call to the Yikka of years past, un-damaged by ignorance and cruelty.

"Yikka! Wait—" They call. But it is too late; Yikka bursts through the doors and Atreyen's sight is blinded by the searing light outside …

After another brief span of dissociation, Atreyen finds themself in a small room; pink flowery wallpaper combined with feminine adornments suggests this to be girl's bedroom. Their summation is confirmed when Atreyen's eyes alight upon Yikka on a nearby bed. She is dressed only in a shift and is curled up into a ball as

she weeps upon a quilted comforter. Atreyen kneels by the bedside and reaches to stroke Yikka's long hair—but the attempt is fruitless—their ghostly fingers pass through her red strands like mist between reeds.

"Yikka, my poor dear. I'm here! I will help you this time!" Atreyen urges.

But there is no response from Yikka, only sobs wracking her slight frame. It is then that Areyen can feel it—slowly at first, like morning frost creeping across a glass pane—but then more urgent —like an ice shard slipping into their heart.

Anguish. Intense and all-encompassing desolation—coming not from Atreyen—but from the young girl before them.

Of course!** They realize. **This is Yikka's memory I am immersed in. Not only will I remember what she saw, but what she felt at the time as well. Oh, my poor Yikka!

On top of the sadness, Atreyen can sense extreme fatigue, telling them that Yikka has been in this state for the entire night. The faint glow of early sunlight can be discerned through the window curtains—soon, it will be morning.

"Oh, Atreyen…" Yikka suddenly rasps. "I'm so sorry—why did I run from you?"

Wiping her eyes, Yikka sits up, casting about her room as if searching for them. Atreyen wants to reach out and seize her—to let Yikka know she is not alone and forsaken.

"Atreyen! I promise I will make things right today! I will find you at school and show everyone—let everyone know… that I love you!" She says, voice and face set in determination.

Atreyen feels buoyed and saddened by Yikka's words—she is going to tell them she loves them! But knowing how this night plays out, Janus has already visited the younger version of Atreyen, and they have already departed this realm. That means…

The sudden slam makes both Atreyen and Yikka turn—it has come from downstairs, the front door most likely. The staccato rhythm of many feet ascending the stairs matches the pace of their quickening heart, and Atreyen turns to see the dawning horror on Yikka's face.

"No…" She gasps. "My parents didn't—no!"

The bedroom door soon opens as Yikka's mother strides in, followed by two large men dressed in white uniforms. Yikka screams as she leaps from the bed, dashing for the window—but the uniformed men appear to have foreseen this—quickly rushing forward to seize the wayward girl.

"Don't fight Yikka!" Her mother scolds. "Don't embarrass us more than you already have!"

Atreyen is helpless as their first love is dragged kicking and screaming to her doom, all the while knowing that if they had returned to their home planet instead of running away to Etheria, they could have stopped this from happening.

In a flash of brilliance, Atreyen's vision is lost.

* * *

Panga stared in morbid fascination as the entity comprised of two different began its march toward the Ruin Sphere. The entity moved in a slow, jerking motion—the upper torso pulled backward as the feet strode forward, head twisting from side to side. It was almost as if it were fighting against itself, trying to stop from walking towards the ghostly glow of the Ruin Sphere.

"YEEESSSS!!! ATREYENNNN!!! WE ARE CLOSSSEEE!!" It said in a voice of disharmony.

As it neared its destination, beams of energy reached forth from the Ruin Sphere and encircled the entity—like a dark parent reaching out to an anti-child, embracing it into a bosom of decrepitude. The entity's body began to glow with the same

ghostly energy as the Ruin Sphere; its ascension was imminent, and soon Double Trouble would be lost.

* * *

Atreyen's mind spun as they regained coherence, the fug of confusion immediately replaced by an unusual sense of disassociation. They could move their body, but it is as if they are not completely in control—that Atreyen is ambulating in concert with another. The two men who had invaded Yikka's room are to either side of Atreyen, leading them towards a blocky concrete structure interspersed by narrow windows. It is a grim building—its name coming to Atreyen's mind easily.

The Conversion Center.

Atreyen has heard stories of this terrible place, but now they lay eyes upon it, they realize that even the worst story cannot do justice to it. It looks like a prison of the worst kind—which it is. Not just for the body—but a prison for the soul as well.

Peering down to inspect themselves, Atreyen sees a feminine body clothed in a thin shift. Immediately, they can tell that the body is not theirs—not even before their transition into their true non-binary state. But the clothing is known to them, for they have just seen its style and patterns.

Wait! That's what Yikka was wearing in her room! That means I am looking through her eyes, experiencing what she had gone through firsthand. *They realize.*

The merging of their identity with Yikka's has reached an event horizon, and soon, Atreyen will lose their perception of themselves. For someone who spent decades establishing a unique identity, the idea of being subsumed into another was terrifying—even if it is someone whom they care dearly for.

But Atreyen attempts to cast aside these feelings of dismay—they must see; they have to find that chink in Yikka's armor. Not to defeat her—but to save her!

“Come on, time to meet your new friends,” one of the men says, tugging at their arm.

“No!” Atreyen shrieks in Yikka’s voice, fighting against the vise-like grip of her jailers.

“We got another fighter,” the other man says with a laugh. “Good thing we have sedatives for the new arrivals!”

Atreyen begins to struggle like a wild animal as they are forced forward; as they near the Conversion Center, two more men in white uniforms and a woman in a gown stride out of the double doors. The men immediately seize Atreyen’s kicking feet to hold them vertically off the ground. As Atreyen writhes in midair, the woman comes astride them, withdrawing a large syringe.

“No! No! Noooo!” Atreyen screams in Yikka’s voice. “Atreyen! Atreyen! Help me, please!!!”

With a slowly dwindling realization of an actual self, Atreyen identifies a cruel twist of fate: here they are, trying to save Yikka in her memories when all they had to do was answer her plea and save her from this situation. It would have been so easy to accomplish with chaos on their side— the pain of this fact makes Atreyen’s slide into assimilation all the easier to accept—they give into Yikka’s desire to merge without a fight.

With a well-practiced surety, the woman presses the sharp tip of the needle into Atreyen’s arm, penetrating the soft green skin to deliver the dense liquid into their bloodstream. As their consciousness slowly fades into oblivion once more, they find it confusing that they are trying to get through to Yikka.

After all, isn’t that who they are? How can they get through to themselves?

They are she, and she is Yikka.

* * *

The entity no longer appeared to be fighting itself as it pressed outstretched arms into the blazing unlight of the Ruin Sphere. Abruptly, a low buzzing began vibrating through the floor and into Panga's body, making her fur tickle. The feline warrior could feel this power deep in her bones, permeating into the very core of her essence.

Something was coming. Something very bad was approaching from the darkness that exists behind the folds of reality, soon to be birthed before her very eyes. She had to act now.

Panga snapped out of her fixation on the entity and renewed her efforts against the bonds, yanking on them in combination with cutting them with her claws. With a last burst of effort, the bonds gave, freeing her arms.

Reaching down quickly, the feline warrior cut the bindings restricting her legs, leaping to her feet. Panga approached the entity hesitantly, not sure whether seizing it and pulling it away from its course was a wise plan. Its chaotic body was in a complete state of flux— there was no telling what would happen if she laid a hand upon them. There was only one option, and looking down at her torso, Panga realized what she had to do.

* * *

It is nighttime in the Conversion Center, and Yikka cannot find solace in sleep. Seated on a small cot in the nighttime seclusion room, she sits up against the rigid tile wall in an attempt to find some margin of comfort. The cold of the ceramic permeates through the paper-thin clothing supplied to her by the Guides and into her body—but the chill feels good in comparison to the misery Yikka has undergone. She has endured this nightmare of a place for what seems like centuries now, the days merging together in an endless stream of horror.

Yikka had fought tooth and nail against the initial attempts to crush her spirit, and when the coercion, manipulation, and forceful

indoctrination tactics did not work, that's when the therapies began.

Yikka glances at the other cot on the opposite side of the cramped space, its occupant in a fetal position as she weeps. Yikka has forgotten her cellmate's name, the memory loss being a side effect of electroshock treatment that she has endured numerous sessions of. That and the medications placed in her food and water have made it hard to concentrate—but that is not the worst by far.

These monsters have taken from her—not just her life and dignity—but actual parts of her. The parts of Yikka's body that the Guides believe are the root of her so-called affliction—cutting them away with the scalpel's razor edge. The latest procedure is the worst, and Yikka raises a tentative hand to the bandages wrapped around her temple.

"The problem lies in your hypothalamus, Yikka," the surgeon had said to her. "We will perform what is called a pre-frontal lobotomy in order to correct it. After that, you will be right as rain and ready to rejoin proper society. Doesn't that sound nice?"

But Yikka does not feel 'as right as rain'—she feels far from it. She cannot explain it fully, but besides the pain of the surgery, Yikka feels as if something has been un-stoppered within her—or a wall has been knocked down. An unspecified part of her has been released… or discovered… or… created.

These fools did not accomplish what they sought—Yikka still has the same sexual desires as she did before—what makes her the way she is beyond their control. It is something separate from the meat of her flesh—they can keep digging and digging until nothing is left of Yikka and still not remove it—for it is an essence that is intrinsic to her soul.

But the monsters did accomplish something—oh, they definitely achieved a feat of unrivaled incompetency with their clumsy blundering inside her brain. Yikka's thoughts used to be linear—a

simple and concise line of beautiful logic that fit comfortably together.

But not now… now they tumble… they twirl into each other… sometimes exploding into a synaptic brilliance, leaving red and orange streaks across her vision. At other times Yikka feels as if her consciousness is moving backwards—or even worse—stuck in time, having no way to move beyond a fixed point. The intense horror she feels in these moments is indescribable, made all the worse by being unable to move or scream.

Emotions come and go like shifting winds; Yikka will feel that something is amusing for inexplicable reasons—but then abruptly, it is replaced by fear or elation. Intense anger and fuming rage are the dominant states of existence for Yikka—but these emotions make sense to her, as does the sadness. So much has been wrongfully taken from a young woman in such a short period of time, and all of it can never properly be given back.

The majority of the time, it's hard for Yikka to concentrate on anything—but then there are short periods in which there is only one thing she can think about. The subject of these fixations is sometimes revenge—wanting to harness the rage and anger and lash out at all those who have wronged her.

But generally, her attention is fixed not on pointless fantasies of the future—but on bittersweet recollections of the past. A face is always tied to these reminiscences—an aspect that leads to a scent, then a touch, and finally to a feeling—one that Yikka experiences so rarely now, even in the chaos of her mind.

Happiness.

In the moments Yikka finally reunites with long lost joy, she whispers a name, as she does now.

"Atreyen…"

Yikka speaks it in a hush, afraid that the cruelties of the environment she inhabits will somehow find this name and steal it

from her. But then the anger returns, as does her boldness, and Yikka voices her endearment into the clutches of the night.

"Atreyen, I'm so sorry! I should have embraced you instead of running away—I wish I could take it all back! I wish you could somehow find me and take me away! I wish—oh, how I wish…"

The moon's light finds its way through the narrow window, alighting upon Yikka's face as she looks up, expectation and hope written across her features. Yikka could somehow feel her soulmate with her, as if they were looking from behind her eyes, their hand upon her heart.

"Atreyen, remember that time when we were both on the stage? I was so nervous when you took my hand… but when I realized you wanted to kiss me…" she says, closing her eyes in blissful memory.

"When we were pressed together, I could feel your heart beating in time with mine—like we were both the same person! I could live in that moment forever!"

Yikka cocks her head as something occurs to her, something kind of odd at first, but as she thinks harder about it, the more it seems to make sense.

"I wish… I wish we really could be one, Atreyen. I feel… ***incomplete****… you—you could fill these empty places in me… the parts of me they took away…" she says, suddenly feeling resolute.*

"If you were a part of me, we would be unstoppable! We could do incredible things together!"

The sense that she is not alone returns to Yikka, as does a feeling of deja vu. She reaches towards her chest, placing her fingers where her heart is.

"Wait… I remember this—I… did this already," she says, casting about the room.

* * *

Reaching down, the feline warrior selected the Chakra Block from her Jaadoo-suit, yanking it off and balling it up in her fist. Tears mist her yellow eyes as Panga realizes that she will have to break her sacred promise in order to save her friend.

"I'm so sorry, Atreyen," she whispered, then hurled enchantment at the entity with all her might.

The Chakra Block streaked like a green comet before exploding into crackling rainbow sparks, surrounding the entity in a halo before absorbing into its chaotic form.

The reaction was immediate.

* * *

"I get it," Yikka says, a smile of realization appearing on her lips. "This seems new because… because a part of me has never seen this before. It's because you are here, Atreyen! You are already here with me! We are already one—I can feel it!"

She looks towards the corner of the cell, the spot where the shadows gather to create a pitch void. Her face becomes set with the fervor of a zealot as she stands—no longer restricted by the pain of recent surgeries, for they have already occurred centuries ago.

"This was the night they came to me, Atreyen—they appeared right there in the darkness," Yikka says, pointing. "Janus arrived and gave me the power to escape this place. Later, they came to Shen'Dar-oom, and I took the rest of their power from them."

Her eyes widen as the entire truth of transpiring events catches up with her—the grin on Yikka's face widens to manic glee.

"The Ritual is taking place! The one I learned from beautiful Zzar! Which means we aren't really here—are we, Atreyen?" She says, standing up.

"It's time you and I leave, Atreyen. Leave this poor, twisted thing called mortality and join the ranks of the celestials. Some might call us a god, but we won't accept worship from just anyone—not like that foolish religion back home! Only the worthy will be accepted into our new theology—those who are exactly like us in heart and soul! We cannot risk those who differ from us taking control of our lives ever again—they must be cast down and burned—obliterated so no more—

Yikka's eyes suddenly widen as her head whips around, directing a look of fury and horror at some unseen enemy. Reaching out towards this invisible assailant, Yikka screams.

"PANGA, NOOO!!!"

* * *

In a flash of brilliance, Double Trouble and Yikka were cast from each other, landing in opposite directions and unconscious. Panga ran to Double Trouble, kneeling down to run tentative hands over their body, searching for injury and to ensure they were solid once more. Just like the last time Panga had used the Chakra block on them, Double Trouble was naked beneath their jacket—their body curvy and feminine. Panga lifted them into her lap, brushing delicate claws over their face.

"Atreyen, I'm so sorry to have done that to you," she said mournfully. "There was no other way. I couldn't let her take you!"

Double Trouble opened their eyes and smiled up at Panga. "It's okay," they whispered in a voice that was no longer androgynous. "Thank you."

Double Trouble grasped Panga's hand as they looked past her—turning her head—Panga spotted Yikka lying on the ground, still unconscious. She was fully nude and much, much different looking—older and more worn out, like a shadow reflection of the illusion of youth that magic allowed her. Amongst a head of gray

hair was a bare patch—a brutal scar bisected it, ending at her temple.

"When we were joined, I saw her memories fully, Panga. So much pain was there, and what they did to her in the Conversion Center was monstrous. It drove her to madness," Double Trouble said.

"She wants to do horrible things—believing them to be right—but in the end, she still loves me, Panga. My poor Yikka still loves me." Moisture pooled in Double Trouble's eyes as they returned their attention to Yikka.

Suddenly Double Trouble gasped as their powers returned, and they immediately reverted to their true appearance. Yikka was standing slowly—she had also resumed her connection to Entropy as the illusion of youth and beauty settled once more into place. Double Trouble lunged out of Panga's arms and grasped the Night Sabre nearby. Kneeling, they activated the blade, drawing the sizzling edge up to their neck.

"NO!" Yikka screamed, holding out her hand and freezing Double Trouble in place before they could harm themselves.

Panga leaped at Yikka, hands outstretched and claws extended. With an outward strike of her hand and a flash of red light, Yikka sent Panga careening to the other side of the room—the feline woman landed on hands and feet, sliding on tense claws to stop her momentum.

Yikka approached the frozen Double Trouble with tears in her eyes, once again removing their weapon from stiff fingers to deactivate it. But instead of tossing it to the ground like before, Yikka held on to it as she strode away. Once at a good distance, Yikka turned back to gaze mournfully at her old lover, her aspect cast in the mien of finality. Anticipating a sudden threat, Panga leaped to the Imp's defense, standing in front of them with arms out as if to shield them.

Yikka smiled sadly at Panga as she waved her hand, releasing Double Trouble from her grip—the Imp gasped as they regained control over their body.

“You were going to kill yourself?” Yikka asked Double Trouble sadly. “You wanted to get away from me so badly you wanted to kill yourself?”

Double Trouble shook their head. “Not away from you, Yikka. Away from what you were going to do to the both of us!” They shouted, tears in their eyes. “I love you, Yikka, I always have, and I know you love me! Please, let's stop this!”

Yikka shook her head. “Atreyen,” she whispered. “Why won't you go with me? Why won't you fly with me again?”

“Because it's too high, Yikka! It's too high for me. I can’t this time!” Double Trouble said, pain in their voice as they reached out to Yikka. “Please, just come with me. We can heal you. I know we can!”

Yikka cocked her head at this offer, a small smile appearing on her face. “Heal me?” She said, slightly confused. She reached up to her head—to the spot where the scar had appeared when she had momentarily lost her magic, lightly stroking it.

Double Trouble continued to appeal to Yikka. “Yes, Yikka! When we were one, just now, I saw what they did to you at the Conversion Center. It’s what caused you to be like this! Can’t you see it?”

Yikka continued to caress her head, a contemplative look appearing on her beautiful face as realization dawned on her. She nodded to Double Trouble.

“I see it, Atreyen,” she whispered.

SIGN OF LIFE

Double Trouble gave a slight laugh and reached father for her. “Come with me, Yikka, *please*,” they begged.

Yikka reached out to Double Trouble, a hopeful smile appearing briefly before her face fell, arm dropping limply to her side.

“I do see it, Atreyen. You were able to see what happened to me through my eyes, and I was able to see myself through your eyes. It's too late—I’ve already gone too high. I’ve gone too far. There is too much *death* inside me,” she said sadly, bringing the Night Sabre hilt up. “I see it now. I see what I was about to do to you, and it horrifies me. *What I have become horrifies me.*”

Yikka held the sabre hilt in both hands, gazing at it dreamily as Double Trouble approached slowly.

“Yikka, please, just come with me to Elysia. Panga’s people can heal you, believe me!” Double Trouble implored, reaching out with both hands to touch her.

Yikka shook her head. “No, I can’t allow you to be corrupted by me. It's too late for me, my love,” she said with grim finality.

“No Yikka, it's never too late!” Double Trouble pleaded.

Yikka beamed at them—a pure, open-hearted smile, and Double Trouble saw the Yikka they had remembered. The Yikka who accepted them no matter what others said and welcomed whomever they wanted to be—Yikka who would always be there for them when the entire world seemed to be against them. Their dearest truest friend who loved them, and who they loved in return.

“I love you, Atreyen,” Yikka said.

Placing both hands on the Night Sabre hilt, she twisted it toward her chest—and activated it.

With a snap-hiss, the black energy blade pierced through Yikka’s chest, searing through her body to burst out the back. Yikka

gasped—wide-eyed—as the excruciating pain provided insight as to the consequences of her rash actions.

With strength quickly leaving her, Yikka released the weapon's activation stud—as suddenly as it appeared—the killing blade vanished from within her body. The Night Sabre hilt fell from slackened fingers, clattering harmlessly to the ground.

But the damage had already been done; hunched over and looking down, Yikka raised a tentative hand to the smoldering hole in her chest, almost in disbelief at what she had done.

"I don't want to—" she began—then stumbled forward, falling face-first to the ground.

"NOOOOO!!!" Double Trouble cried as they rushed to her side. They kneeled, pulling the fallen Yikka up into their arms, cradling her head to peer down at her face. She gazed up at Double Trouble—love for them in the brilliance of her eyes as regret cast her lips into a grimace.

"I am sorry… sorry for what I tried to do and sorry for this… I was so horrified by myself that this seemed like the only choice…*it wasn't.*" She said.

"NO!! Please no, Yikka, nooo!!!" Double Trouble cried, the grief streaming in rivers from their yellow and green eyes.

Panga knelt nearby, placing a tentative hand on Double Trouble's shoulder, tears falling from her eyes as well. Yikka cast her gaze in the feline warrior's direction, her lips forming a beautiful smile.

"I should… have taken your offer… *Star Hunter*…now you must take care of Atreyen… for me…" Yikka wheezed. Panga nodded before turning to Double Trouble; as her eyes met theirs, the feline woman could see pupils dilated in absolute panic.

"Panga! Can't you do something? Use that magic suit of yours to heal Yikka—*Please!*" Double Trouble pleaded.

The feline warrior gritted her teeth, unsure of what to say; Panga would have to be back on Elysia with an entire medical team at her disposal. There was no way to halt Yikka's encroaching death with the minor mending cantrips of her Jaddoo-suit.

"Atreyen, I don't—" She started before choking up, unable to tell her friend the bad news.

"Hey," Yikka whispered, placing fingertips on Double Trouble's chin to steer their attention back to her. "My love, when I—I am gone… you need—*hunnnn….*"

Gritting teeth against the pain coursing through her body, Yikka's fingers formed into hooks over the mortal injury in her torso. After a brief span, the spasm passed, allowing the dying Yikka the strength to speak one last time.

"*Atreyen,*" she gasped. "*You must be the one to take it!*"

Before Double Trouble could respond, they felt the body in their arms go slack—see the vibrant light of their lover's eyes dim as her jaws parted. Yikka was receding away from them—the reunion between two lost lovers cut short as one became the other's ghost—a bittersweet memory of what could have been but never will be again. Double Trouble was overcome with grief as they wept, drawing gentle fingers over Yikka's lids to close them—no longer wanting to witness the glassy stare of death.

In a mirror of Yikka's parting, the dread light behind Panga started to dwindle—she peered back just in time to see the Ruin Sphere contract into itself, vanishing from sight as the connection to the dread font was severed, ceasing its power. Panga's attention returned to Yikka just as her lifeless body started to fade into a transitional form—the dancing red lights of corruption slowly becoming green as the evil that had haunted Yikka evaporated.

As soon as the torch of life was extinguished, the form that had once been Yikka started to shrivel into itself—Double Trouble clutched at the empty shell, desperate to maintain a hold on

Yikka's body before it withered into nothingness. When they no longer felt anything, Double Trouble withdrew their arms, discovering a black orb floating above their lap—green specks, like fireflies, swirling within its mass.

The Orb of Entropy.

Panga rested her hands on Double Trouble's shoulders. "Atreyen, you must take it. When an Ultimate Power is not anchored, its power will begin to diminish. You must take it before it dissipates completely!" Panga urged.

Still crying, Double Trouble attempted to wipe tears from their eyes.

"Me?" They asked Panga incredulously.

Panga positioned herself to gaze directly into the other's eyes. "Janus would have wanted for you to have it, Atreyen! I can't think of anyone better suited for it! I swear it by the Great Chailendra Tree!" She stated emphatically.

Double Trouble stifled a laugh, still crying. "Well, don't go all sweary on me now, honey." They said.

With a soft exhalation of breath, Double Trouble became their pure entopic state and reached for the Orb, their long fingers wrapping it snugly before drawing it close. As the Ultimate Power made contact, it was immediately drawn within the Imp, the similar magics pulled together by arcane polarities. Double Trouble gasped as they felt the sudden incredible might of an Ultimate Power fill them—the range of their previous abilities expanding exponentially from merely terrestrial—into wholly cosmic. With the merging complete, Double Trouble solidified into their customary appearance as a small, sad smile formed on their lips.

"I just gained an Ultimate Power, and all I had to do was let the love of my life die," Double Trouble said, their gritted teeth forming a dam against the flood threatening to overwhelm them.

"*It's the worst deal ever,*" they finished.

Panga positioned herself behind Double Trouble, gently pulling them back as she wrapped her arms around their chest, using her body as a buffer against their heartbreak. As Double Trouble gave in fully to grief, the feline woman rested her head onto their shoulder, beginning to purr.

"Shhh… it's okay," Panga said, gently rocking them. "It's going to be okay, shhh…"

The two of them stayed like that for a while longer, one basking in the other's comfort as the storm outside began to fade away, becoming a soft trickle—like teardrops.



[*THE GHOST OF YOU (ATREYEN'S LAMENT)*]

THE GHOST OF YOU (YIKKA'S TORMENT)

Chapter End Notes

Illustration by Miledibuja on Tumblr, Instagram, and Twitter.

Author's Note: The title of chapter 8, 'Though Lovers Be Lost, Love Shall Not,' and of this chapter, 'And Death Shall Have No Dominion,' are both lines from a Dylan Thomas poem titled: 'And Death Shall Have No Dominion.'

And death shall have no dominion.
Dead men naked they shall be one
With the man in the wind and the west moon;
When their bones are picked clean and the clean bones gone,
They shall have stars at elbow and foot;
Though they go mad they shall be sane,
Though they sink through the sea they shall rise again;
Though lovers be lost love shall not;
And death shall have no dominion.

And death shall have no dominion.
Under the windings of the sea
They lying long shall not die windily;
Twisting on racks when sinews give way,
Strapped to a wheel, yet they shall not break;
Faith in their hands shall snap in two,
And the unicorn evils run them through;
Split all ends up they shan't crack;
And death shall have no dominion.

And death shall have no dominion.
No more may gulls cry at their ears
Or waves break loud on the seashores;
Where blew a flower may a flower no more
Lift its head to the blows of the rain;
Though they be mad and dead as nails,
Heads of the characters hammer through daisies;

Break in the sun till the sun breaks down,
And death shall have no dominion.

Their New, New Them

Chapter Summary

> In the aftermath of tragedy, Double Trouble finds new meaning to their life.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Held in the palm of their open hand, Double Trouble considered the toy bracelet they had purchased from the marketplace vendor the day they had met Flit. The plastic surface of the beads glinted as the Imp tilted them under the workroom lights—red, orange, yellow, green, blue, indigo, and violet—all the colors of the rainbow.

But it was the dull hue cast by the green bead that caught their attention—Double Trouble tentatively stroked it with a claw tip, rotating the fake gem until they could discern a dark smudge staining its phony glamor. They frowned.

It had been four months since the dramatic showdown with Yikka—four of the hardest months Double Trouble had ever experienced in their long life. In the immediate aftermath of her death, terrible emotions wracked the Imp—guilt over not saving poor Yikka from her terrible fate in the Conversion Center; Double Trouble could have whisked her away from that terrible place and to Etheria. How much better would both of their lives have been if only they had done that?

Double Trouble also blamed themselves for not being able to save their first love from taking her own life. How could someone who always had a witty retort or insightful comment not have the words to sway someone whom they cared for from self-destruction? Better arguments spring forth into their brain, now that it was over, tormenting them like the bitter hail that sometimes falls from Thenlor's skies. How had they failed—letting

Yikka slip through their fingers—lost once again, but this time, never to be returned to them?

The self-recriminations had become a multitude, weighing down the normally indomitable Double Trouble to the point that their own life had started to lose its appeal. During their most grim moments, it seemed the most logical course of action to follow Yikka's example. They still had the Night Sabre—wouldn't it be so nice to use the same instrument their fallen lover had used? Just a flick of the switch and they could join her—wherever she had gone to. It seemed so simple.

Double Trouble rubbed a thumb against the grim marring the surface of the green bead, removing the stain. The Imp then brought the adornment up to their mouth and exhaled—moisture from their breath wetting the bead before they rubbed it against their jacket. Holding the bracelet up to the light one more, Double Trouble was pleased to discover it was now more radiant than its siblings—a fortuitous sign.

"Are you even paying attention to me, Fancy-Pants Lizard?" A voice asked from nearby.

Turning to regard the speaker, the Imp found a rather annoyed Canens regarding them from over a datapad.

"Oh, I'm sorry, my darling—what were you saying?" The Imp said.

After a brief eye roll and rude noise, the muscular woman answered.

"I was saying… Carmen disappeared before I could get to her. So, unfortunately, we now have no way of getting to the funds Janus had accumulated."

Double Trouble gave their friend a reassuring smile.

"Hmm… well, thanks for trying Canens, darling, but let's not give up hope. That Carmen could not have scurried far." They said.

Canens had come to Double Trouble during the midst of their darkest despair with a plan: with Janus gone, why not take over the organization and all of his holdings? They could do whatever they wanted with that kind of influence and power—why let it go to waste?

The Imp didn't have it in them to explain to Canens who Janus actually was or that the Vibrissa had been a sham organization created to manipulate them. But they did perceive the potential in seizing any wealth Yikka had accumulated during the time that the Sable was being sold. Even if it turned out to be all smoke and mirrors, it would, at the very least, give Double Trouble something besides their misery to think about.

The Imp turned to two men seated at the table occupying the workroom in the back of the candy shop, one silver eyebrow raised in expectation. The slighter of the pair had long, luxurious blond hair and was dressed flamboyantly, whereas the other was in more utilitarian garb; a dark blue shirt with matching cargo pants—skull cap fitted snugly to his shaved head.

"Well, Tibernus and Fontus? Are you just going to sit there like part of the décor? Or do you have something to say?" Double Trouble teased.

As it turned out, when the two men had gone to the Numen and disappeared, it wasn't for any malevolent reasons. Carmen was there to greet Tibernus and Fontus when they got to the gothic building, informing the pair that their services were no longer required—even giving them a sum of money as a severance package. The two promptly disappeared into the city's underbowels—busy blowing their newly acquired fortune on frivolities, only to turn back up when all the funds were gone. The fact that no harm had come to their friends had come as most welcome news to Double Trouble, further drawing them up from their emotional nadir.

Tibernus and Fontus shared a glance before chuckling at the Imp's playful attention.

“I’m sure we could think of something,” Fontus said with a smile. “Tibernus here could hack into the bank system and free up your money. Right, honey?”

“It will take some time, but it can be done,” Tibernus said thoughtfully. “Although, that time can be halved if we had some help from *him*,” he finished, aiming a thumb to his left.

Growling, Gmork glowered at Tibernus.

Double Trouble had not turned the defeated mercenary over to the authorities nor thrown him into a garbage chute as they had threatened. Instead, they fitted him with three motorized wheels, two on each side of his torso and the third on a retractable strut in the middle, giving him some locomotion. Instead of getting arms back, Gmork was fitted with various computer jacks and tools that could be extended from various hidden compartments. It was a fitting punishment for the wicked criminal—plus diverting an evil element to the needs of good met the Imp’s chaotic needs.

“Gmork,” Double Trouble said, warning in their voice and in a raised finger. “Be a good dog. Remember that talk we had, honey,”

Gmork glanced at Double Trouble, noticing that their eyes had become two black orbs, glittering with entopic threat. He cast his gaze downward with a whine, ears flat against his skull.

“Yes, Tibernus, I will be glad to help,” the Bounty Hunter said in defeat.

Double Trouble did not entirely like forcing another to do their bidding, but part of them was hoping to ultimately divert Gmork from his path of cruelty. The prospect of this task daunted them more than the one of redirecting Catra from her downward spiral into villainy—but the Imp would not be deterred, for they now had the full might of Entropy on their side. Double Trouble’s drive to use chaos for good had been annealed in the aftermath of Yikka’s suicide—now they were even less likely to give up on any hard

case. When the day came when Gmork was ready to leave the Imp's side, it would be as a changed man.

A small jingle indicated that someone had just entered the candy shop—Double Trouble turned just in time to witness Flit burst into the workroom, Panga not far behind the exuberant girl. Catching the feline woman popping something into her mouth, the Imp grinned, knowing that by the subtle curling of her striped tail, she had just eaten a peppermint. It seemed that by her proximity to Double Trouble and their candy shop, the proud and noble Star Hunter had developed a sweet tooth—another victory for the cause of chaos and Entropy. But the Imp's pleasure did not stem from their small influence on the feline woman—no, it was from her impact on them.

From the moment of Yikka's death, Panga had been by Double Trouble's side—nurturing them during the worst times and helping the Imp process their turbulent emotions during the rare moments of clarity. Double Trouble had no idea what they would not have done without the feline woman's compassion—her's and Flit's—the feline woman bringing the little girl around whenever the Imp was in a state that would not frighten the little girl. The unconditional care the two had shown Double Trouble was the main reason they had come to a decision on the course of their life. The Imp had called everyone to their place for they had an announcement to make.

Upon laying eyes upon Panga's beautiful orange face, the Imp felt a tingle of a sensation within their chest, a tender compassion that was sweet to experience. The emotion was not fully ready to surface, though—it was like a seed buried within ripe dirt, waiting for the last of winter's bite to depart to germinate.

"Hello, Kitten! Hello, Little Mouse. Come in, dears!" They beckoned to Panga and Flit.

Flit bounded over to Canens—the muscular woman picked the little girl up to place her on the table as Panga sided up to Double Trouble. The feline woman gave the Imp a friendly bop with her

hip, making them smile—a friendly greeting and a promise for the future.

"So, Double Trouble, once we have the money we need, what are we going to do? Back to crime?" Canens asked with a smirk.

Double Trouble glanced at Panga—the feline woman was staring at them, eyes hooded and ears lowered.

"Don't even think about it," she said, trying to stifle a grin.

Double Trouble laughed. "No, my dears, that part of me is over. I had come to Thenlor to become the new me, and it didn't really work out." They said, a sad aspect to their face.

"So what? You're going to become the new, new you now?" Fontus asked.

Double Trouble shook their head. "No, honey, I'm just going to be me. Who I always was this whole time." They said softly.

Panga placed a hand on the Imp's shoulder, favoring them with a kind smile. Returning the expression in kind, Double Trouble cast their attention behind her; all the little children they had hired to sell the evil Sable were in their little beds, watching the group intently. The Imp suddenly thought of Janus—how the bearer of the Orb of Entropy had used their power to help Yikka and them, plus countless others. Their new role was more apparent than ever to them.

"I'm going to take these children away from here," Double Trouble said. "These children, plus any others I can find. The lost and the unwanted, the ones who didn't fit in and were abandoned by society."

Panga cocked her head and peered at Double Trouble. "To where?"

A haunted mien crossed Double Trouble's features before a look of utmost beneficence settled upon their lips and eyes.

“To a kind place, to a magical place. I want to take them to Etheria, Panga. I want to go to Etheria—and I want you to help me. Will you and Flit come with me?” They ask, hopefully.

Panga placed herself in front of Double Trouble, running fingers down the edges of the open black jacket, lightly tugging at it as if checking the fit.

“I think I could be persuaded to help,” Panga said, giving them a coy smile. “You know, I think I could get used to having you around,”

Double Trouble beamed back at her, happiness openly showing on their face at her reply. There was no longer any need to hide themselves away from the world—they had come back to themselves. They were home.

“Kitten,” Double Trouble said meaningfully. “You and I are going to do wondrous things together—*wondrous things*!”


HENARTORIN0S'23

Chapter End Notes

Illustration by Henar, a.k.a., ilikeyoucatradora on Tumbler and Instagram

Epilogue: Many Years Later…

Chapter Summary

Approximately 20 years later.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Smiling broadly and openly, they sauntered down the halls of one of Bright Moon's many towers, expressing their joy for all to see. And why not? They were on their way to visit someone—a special someone they had an incredible gift for.

Standing guard at an intersection, two Bright Moon sentries caught sight of them and gawked; their appearance was outlandish, even in a place where the exotic was ubiquitous. Dressed in what had become their customary all-white outfit, they seemed to glow with a radiance that rivaled even that of the Moonstone. Perched on their head was a matching wide-brimmed hat—their long black hair sparkling with entropy as it cascaded down from beneath it. A short white staff was in their hand, topped with a black orb that glittered with the same magic as their hair.

Raising their staff, they tipped their hat at the Bright Moon sentries.

"Wonderful day, darlings," they said brightly in greeting.

The guards looked at each other before facing forward one more, not responding.

Laughing at the guard's seriousness, they continued their journey along the hallway, long green tail swaying back and forth with their movement. They loved being back on Etheria—the sights, the smells, the magic permeating their body and filling them with

potential. They loved that acceptance was so commonplace on Etheria that one there realized just how special their world was.

Well… no one except for themselves and the beings they had rescued from hardship—the refugees of non-conformity they had whisked away and delivered to Etheria's tender bosom.

Coming to a stop at their destination, they leaned in towards a door, straining their long green ears. From within the room, they could make out a creaking noise—as if springs were being compressed repeatedly. They gave the door a neat rap with the end of their cane.

"Come in!" A young voice responded. They smiled and opened the door.

Inside they discovered a Madgēcot child bouncing up and down a large bed; with the exception of the hair and long ears, the youngster was covered in light tan fur. They took note of the blond hair and blue eyes—like the mother's—and of the all-black ears—like the other mother's. The last time they had been on Etheria, the child had just started wearing dresses—but now, the youngster wore a simple white tank top with tight black shorts—a red scarf tied jauntily around their neck. The child's face lit up with joy when they spotted their visitor.

"Auncle, Atreyen!" They shouted, running to their visitor.

"My darling Finn!" Atreyen responded as the child bounded into them, wrapping their arms around their Auncle in an exuberant hug. "My, you've grown since last I saw you!"

Finn grinned up at Atreyen, their furry tail practically wagging in excitement.

"I'm so happy to see you! Did you bring more friends for me to play with?" Finn asked.

Atreyen nodded. "Yes, more children from far, far away."

“How far?” Finn asked, their slitted blue eyes sparkling with curiosity.

“Far. Another reality, in fact—a dark dimension with no magic. They came from a miserable planet called…” Atreyen said while holding their chin in thought. ‘Earth! It was called Earth!”

“Earf?” Finn said questioningly, their upper fangs protruding over their lower lip.

“Close enough, darling,” Atreyen said as they patted Finn on the head. “Where are Catra and Adora? They left you here alone, honey?”

Finn rolled their eyes. “Oh, I’m grounded—but I’m not alone; I have those lame guards outside to keep an eye on me. Mommy and Momma are up on Eternia with Uncle Shen.” They said, pointing up at the ceiling. “They are all at some boring ceremony at Castle Grayskull, inducting another member into The Order.”

Atreyen smiled at the mention of Shen; they had made up with him a long time ago and had given his jacket back to him, for they no longer needed it.

Finn then peeked behind Atreyen as if looking for someone.

“Where’s Aunty Panga and Flit?” Finn asked sorrowfully.

Atreyen tousled Finn’s blond hair. “Aunty Panga is taking your cousin on her first Star Hunter mission, honey. It’s just me here. Am I not good enough?” They said with a teasing pout.

Finn laughed and hugged Atreyen again. “Of course you are, dummy! I just haven’t seen them in a while. I missed all of you.” Finn said sadly.

Atreyen felt their heart swell at this admission, for they loved Finn so very much. Out of all the children they encountered during their journeys, Atreyen had always felt the greatest connection with Adora and Catra’s offspring. Now Atreyen could see that Finn

was behaving just as they had at that age—questioning the gender binary and adopting an outward appearance that skewed male and female. Atreyen knew immediately that they had come at the right time.

“Well, I have something that might cheer you up. I want to give you something someone gave me a long time ago,” Atreyen said mysteriously.

Finn cocked their head. “A long time ago? Like when they used to call you Double Trouble?” Finn asked, confused. “Why did they call you that anyway? The name doesn’t even fit you, Auncle. It's dumb.”

Atreyen laughed at this; they had not gone by Double Trouble in a long time, and Finn’s rejection of that old name was touching.

“No, my dear, wayyyy before that, before I came to Etheria,” Atreyen said, sitting down on the bed and patting on the spot next to them. As Finn hopped up, Atreyen proffered their staff to the child—the green motes swirling into a galaxy within.

“This is the Orb of Entropy, and I am its bearer. It is my ward.” Atreyen said. “I want to give you a fraction of its power—and with it, you will be able to take any form you wish—be who you really want to be. All you have to do, darling, is take it.”

“Wow!” Finn said in amazement, the green lights sparkling in their eyes. “You're going to give me magic? Neat!”

Worry suddenly flashed across Finn’s face. “I don’t know. Maybe I should ask my mommies first.” They said uncertainly.

Atreyen shook their head. “No, Finn, this is your decision. It has nothing to do with your parents. You should make your decision based on what you want and who you are, not what anything thinks, darling,”

Finn took this all in. Their eyes suddenly became firm with resolve, and they nodded to Atreyen.

They had made their decision.


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WAVING GOODBYE

Chapter End Notes

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